SO RUN THAT YOU MAY WIN

Thoughts From the Apostle Paul on the Judgment Seat of Christ

By Rollin E. Wilson, Jr.

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Dedication

"...Faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also,"

2 Tim. 2:2

Many are the "faithful" who have shaped my life and ministry. To the following I dedicate this book. First, to the memory of my father, Rollin E. Wilson, Sr. He it was who introduced me to right division of Scripture. When the waters of Bible truth got too deep for him, he took me to the late John P. Petersen. John became my teacher and mentor.

And lastly, I include my mother, Janice C. Wilson, whose prayers are valued in our running of the race.

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Preface

Recently in a Bible study the host suggested that we should study the Judgment Seat of Christ. My response was affirmative. After all, I thought, this is a fairly simple topic and since it's mentioned directly but twice (Romans 14:10 and 2 Corinthians 5:10) it could readily be studied with a minimum of research.

What I discovered in studying the Judgment Seat of Christ demonstrated that it is one of the more far reaching of Pauline doctrines. I formerly thought this theme could be adequately handled in a few studies or lessons. However a veritable treasure-chest of truth unfolded before my very eyes. This wealth of truth has impressed me by its sheer weight - the number of times Paul refers to it.

These truths have given my life and ministry a dimension that previously was lacking. Daily I find a new consciousness of the "race to run" (1 Cor. 9:24), a "temperance" to apply in all things (I Cor. 9:25), and "subjection of my body" (1 Cor. 9:27) lest I stand before Christ in that day "un-rewardable" (1 Cor. 9:27).

Lest I seem to present here a picture that is too subjective I need to point out that the major portion of the contents of this book has been presented to varied audiences here in Wisconsin. Their response has been positive and affirmative. Numerous hearers have suggested putting these thoughts and teachings into a more permanent form. Thus in God's providence we send forth the book you hold in your hands: "So Run That You May Win."

Since each believer in Christ is nearer to that *finish line* of the Judgment Seat of Christ than when he believed, Paul's words in 2 Timothy 4:6-8 are appropriate:

"For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand. I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing."

Chapter 1

Paul: And The Judgment Seat of Christ

In addressing our title "So Run That You May Win" and its subtitle *Thoughts from Paul on the Judgment Seat of Christ* it is important that we establish the Pauline authority for this subject. Why?

Only Paul mentions the phrase in question: "the Judgment Seat of Christ" which is found in Romans 14:10 and 2 Corinthians 5:10. The principle of *right division* from 2 Timothy 2:15 demands that we carefully maintain the differences and distinctions God has placed in His word as to judgment, rewards, crowns, etc.

As a case in point, many Bible teachers use our Lord's parable(s) in Matthew 25:14-30 in teaching this topic. They teach from 25:19 that when the lord of those servants comes and reckons with them this is the Judgment Seat of Christ. What puzzles me and contradicts Paul's teaching is found in 25:30. Here the *one talent* servant, who, due to slothfulness and unbelief, buried his talent, is judged and stripped of his talent (25:28). But listen to the language in 25:30 "And cast ye the unprofitable servant into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth." This definitely speaks of this servant as unsaved, judged, and banished to eternal punishment. Surely this cannot be the same as Paul's teaching where even in his most extreme case at the Bema of Christ (1 Cor. 3:15), where loss of reward is experienced, that believer "shall be saved; yet so as by fire."

The following lists 108 references from Paul concerning the Bema of Christ in principle.

REFERENCES FROM PAUL (IN PRINCIPLE) TO THE JUDGMENT SEAT OF CHRIST

ROMANS:

1:13 "some *fruit* among you also.."

1:14 "I am *debtor* both to Greeks..Barbarians..wise, and unwise.."

1:16 "For I am not *ashamed.."*

1:32 "Who knowing the judgment of God.." (even unsaved know of accountability)

2:6 God the re-payer

2:7-11 God is impartial, doesn't show favorites

2:12-16 Dispensational principles apply to His judgments..Paul's gospel: the final authority!

3:6 God shall judge the world (universal principle/knowledge; both believers and unsaved know this)

4:4 "reward is not reckoned of grace, but of debt." Justification can never be on the "works-reward" principle, which involves recompense

6:14,15 Grace provides victory over sin - Rewards evidence "victory" and progress which God rewards, thus "Grace" is the over-riding precept re: Reward.

6:16-22 Service to God issues in [fruit] unto *holiness* [now] and the end [now] as well as [forever] EVERLASTING LIFE. 8:12 we are *not* debtors to the flesh - implying debt to the Spirit.

8:12,13 living after flesh/Spirit determines: "dying" and "living," principle here of responsibility on which rewards are based. 8:31,33,34 these verses must refer to "things" believers "do" after salvation; if salvation is not the issue at the Bema of Christ (and it isn't) then nothing a believer does can condemn as to rewards or lack thereof.

11:6 Are not Rewards more closely associated with works, than grace? Yet only that which God rewards must come from grace extended by God to be used in service by believers.

11:35 "who hath first given to him, and it shall be recompensed unto him again?"

11:36 "of..through..to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever.." What God rewards is actually these "all things" outworked in believers' lives.

12:1 Believers moved to "present bodies..living sacrifices" based on 11:35,36.

12:6 Believers are responsible/accountable to God for "giftsgiven."

12:17-21 Believers are not to usurp God's prerogative of Rewarder/Recompenser which will be fulfilled at the Bema

13:2 is this damnation "received" here immediate, only? or also reserved for the Bema?

13:6 "God's ministers," i.e. believers are (here and now) accountable to "render to all their dues" this proves responsibility and accountability finally at the Bema

13:8 Believers are to pay all debts, why? Because God (whose we are) will be no man's debtor

14:4-8 Believers must recognize we each serve the Lord - only the Lord may judge our service for/to Him..this determined at the Bema, 14:10

14:10 One "judgment" is assigned believers, and that by the Lord Himself - believers are not to "set each at nought" only the Lord will do this, and at the Bema.

14:11,12,13 All believers (in the body-church, 12:5) are accountable to God; we should therefore only judge that we cause no one to stumble/fall.

1 CORINTHIANS:

1:8 "Who shall also confirm you unto the end..blameless in the day of our Lord Jesus Christ."

3:8 "every man shall receive his own reward according to his own labour."

3:10 "..another buildeth thereon. But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon."

3:12-15 "work..revealed by fire..fire shall try every man's work..if abide: receive *reward.* If..burned, suffer loss."

4:4 "..he that judgeth me is the Lord.."

4:5 "Judge nothing *before the tirne,* until the Lord come..make manifest the counsels of the hearts..then shall every man have praise of God.."

4:8 "..and I would to God ye did reign.."

5:1-13; specially 5:5 "that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus," i.e. Bema.

9:7 "Who goeth a warfare..at his own charges? who planteth a vineyard, and eateth not of the fruit thereof? who feedeth a flock, and eateth not of the milk of the flock?"

9:8 "Say I (i.e. grace teacher/ing)..as a man? or saith not the law the same also?"

9:9 "..Thou shalt not muzzle the mouth of the ox that treadeth out the corn. Doth God take care for oxen?"

9:10 "..that he that ploweth should plow in hope; thresheth in hope should be partaker of his hope."

9:11 "sown unto you spiritual things..reap your carnal things?"

9:14 "..Lord ordained that they which preach the gospel should live of the gospel."

9:17 "If I do this thing willingly, I have a reward: but if against my will, a dispensation of the gospel is committed unto me.."

9:24-27 "run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize? So run, that ye may obtain"

"but we an incorruptible (crown)"

"I therefore so run..so fight I"

"..lest..I myself should be a castaway (disapproved)" 10:12-13 "standeth..fall..temptation..tempted above that ye are able..make way to escape..bear it"

11:17-34 context of self judgment or judgment by Lord! principle of Bema here.

12:7 "manifestation of the Spirit given to every man to profit withal"

13:1-3 various activities without charity PROFITETH NOTHING (when? now? or at Bema, also?).

15:41,42a "star differeth from another star in glory..So also is the resurrection of the dead.." at the Bema.

15:58 "always abounding in the work of the Lord..labour is not in vain in the Lord.."

2 CORINTHIANS:

1:4-7 Share in sufferings also will in the "consolation" when? now? or Bema?

4:14 "shall present us with you.."

4:17 "light affliction..worketh..a far more exceeding.. weight of glory" (when? now? or Bema?)

5:10 "we must all appear before *the judgment seat of Christ.."* 5:11 "Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men"

9:6 "He which soweth sparingly shall reap also sparingly; (when now or Bema or both?) he which soweth bountifully shall reap also bountifully" (ditto)

9:8-13 God gives that believers may give, thereby glorifying God. 13:5-7 issue of reprobates (adokimos) when? at Bema? cf 1 Cor. 9:27; 2 Tim. 2:15, et al.

13:9 Paul desired Corinthians' perfection - when: now or at Bema?

GALATIANS:

2:2 "lest by any means I..had run, IN VAIN.." (now? or Bema? or both?)

4:11 Paul feared he'd bestowed on the Galatians "labour in vain" 5:2 "if ye be circumcised, Christ shall profit you nothing" (now? at Bema? or both?)

5:4 "Christ is become of no effect unto you..ye are fallen from grace" (now? at Bema? or both?)

5:7 "Ye did run well; who did hinder you that ye should not obey the truth'?" (at the Bema?)

5:10 "shall bear his judgment, whosoever he be.." (now? Bema? or both?).

6:4 "Let every man prove his own work, and then shall he have rejoicing in himself alone, and not in another" - Bema principle 6:7,8 sowing and reaping principle - basic to the Bema

6:9 "not be weary in well doing -due season we shall reap, if we faint not"

EPHESIANS:

2:10 "good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them" as such, rewardable.

6:8 "Knowing that whatsoever good thing any man doeth, the same shall he receive of the Lord, whether he be bond or free." 6:9 "knowing that your Master also is in heaven; neither is there respect of persons with him."

PHILIPPIANS:

1:10 "that ye may be sincere and without offence till the day of Christ" (i.e. the Bema).

1:11 "Being filled with the fruits of righteousness, which are by Jesus Christ, unto the glory and praise of God" - thus rewardable works

1:22 "this is the fruit of my labour"

2:15 "That ye may be blameless and harmless, the sons of God, without rebuke.."

2:16 "that I may rejoice in the *day of Christ,* that I have *not run in vain, neither laboured in vain. "*

3:11 "I might attain unto *the resurrection of the dead."*

3:12 "if that I may apprehend that for which also I am apprehended of Christ Jesus."

3:14 "I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus."

3:18,19 "Whose end is destruction, whose God is their belly." (now? or at Bema? or both'?)

4:17 "Not because I desire a gift: but I desire *fruit* that may abound to *your account."*

COLOSSIANS:

1:29 "Whereunto I also labour, striving according to his working, which worketh in me mightily." (basic principle of rewardable factors in the believer)

2:4,8 "lest any man should *beguile* you..Beware lest any man spoil you through philosophy.." cf 2:18

2:16,17 "Let no man therefore judge you in meat, or in drink..holy day..which are a shadow.." Only at the Bema will true judgment be issued for believers.

2:18,19 "Let no man beguile you of your *reward.."*

3:24 "Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the *reward of the inheritance:* for ye serve the Lord Christ."

3:25 "But he that doeth wrong shall receive for the wrong which he hath done: and there is no respect of persons."

4:1 "Masters, give unto your servants that which is just and equal; knowing that ye also have a Master in heaven.."

4:12 "..always labouring fervently for you in prayers, that ye may stand perfect and complete in all the will of God." (now? or at Bema? or both?)

4:17 "Take heed to the ministry..that thou fulfill it." i.e. accountability.

1 THESSALONIANS:

2:1 "our entrance in unto you, that it was not in vain.."

2:4 "but God, which trieth (dokimazo) our hearts.."

2:19,20 "what is our hope..or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming? For ye are our glory and joy." (at the Bema!)

3:8 "we live, if ye stand fast.."

3:13 "stablish your hearts unblamable in holiness before God, even our Father, at the coming.."

5:23 "your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ."

1 THESSALONIANS:

3:13 "But ye, brethren, be not weary in well doing" (Why? See Gal. 6:9; 1 Cor. 15:58 re: Bema).

1 TIMOTHY:

3:10,13 "And let these also first be proved..being found blameless"

4:8 "but godliness is profitable unto all things, having promise of the life that now is, and of that which is to come."

4:16 "Take heed ...continue in them ...thou shalt both save thyself, and them that hear thee."

5:7 "And these things give in charge, that they may be blameless."

5:18 "...The labourer is worthy of his *reward."*

6:17,18,19 "God..giveth us richly all things to enjoy ...do good.. works ...Laying up in store ...against the time to come..." (at the Bema).

2 TIMOTHY:

1:18 "The Lord grant unto him that he may find mercy of the Lord in *that day."*

2:4 "that he may please him who hath chosen him to be a soldier."

2:5 "man also strive for masteries, yet is he not *crowned,* except he strive lawfully."

2:6 "husbandman that laboureth must be first partaker of the fruits."

2:10 "endure all things for elect's sakes, that they may also obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus with eternal glory." (surely at the Bema)

2:11 "...if we be dead with him, we shall also live with him:"

2:12 "If we suffer, we shall also *reign with him..."*

2:15 "a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth."

2:20,21 "vessels ...some to honour ...some to dishonour ...meet for the master's use ...prepared..."

3:17 "man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works."

4:7,8 "I have fought ...finished ...kept ...Henceforth there is laid up for me *a crown of righteousness* ...the...righteous judge, shall give me *at that day* ...not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing."

4:14 "Lord reward him according to his works (much evil)"

TITUS:

3:14 "that they be not unfruitful" (when: now, Bema, or both?)

PHILEMON:

:15 "perhaps he therefore departed for a season, that thou shouldest receive him for ever." Rewardable at Bema.

:18,19 "If he hath wronged.. oweth..put that on mine account..I will repay..owest unto me even thine own self besides.."

Chapter 2

Non-Pauline Texts Regarding Judgment, Rewards and Crowns

One of the major factors in God's directive to rightly divide the word of truth (2 Tim. 2:15) is the need to recognize differences that God places in His programs in Scripture.

It is patently simple to distinguish between words like: "old" and "new," "male" and "female," "light" and "darkness," et al. There are also important differences and distinctions to be noted between other (apparently generic) words in Scripture such as:

1) "church" in Acts 7:38, and "church" in Eph. 1:22,23.

2) "baptism" in Mk. 1:4, and "baptism" in 1 Cor. 12:13.

3) "salvation" in Rom. 10:10, and "salvation" in Phil. 1:19.

4) "gospel" in Matt. 4:23, and "gospel" in 1 Cor. 15:1.

5) "coming" in Acts 1:11, and "coming" in 1 Thess. 4:15.

The reader can think of other *generic* Bible words to add to the above list. By *generic* is meant words that appear the same but by their (contextual) use show difference and distinction. For example, the word *church* does not always refer to the same "called out assembly" every time it is used in the Bible. Likewise the point can be made with the words: *baptism, salvation, gospel,* and *coming.* The context (especially the dispensational context) in which each word is found will always define and accurately describe it.

If this principle of *right division* is overlooked (or otherwise misused) serious error is produced. See how this is illustrated in 2 Timothy 2:17 and 18. Here wrong division (i.e. saying the resurrection was past) instead of producing truth, resulted in error.

The thesis of this book So *Run that You May Win* deals with Paul and the Judgment Seat of Christ. In Chapter 1, we've submitted 108 references from Paul's letters to the principle of the Bema of Christ. No other Bible writer addresses the Bema of Christ. To Paul alone was given the special revelation of the dispensation of the grace of God, Eph. 3:1,2. As part of this mystery-revelation we learn of Christ's headship over all things to the church which is His body, the fulness of Him that

filleth all in all, Eph. 1:22,23.[1] It is this church that Paul addresses in Romans 12:5 and which is later (14:10) appointed to stand before the Judgment Seat of Christ. Note a parallel usage with the Corinthians in 1 Cor. 12:13,27 and 2 Cor. 5:10.

Here in Chapter 2 we note that there are Bible references outside Paul's letters to the church using certain generic words that Paul also uses. As we rightly divide these uses, studying the context (specially the dispensational context) of each reference, the conclusion will be clear. Therefore, I state again what that conclusion will be: all non-Pauline Bible texts using generic words: *coming/ return, rewards, crowns, judgment,* et al., can not refer to the Judgment Seat of Christ because only Paul writes about the Judgment Seat of Christ. Most of these non-Pauline texts refer to the prophetic Kingdom program of God for national Israel and the Gentiles.

I. CHRIST'S KINGDOM TEACHINGS IN THE GOSPELS

A. Previewed in John the Baptizer's ministry

Matthew calls Christ's teachings: "the gospel of the kingdom," Matt. 4:23. John the Baptizer had preached (Matt. 3:2) before Christ's public ministry: "Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand." National Israel was thus called upon to repent of spurning in unbelief her prophets' ministry of the coming Messiah. John was the greatest of Israel's prophets (Matt. 11:9-13). He introduced Israel's King via his baptism unto repentance, see John 1:31.

As Israel submitted to John's baptism, confessing their sins (Matt. 3:6), observe here: "But when he saw many of the Pharisees and Sadducees come to his baptism, he said unto them, O generation of vipers, who hath warned you to flee from the wrath to come? Bring forth therefore fruits meet for repentance ...And now also the axe is laid unto the root of the trees: therefore every tree which bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down, and cast into the fire," Matt. 3:7-10. Carefully review verses 7-10; and add verses 11 and 12. John warned of "wrath [judgment] to come," in 3:7. He demanded "fruit" (the principle of "seed and harvest") in 3:8. In 3:10 trees that do not bear good fruit are to be hewn down and cast into the fire. This *fire* must be the same as the *wrath to come* in 3:7. Could this refer to the purifying *fire* that Paul writes about in 1 Cor. 3:12-15? Surely not. Using the principle of right division we note the difference here between *fire* in these two passages. John spoke exclusively to those of Jerusalem and all Judea (Matt. 3:5), the Pharisees and Sadducees (Matt. 3:7). Obviously these were all Jews; see also the reference to Abraham our father, in 3:9. Whereas, Paul addresses in 1 Corinthians, Gentiles (12:2) who are called the one body church in 12:13,27. Paul there speaks exclusively to/about believers at the judgment seat of Christ for rewards, 1 Cor. 3:1215. Notice in the most extreme case of loss of rewards Paul's hearers are still saved, 1 Cor.3:15 & 5:5. John the Baptizer spoke, here in Matt. 3:7-10, of coming wrath/judgment upon unbelieving Israel. This parallels Isa. 9:19 and 13:9.

[1] "In his writings alone we find the doctrine, position, walk, and destiny of the church." Scofield Ref. Bible, Edited by C.L. Scofield, D.D., Oxford Univ.Press, New York, N.Y, 1909; p.1252.

John also implied Christ (Matt. 3:11,12) would later baptize the unbelieving in Israel with fire. He uses the metaphor of the threshing process, "burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire." We must keep this in mind as we come to our Lord's further kingdom teachings in his sermons on the Mount (chapters 5,6, & 7), and from Mount Olivet, specially 25:14-30.

B. Christ's Sermon on the Mount

In Matthew 5:12 Christ had just completed His "beatitudes" in Matt. 5:3-11. His hearers are told to "Rejoice, and be exceeding glad; for great is your reward in heaven." Does this sound like Paul's teaching of rewards at the Judgment Seat of Christ in heaven? We must answer, No. Paul teaches that the Bema takes place in heaven immediately after the Rapture, when bodies from heaven (2 Cor 5:1) will have been assigned each believer. There are notable differences between the Lord judging Israel and His evaluating service of believers at the Bema.

Christ's Kingdom teachings are earth focused not heaven focused, Matt. 5:5 and 6:10. God's Kingdom and Will are both be to established here on earth. The "reward in heaven" will find its realization in Christ's earthly Kingdom. All the contextual guide lines verify that this kingdom comes from heaven and is established here on earth, Matt. 5:12. Observe here Christ's parable in Luke 19:11-27. In the parable of Luke 19, Christ taught that a nobleman (our Lord) went into a far country (heaven) to receive for himself a kingdom and to return (to the earth). From this we learn that the Kingdom could not have been established at His first coming. Neither could it be established while He is in the far country. He must return to earth from the far country, heaven, to establish the Kingdom.

Again in Matthew 5, Christ referred to rewards, see verse 46. All we've pointed out above regarding Matt. 5:12 would apply here also. These do not refer to the Bema of Christ as found in Paul's writings.

Rewards are mentioned in Matt. 6:1,2,4,5,6,16 and 18. These are negative rewards from God's perspective as shown in verses 1,2,5 and 16. These rewards are not given by the Father. They result from "the glory and praise of men," as assigned to *hypocrites,* 6:16. Also there are positive rewards: "the Father which seeth in secret himself shall reward thee openly," Matt. 6:4 and 18. Again the Kingdom context here distinguishes these rewards as from the Father, whereas, Paul teaches rewards at the Bema are from Christ, 2 Tim. 4:8.

C. Christ's Olivet Discourse Parable in Matthew 25:14-30

From Matthew 24:3 we believe the extended text of 25:14-30 is part of the so-called Olivet discourse. To set the context, chapters 24 and 25 should be read together. Our Lord, as He exited the Temple, predicted its destruction, in 24:2. The disciples ask him "when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?" Apparently the disciples knew that the Temple's destruction coincided with the eschatological events that would consummate the age. Throughout these two chapters the subject of "the kingdom of heaven" surfaces, see 24:14; 25:1. This phrase is italicized in 25:14, However the KJV translators correctly realized that this was what Christ was teaching.

The Kingdom then was likened to a man (Christ) taking a journey into a far country (heaven). To his servants (all of his subjects) he divided talents; one received five, another received two, and the last received one. Note: "To every man according to his several ability," Matt. 25:15, and observe that this talent distribution was intended to portray all the nobleman's subjects. The remainder of the parable deals with how each servant handled his entrusted talent. The five-talent servant traded and earned five more. The two-talent servant likewise gained two more. However, the one-talent servant hid his lord's money in the earth. Note: he recognized to whom it belonged! After a long time the lord of these servants returned and reckoned with them. The five-talent and two-talent servants receive favorable commendations. Their lord received their original deposits back, along with what they had gained. His words of approval are noteworthy: "..Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: *enter thou into the joy of thy lord,"* Matthew 25:21,23. The word *enter* is significant here. These faithful servants will be allowed entrance into the Kingdom (see Lk. 19:12) which Christ will establish upon His return to earth. The context deals with the Millennial Kingdom Christ will establish when He returns to Jerusalem at the close of the great tribulation. Perhaps the most notable difference here between Paul's teaching of the Bema, and the parable, has to do with the one talent servant.

This servant is called "wicked and slothful," in verse 26. He then is stripped of the one talent and it is given to the ten-talent servant. Then follows Christ's Kingdom teaching explaining this: "For unto every one that hath shall be given, and he [i.e. the faithful ten-talent servant] shall have abundance." The loss of the talent from the wicked, slothful servant becomes his gain. "But from him that hath not [via unbelief, wickedness and slothfulness] shall be taken away even that which he hath," 25:29. Now compare this to Paul's teaching regarding the Bema, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: *and then shall every man have praise of God,* 1 Cor. 4:5. Obviously the italicized phrase here cannot be the same as Matthew 25:26-29. The major distinction here is "And cast ye the unprofitable servant into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth," Matt. 25:30. The "outer darkness" and "weeping and gnashing of teeth" hardly sounds like the Heaven God has assigned to the Body of Christ church, 1 Thess. 4:17, Col. 3:4. Compare Paul's worst case scenario at the Bema in 1 Cor. 3:15. Those losing rewards are still saved - not banished to outer darkness!

This parable in Matthew 25:14-30 is parallel to that found in Luke 19:11-26. Both are often applied to the church today as referring to the Judgment Seat of Christ. Here are classic examples of wrongly dividing the word of God in applying these two passages to the church the Body of Christ.

"All of this is a perfect picture of our relationship to Christ as servant to Master. Like the nobleman, He has gone away to receive a kingdom. He will soon return and immediately we must give an account of what we have done with what He has entrusted to us - the message of the gospel. We will be rewarded proportionately for our service to the Master, as the servants were in the parable. Just as that nobleman gave his faithful servants governing authority over cities in his new kingdom, so too

Jesus Christ will award similar authority to us." [2] Luke 19:11-26 is not "a perfect picture of our relationship to Christ as servant to Master."

The following quote is offered as it directly mis-applies Matthew 25:14-30 to the church today. "[George W.] Dollar teaches that the wicked servant in the parable of the talents in Matthew 25:14-30 is a carnal Christian. `For a thousand years when the Lord reigns and rules over the earth you'll not rule ...But throughout that one thousand years, up there in the outer darkness ...there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth. You don't care now, you will care ...you'll have a thousand years, my friend, and I'm a friend to your soul to warn you...Lazy, unprofitable, wicked servants, you will have one thousand years of remorse...He is going to take the good and faithful servants with Him; they will rule with Him over the earth. But He's going to send all of the wicked, lazy, unprofitable Christians ...to outer darkness for one thousand years and they shall weep and there shall be gnashing of teeth.'" [3]

II. THE CIRCUMCISION LETTERS OF THE NEW TESTAMENT AND REWARDS, CROWNS, ET AL.

A. James 1:12 "Blessed is the man that endureth temptation: for when he is tried, he shall receive the crown of life, which the Lord hath promised to them that love him." Some consider this verse parallel to Paul's testimony in 2 Timothy 4:6-8. There Paul sees a crown of righteousness laid up for him, and for all who "love his appearing." These "crowns" are not identical. Right division shows that they are associated with different hopes and callings. Observe to whom James writes: 1:1 "James, a servant *of* God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, *to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad, greeting. "* This is in contrast to Paul's readers who were predominantly Gentiles, see Eph. 3:1-2. James was associated with the gospel *of* circumcision in Gal. 2:7-9, whereas, Paul was commissioned with the gospel *of* the un-circumcision. James confirmed this circumcision emphasis. See 2:2 where *assembly* is the Greek word *synagogue.* Also consider 1:25; 2:8,9,12 and 4:11, James applied the Law to his readers. "It seems significant that in their epistles neither James, Peter, nor John state that the Law system has been done away." [4]

B. 1 Peter 1:7 "That the trial of your faith, being much more precious than of gold that perisheth, though it be tried with fire, might be found unto praise and honour and glory at the appearing of Jesus Christ."

Peter distinctly opens his letter by informing us to whom it is addressed. He writes "to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia," 1:1. The Greek word here "scattered" means "of the dispersion." In John 7:35 the Jews recognized a dispersed Jewish element among the Gentiles, whom they (erroneously) thought Christ might visit. Peter therefore addresses this Jewish element scattered among the Gentiles. Peter saw (1:10,11) the grace and salvation of his hearers as the subject of Prophecy. Paul on the other hand proclaimed that his

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[2] Woodrow Michael Kroll; Tested By Fire; Loizeaux Bros., Neptune, New Jersey; 1977, p.86.

[3] quoted by Samuel L. Hoyt in Bibliotheca Sacra, Jan. 1980, of George W. Dollar in a taped sermon "Rewards" delivered at Faith Baptist Church; LaCrosse, Wi.

[4] C.F. Baker, Understanding Galatians and the Law; Grace Publications, Grand Rapids, Mi. p.46.

hearers received grace and salvation as part of Mystery truth. This Mystery had not been known to men in previous ages, see Eph. 3:1-5; Rom. 16:25,26; and Col. 1:25-28.

Peter taught rewards for faithful service as being realized at "the appearing of Jesus Christ," (1:7). This appearing is the revelation of Christ as seen in Rev. 19:11-20:4. At that time He will return to Jerusalem to conquer and reign for one thousand years.

The coming of Christ that Paul associates with the Bema of Christ is in heaven and completely distinct from His Revelation appearance to the earth, cf Phil. 3:20,21 and 1 Thess. 5:1-9.

C. II John 1:8 "Look to yourselves, that we lose not those things which we have wrought, but that we receive a full reward."

As one of Christ's chosen twelve apostles, John was selected to reign with Christ on earth during His Kingdom reign over Israel, see Matt. 19:27,28. Paul identified John, Peter, and James, (the Lord's brother) with the gospel of the circumcision, while he and Barnabas ministered the gospel of the un-circumcision, Gal. 2:7-9.

In his second epistle John didn't identify this full reward with any return/appearing of Christ. But it is obvious in view of his sharing the same hope and calling as Peter both had Christ's coming to earth at the end of great tribulation in view, Rev. 19:11-20:4. Therefore, we cannot make 2 John 1:8 refer to the Judgment Seat of Christ in Paul's writings.

D. Revelation 3:11 "Behold, I come quickly: hold that fast which thou hast, that no man take thy crown." This is the message John wrote "to the angel of the church in Philadelphia," Rev. 3:7. In the Revelation John was instructed to write a book and send it to seven (Jewish) assemblies, Rev. 1:11; 22:16. Some suggest that these seven churches maintain only until chapter 4:1. It is further suggested that "this call seems clearly to indicate the fulfillment of 1 Thess. 4:14-17. The word `church' does not again occur in the Revelation till all is fulfilled." [5]

It is evident that John wrote from the vantage of the prophetic time called "the Lord's day," Rev. 1:10. The coming (apokalupsis) that John discussed (I:1) relates to Prophecy and not Mystery, see Rev. 1:3,7; cf. Zech. 12:10. Paul does speak of "crowns" related to the Bema of Christ: Phil. 4:1; 1 Thess. 2:19; and 2 Tim. 4:6-8. However, right division will distinguish between "crowns" at Christ's Revelation coming, e.g. Rev. 3:11, and "crowns" following Christ's Rapture coming, 2 Tim. 4:8.

III. THE GREAT WHITE THRONE JUDGMENT IS NOT THE SAME AS THE JUDGMENT SEAT OF CHRIST

The "great white throne" judgment is fully treated by John in Rev. 20:11-15. Some notable factors here that distinguish it from the Bema of Christ are as follows:

[5] Scofield Ref. Bible, Oxford Univ. Press, New York; 1909; p.1334, footnote #2.

A. The great white throne is called by Christ in John 5:29 "the resurrection of damnation." The resurrection of life takes place one thousand years prior to the great white throne judgment, see Rev.20:4-6.

B. Paul established the principle for this white throne judgment "according to their works" in Rom. 2:6-9, 12-16; and Acts 17:31.

C. The great white throne judgment takes place after the Millennial reign of Christ and after Satan is loosed from the bottomless pit, after the battle of Gog and Magog, and after the devil is banished forever to the lake of fire, Rev. 20:7-11.

D. The great white throne judgment involves only the wicked dead ("what we do know is that `the first resurrection' is specifically called `the resurrection of life;' and that those who have part in it will not be reckoned with `the rest of the dead which lived not again till the thousand years were finished," [6] [Rev. 20:11 cf 20:5]). They will be raised in resurrection bodies to face Christ the Judge, 1 Cor. 15:25,26 and Phil. 2: 10, 11.

E. "There is no coming of Christ associated with the great white throne judgment. His throne is established after the battle of Gog and Magog and the devil is banished to the Lake of Fire. The judgment seat of Christ follows the rapture and is distinguished from the great white throne in time and purpose. 20:11-15.

F. The dead of Rev. 20:12 come from: "the sea, death, and hell," see 20:13; they don't come from heaven. The church will have been raptured (and the Bema finalized) at least 1007 years before this great white throne is set up. Therefore these two judgments cannot be the same.

G. Nowhere in Paul's letters to the Body of Christ church does he recognize a judgment of Christ composed of both believers and unbelievers. Some have supposed that Paul's use of Isa. 45:23 in Phil. 2:10,11 regarding the unbeliever, and in Rom. 14:10,11 regarding the believers at the Bema, proves these two judgments are one and the same. One might just as easily suppose that because Christ is "judge" at both events the two must be the same. This would be tantamount to saying that since Christ is Israel's Messiah-King as well as Head of the church His Body, therefore Israel and the Church are one and the same! Similarities do not prove things to be identical. Things may even be parallel but are not identical. The obvious differences and distinctions between the Bema of Christ and His great white throne demonstrate that these two are just that - separate and distinct. Right division of the Word always produces truth, while on the contrary wrong division creates error.

Right division classifies Paul's writings according to the standard of the Mystery, note Romans 16:25. Mystery truth teaches that Christ's return to Rapture the church to glory (1 Cor. 15:51) will include the redemption of our bodies (Rom. 8:23; 1 Thess. 4:16,17; and Phil. 3:20,21). Immediately thereafter, the church will be summoned before the Judgment Seat of Christ in Heaven, 1 Cor. 4:5; 2 Cor. 5:10.

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[6] E.W.Bullinger,D.D., The Apocalypse or the Day of the Lord, 3rd Ed., Eyre and Spottiswoode, London, 1935, p.642.

Chapter 3

The Precedent:
God The Recompenser

It has been well said, "God will be no man's debtor." Note Paul's words in Romans 11:35,36 "..who hath first given to him, and it shall be recompensed unto him again? For of him, and through him, and to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever. Amen."

No one has ever first given to God. Rather, God has first given to us, 1 Cor. 4:7. To every believer God becomes the recompenser as His *all things* (Rom. 11:36) are returned to Him via thankful hearts and hands. Even though all the believer has is from the hand of the beneficent God; even though all we have received is via His gracious provision; it is only as this enabling grace is utilized in faithful service back to Him that rewards will be forthcoming at the Judgment Seat of Christ.

It is necessary to realize that salvation is *not* the issue at the Bema of Christ. Salvation is clearly God's gift to believing sinners, (Ephesians 2:8 and 9), whereas, rewards are apportioned to the saints for their faithful service Ephesians 2:10, "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them." Salvation is the same for every member of Christ's body-church. However rewards to believers are proportionate to their service (Col. 3:23,24,25; and 1 Cor. 15:41, 42a).

Only Paul mentions the Bema of Christ. In Chapter 2 we noted the Non-Pauline texts that speak of reward, judgment, crowns, and even a coming of Christ associated therewith. But right division of Scripture determines that only Paul's letters refer to the Judgment Seat of Christ before which the church must all appear. Scripture sees a coming of our Lord from heaven to earth (often called the Second Coming or Advent) associated with *prophecy,* (Acts 1:11; 3:20; 15:15,16) involving Israel and the nations (Rev. 1:7). But Christ's coming in the air (1 Thess. 4:13-18, often called the Rapture) to evacuate the church from planet earth to heaven is only found in Paul's writings. This is associated with Mystery teaching, see 1 Cor. 15:51 ff. The Bema of Christ is in conjunction with this Rapture. Again all of these details are found in Paul's letters alone.

In Romans 11:35 the word *recompensed* is the Greek word antapodidomi. Strong's Concordance sees this word combined from: *"anti* - opposite, i.e. instead or because of (rarely in addition to):because, for, in the room of," and *"apodidomi* - to give away, i.e. up, over, back: - deliver (again), give (again), (re-)pay (-ment be made), perform, recompense, render, requite, restore, reward, sell, yield."

Bullinger's Lexicon sees this word thus: "antapodidomi=to give back in stead of something received; to repay, requite." [7] This verb is found twice in Luke 14:14 with reference to Christ's Second Coming to earth and the resurrection of the just. See Rev. 11:18 and 20:4-6, which are to be distinguished from the Bema and Christ's rapture return for the church.

I. GOD'S ATTRIBUTE: POSSESSOR AND OWNER OF ALL THINGS

An interesting detail is afforded in this concept of God the recompenser. It surfaces for us in Genesis 14:19 and 22. Here Abram had returned as conqueror over Chedorlaomer. Sodom's king meets Abram as does the mystic personage Melchizedec. Melehizedec blessed Abram, "And he blessed him, and said, Blessed be Abram of the most high God, *possessor of heaven and earth," (v.19).* Added to El Elyon "the most high God" is the phrase: "possessor of heaven and earth."

When the king of Sodom offers to take "the persons" giving Abram "the goods," hear Abram's response. "...I have lift up mine hand unto the LORD, the most high God, the possessor of heaven and earth" (Gen. 14:22). Recognizing God's possession and ownership of all things Abram refuses "from a thread even to a shoe latchet," that belonged to the king of Sodom.

It is "after these things" (Gen. 15:1) that Abram received the word of the LORD: "Fear not, Abram: I am thy shield, and thy exceeding great reward." If God had told Abram He was his *reward* that would have been good. If He had told him He was his *great reward* that would have been better, but when God said "I am thy *exceeding great reward,"* Abram knew he was singly blessed! Out of God's inherent ownership and possession of heaven and earth Abram learned that God was also his exceeding, great *reward.*

The Hebrew word *reward* here means: "payment of a contract, salary, fare; by impl. compensation, benefit:-hire, price, reward [-ed], wages, worth." [8]

David further demonstrates God's quality of recompenser in 1 Chronicles 29:11-14.

"Thine, O LORD, is the greatness, and the power, and the glory, and the victory, and the majesty: for all that is in the heaven and in the earth is thine; thine is the kingdom, O LORD, and thou art exalted as head above all.

"Both riches and honour come of thee, and thou reignest over all; and in thine hand is power and might; and in thine hand it is to make great, and to give strength unto all.

"Now therefore, our God, we thank thee, and praise thy glorious name.

"But who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able to offer so willingly after this sort? *for all things come of thee, and of thine own have we given thee."*

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[7] Ethelbert W.Bullinger.D.D.; A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek New Testament; The Lamp Press Ltd., London, 8th Ed, 1957; p. 628.
[8] Op.cit., Strong's Concordance.

Israel collaborated with their king David and willingly offered materials in stockpile for the coming construction of Solomon's Temple. "Then the people rejoiced, for that they offered willingly, because with perfect heart they offered willingly to the LORD: and David the king also rejoiced with great joy," 1 Chron. 29:9.

David had to acknowledge Who owned everything and Who deserved the thanksgivings and why, see 1 Chron. 29:11. "Thine, O LORD, is the greatness, and the power, and the glory, and the victory, and the majesty: for all that is in heaven and in the earth is thine..." "...for all things come of thee, and of thine own have we given thee" (1 Chron. 29:14). God is the Creator and therefore the owner and possessor of all things. He gives to His own so they may give back to Him. And being the great recompenser He keeps this cycle going.

Psalm 50:12 records God as saying: "If I were hungry, I would not tell thee: for the world is mine, and the fulness thereof." Paul picked up on this theme in 1 Cor. 10:26 and 28b. By grace, Paul taught that because of God's ownership and possession of all things we may have liberty. Such liberty issues in doing all (i.e. eating and drinking) to the glory of God, 10:31.

To the Corinthians Paul extended this teaching of God's ownership and possession of all things (1 Cor. 8:6). Paul included himself in this verse. He wrote: "...to us there is but one God, the Father, *of whom* are all things.." All things come from God. He owns and possesses all.

II. GOD'S DEMONSTRATION OF ENABLING GRACE

2 Corinthians 8 and 9 deals with Christian giving. This is one area of good works that will result in rewards at the Bema of Christ (Eph. 2:10; 1 Cor. 3:8). How appropriate that we consider God, the recompenser, 2 Cor. 9:8

"And God is able to make all grace abound toward you; that ye, always having all sufficiency in all things, may abound to every good work:"

First we consider: the able-God. The word *able* is the Greek *dunatos.* It means powerful, capable, mighty, or strong. Such is our God! His ability is completely within Himself. His ability is: "to make..abound." The idea is to superabound, to exceed. And note what it is that He makes superabound: grace! We understand that God has always dealt with mankind in grace (Gen. 6:8; Ex. 33:12,16; and John 1:16,17). But *abounding grace* and *God's dispensation of grace* are descriptives only used by Paul to portray God's special dealings with the world and His church today.

I suggest that this: "all grace abounding toward you" is not saving grace as it is in 2 Con 8:9. This abundance of grace here is designed to issue forth in every good work. That is what the Bema of Christ is purposed to detect and thus reward or judge un-rewardable.

Further, observe the result here via the purpose clause: "ye, *always* having all sufficiency in all things.." And all to what end? (That ye) "may abound to every good work." This refers indirectly to the coming Judgment Seat of Christ.

There is a parallel thought in 2 Corinthians 6:1 and 3. Paul endears his hearers by writing, "We then.. *workers* together (jointly as fellow laborers) with him, beseech you also that ye receive not the grace of God in vain." This is not "saving grace" toward unbelievers but God's grace working effectively in believers. Rather, enabling grace of 9:8 is the thought. It produces "every good work." This is Paul's emphasis in 6:3 "Giving no offence in any thing, that the ministry be not blamed."

If the enabling grace of God in service is received in vain (and these carnal Corinthians were examples of this) then the ministry would be blamed. This would surely reflect on Paul and his coworkers of 6:1. Nor would this speak well for them at the coming Bema of Christ!

III. GOD'S ULTIMATE GLORY - HOW?

Returning to our illustration of Abram back in Genesis 15:1, "After these things the word of the LORD came unto Abram in a vision..." It was after "these things" of chapter 14; after Abram's recognition of God as the "El Elyon," "possessor of heaven and earth." It was after the Patriarch had refused the spoils from the king of Sodom (14:23,24). Perhaps God could see that His friend (Isa. 41:8) was feeling impoverished and therefore comforted him: "Fear not, Abram: I am thy shield, and thy exceeding great reward." Keil and Delitzsch comment here: "The divine promise to be a *shield* to him that is to say, a protection against all enemies, and a reward i.e. richly to reward his confidence, his ready obedience.." [9] God made reference to the promised seed, dependent upon God's benevolence being the exceeding, great, reward to Abram. The idea of reward points to the future: "wages," "hire," "fare," even "passage money." Would all this lift Abram's spirits? Abram realized on the strength of God's word to him that regardless of what he had given up for the LORD, God would not be his debtor! !

Observe our text from Romans 11:33-36.

"O the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! how unsearchable are his judgments, and his ways past finding out!

"For who hath known the mind of the Lord? or who hath been his counselor?

"Or who hath first given to him, and it shall be recompensed unto him again?

"For of him, and through him, and to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever. Amen."

Here Paul appealed to the depths of God's wisdom and knowledge. In context and conclusion of this dispensational section (chapters 9, 10 and 11) Paul asked the following questions. "For who hath known the mind of the Lord?" Who could ever instruct, inform or advise Him? "Or who hath been his counsellor?" No human with his created intelligence can counsel God! "Or who hath first given to him..." What could you or I give to God? Strange that Paul should even ask this here, for in 12:1 he begs these Romans to present their bodies "a living sacrifice..unto God." From

[9] Keil & Delitzsch, Commentary on the Old Testament. Wm. B. Eerdman Pub. Co., Grand Rapids, Mi. 5th Ed. 1978; Vol I; p. 210,211.

11:35 it must also then follow: if in 12:1 our bodies have been so offered, then God will "recompense him (us) again." Now come to 2 Cor. 5:10 where we read that the reason we must all appear before the Bema is: "that every one may receive the things done in his *body,* according to what he hath done, whether it be good or bad."

Connected with all this is Romans 11:36, "For of *him,* and *through him,* and to *him,* are all things to whom be glory for ever. Amen." See how the three references to "Him" (i.e. God-the recompenser) are enhanced by three separate prepositions. And definitely this is seen here in Romans 11:36. Follow along in this circle or cycle of God's glory. First, all things start and originate with God, i.e. OF *HIM.* Then, these all things come to us *THROUGH HIM.* Too often we are content to allow these to be finalized with our receiving them. But thus far *the glory* has not been realized God-ward. Only as all that we've received from Him is returned *TO HIM* does glory ensue to His account. This again points to the God Who recompenses. He will be no man's debtor. Therefore, at the Judgment Seat of Christ, God must, according to His own attributes and character (possessor and owner of heaven and earth) recompense the faithful discharge of His enabling grace operative in service through the members of His church.

Chapter 4

The Judgment Seat of Christ, Per Se

It is necessary that the Judgment Seat of Christ be determined "per se." By this is meant: what it is by, of, or itself; i.e. as such, or "intrinsically." Paul uses the expression *the Judgment Seat of Christ* only twice: Romans 14:10 and 2 Corinthians 5:10. We have listed in Chapter I, over one hundred references from Paul that either directly or indirectly address the principle of the Judgment Seat of Christ. We show the following number of references for each of his letters: Romans-25 times; I Corinthians-19 times; 2 Corinthians9 times; Galatians-9 times; Ephesians-3 times; Philippians-10 times; Colossians-9 times; 1 Thessalonians-4 times; 2 Thessalonians-1 time; 1 Timothy-6 times; 2 Timothy-11 times; Titus-1 time; and Philemon-1 time; for a total of 108 references. There are many factors included in the judgment Seat of Christ beyond its name or title. We will consider three intrinsic attributes in the Judgment Seat of Christ. First: It is a special day of reward for the Church, the Body of Christ; second: It is designed to preclude all present (imperfect) judging; and third: It ushers in God's praise and presentation of His Church.

The Word, "Judgement Seat"

"In Ancient Greece, the Bema, was a stage or kind of pulpit, on which speakers stood when addressing an assembly." [10]

"Bema, a step, a raised place. Then a tribune to speak from in a public assembly. In Roman Law courts there were two, for plaintiff and defendant.' Then, the elevated seat of a Judge, (occ. Acts 7:5). The Bema, or Tribunal of Christ, must be distinguished from the throne of His [`the King's'] glory, Matt. 25: and also from the great white Throne of the Father (Rev. 20.)." [11] These distinctions were drawn between the Bema and other Judgments, in Chapter 3.

"Bema, a raised platform in a synagogue from which the Pentateuch and the Prophets were read." [12]

"BEMA, primarily, a step, a pace (akin to baino, to go) as in Acts 7:5, translated `to set foot (his foot) on,' lit., 'foot-room,' was used to denote a raised place or platform, reached by steps, originally that at Athens in the Pnyx Hill, where was the place of assembly; from the platform orations were made. The

[10] Noah Webster. American Dictionary of the English Language, 1828, Foundation for American Christian Education. San Francisco, Ca. 1980.
[11] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek New Testament. The Lamp Press, Ltd.. London, 8th Edition. 1957, p.428.
[12] INFOMEDIA. copy 1996 Softkey Multimedia, Inc.

word became used for a Tribune, two of which were provided in the law courts of Greece, one for the accuser and one for the defendant; it was applied to the tribunal of a Roman magistrate or ruler, Matt. 27:19; John 19:13; Acts 12:21 translated `throne;' 18:12,16,17; 25:6,10,17.

"In two passages the word is used of the Divine Tribunal before which all believers are hereafter to stand. In Rom. 14:10 it is called `The judgment seat of God,' RV. (AV `of Christ'), according to the most authentic mss. The same tribunal is called `the judgment seat of Christ,' 2 Cor. 5:10, to whom the Father has given all judgment, Jn. 5:22,27. At this *Bema* believers are to be made manifest, that each may `receive the things done in (or through) the body,' according to what he has done `whether it be good or bad.' There they will receive rewards for their faithfulness to the Lord. For all that has been contrary in their lives to His will they will suffer loss, I Cor. 3:15. This judgment-seat is to be distinguished from the pre-millennial earthly Throne of Christ, Matt. 25:31, and the post-millennial `Great White Throne,' Rev. 20:11, at which only `the dead' will appear. The judgment-seat of Christ will be a tribunal held `in His Parousia,' i.e., His presence with His saints after His return to receive them to Himself." [13]

While this Greek word "Bema" is found twelve times in the New Testament, only Paul adds to it the words: "of Christ." Thus it is translated "The Judgment Seat of Christ." Therefore, this Bema of Christ is definitely a teaching of Paul.

The Twelve New Testament References to Bema:

1. Matthew 27:19, "When he was set down on *the judgment seat,* his wife sent unto him, saying, Have thou nothing to do with that just man: for I have suffered many things this day in a dream because of him." Pilate, though not a King, was seated as a Roman governor (27:14,15) hearing the charges of the Jews against Christ.

2. John 19:13, "When Pilate therefore heard that saying, he brought Jesus forth, and sat down in *the Judgment seat* in a place that is called the Pavement, but in Hebrew, Gabbatha." This is an identical reference to Matt. 27:19. In both places Pilate "officially" heard the matter because the Jews referenced Christ's claim to be a King in opposition to Caesar. Pilate later ruled these Jewish charges false, yet permitted Christ to be crucified, (John 19:16). Such perversion of judgment with Pilate will not be the case at the Judgment Seat of Christ!

3. Acts 7:5, "And he gave him none inheritance in it, no, not so much as to *set* his foot on: yet he promised that he would give it to him for a possession, and to his seed after him, when as yet he had no child." Strong says of Bema: "from the base of 939; a step, i.e. foot breath; by imp]. a rostrum, i.e. tribunal; - judgment seat, set [foot] on, throne." [14] Thus Abraham had no legal possession of the land that God had promised to him.

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[13] W.E.Vine, M.A.. An Expository Dictionary of New Testament Words, Fleming H. Revell, Old Tappan, N.J., 17th Impression, 1966, p.282-283.

[14] James Strong, S.T.D., LL.D., The Exhaustive Concordance of the Bible, Abingdon-Cokesperry Press, New York, Nashville, 17th Printing, 1947, p.19 #968.

4. Acts 12:21, "And upon a set day Herod, arrayed in royal apparel, sat on his *throne,* and made an oration unto them." The word Bema is here translated by the English word "throne." Such was a judgment seat although not all sitting thereon would be a King.

5. Acts 18:12, "And when Gallio was the deputy of Achaia, the Jews made insurrection with one accord against Paul, and brought him to *the judgment seat."* The word "deputy" refers to a pro-consul, a governor or military commander of an ancient Roman province. This Bema represented authority before which the Jews desired action brought against Paul.

6. Acts 18:16, "And he drave them from the *judgment seat."* Gallio considered the Jews' case against Paul worse than untenable, expelling them from his very seat of jurisdiction.

7. Acts 18:17, "Then all the Greeks took Sosthenes, the chief ruler of the synagogue, and beat him before the *judgment seat.* And Gallio cared for none of these things." Surely this Roman official knew the Jews had no case - and once the Greeks standing by saw this they celebrated by publicly beating Sosthenes, Paul's chief accuser. The use of Bema here does not justify this beating, however.

8. Acts 25:6, "And when he had tarried among them more than ten days, he went down unto Caesarea; and the next day sitting on the *judgment seat* commanded Paul to be brought." Upon this Bema Festus agreed to hear the Jews' charges against Paul at Caesarea. Since Paul had appealed to his Roman citizenship (22:25-30), the Roman Festus must give the Apostle a hearing.

9. Acts 25:10, "Then said Paul, I stand at Caesar's *judgment seat,* where I ought to be judged: to the Jews have I done no wrong, as thou very well knowest." Paul realized that the Bema at Caesarea under Festus' jurisdiction was not going to afford him a fair or just hearing. In fact Festus would even throw Paul to the dogs by suggesting a change of venue back to Jerusalem. Therefore, Paul appeals to the highest Bema on earth at that time: Augustus Caesar, in Rome. Surely Paul was very familiar with this Greek word, Bema.

10. Acts 25:17, "Therefore, when they were come hither, without any delay on the morrow I sat on the *judgment seat,* and commanded the man to be brought forth." These words Festus spoke to King Agrippa as to Paul's recent hearing there at Caesarea. The Bema again refers to Festus' Tribunal there.

11. Romans 14:10, "But why dost thou judge thy brother? or why dost thou set at nought thy brother? for we shall all stand before the *judgment seat* of Christ." Here the Bema is that of Christ. Here Christ sits in judgment. Before Him all the Church will be summoned to give account.

12. 2 Corinthians 5:10, "For we must all appear before the *judgment seat* of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad." This Bema is the same as in Romans 14:10.

This Bema is:

I. A DESIGNATED DAY OF REWARD FOR THE BODY OF CHRIST

As Paul's life drew to the close, he wrote in his second letter to Timothy of "that day" in which "the Lord the righteous judge" would give him "a [lit., "the"] crown," 2 Tim. 4:8. The extended text here gives reasons for this crown or reward. 2 Tim. 4:6-7 "For I am now ready to be offered ["poured out like a drink-offering to God"], and the time of my departure is at hand. I have fought a [lit., "the"] good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith." With sanctified certainty Paul continued, "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness.." and further he includes the members of Christ's Church on down to our day: "and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing," 4:8b.

Anticipating this coming day, Paul considered "the Lord, the righteous judge," 4:8. This is the same One Paul had in mind in Rom. 14:10 and 2 Cor. 5:10. Is there judgment then, under grace? Christ the righteous Judge - is this a grace concept or teaching? Absolutely!

Paul asserted there would be a special crown for those who loved "his appearing." And who would be appearing? "The Lord, the righteous judge." Our Lord Jesus Christ wears many titles for His Church; "now the Lord is that Spirit," 2 Cor. 3:17; "head over all things to the church," Eph. 1:22,23; "Christ-our life," Col. 3:4; "Christ..our hope," 1 Tim. 1:1; "the great God and our Saviour," Tit. 2:13; et al. But referring to the coming Bema, Paul called Him, "the Lord, the righteous judge," 2 Tim. 4:8.

Paul reflected upon his life of service for Christ. He saw himself ready to be offered, poured out as a drink-offering, 2 Tim. 4:6. He had "fought a good fight;" which means he had competed for the prize, or had been a combatant in the public games, 4:7. Next, Paul said he had "finished [his] course;" in other words he had reached the end. He used again the race-course as the figure of speech. Some see here the idea that his career was now over. Next, Paul said: "I have kept the faith." He had "watched over," "taken care of," "kept his eye on," the faith. What might "the faith" be? It must relate to that one, singular faith of which he wrote in Eph. 4:5. This we define as the doctrinal content of that revelation he received from Christ to and for the Church. In Eph. 3:2 he called it "the dispensation of the grace of God." In Rom. 16:25 he called it "the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery." In 2 Tim. 3:10 he called it "my doctrine." It is that special composite of truth for the church which Satan has pluralized ("doctrines of demons) in its counterfeited form, see 1 Tim. 4:1. When anyone turns from "the faith" he faces a multiplicity of "doctrines of demons."

Paul took comfort and joy knowing: "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge shall give me *at that day..."* 4:8. What an encouragement, to know that the Apostle's life of faithful service will be recognized and rewarded at the Bema of Christ.

But there's more. Paul saw that his expectations *at that day* were also available to others, "and not to me only, but unto all *them also* that love his appearing," 4:8. Does this include you, dear reader? If you like Paul, have been saved by grace alone, through faith alone (Eph. 2:8,9), in Christ alone (Rom. 10:9,10), you are now

running the race of service for Christ. This Bema is associated with Christ's appearing. Loving it positively affects and helps produce crowns and rewards.

This text doesn't actually say "the crown of righteousness" will be given at the Bema of Christ. Rather, it is given "at that day." However, in 1 Thess. 2:19 a crown of rejoicing is promised in the presence of our Lord "at his coming." Surely the Bema then, is "that day" of 2 Tim. 4:8, and associated with Christ's Rapture of His church. The word for crown in both cases comes from the Greek word *stephanos.* This was a wreath, circlet or chaplet worn by the victors in the public games in ancient Greece. This is in contrast to the word *diadema,* a crown worn by Kings.

Note here an extended reference from W. E. Vine, "STEPHANOS, primarily, that which surrounds as a wall or crown (from stepho, to encircle), denotes (a) the victor's crown, the symbol of triumph in the games or some such contest; hence by metonymy, a reward or prize; (b) a token of public honor for distinguished service, military prowess, etc., or of nuptial joy, or festal gladness, especially at the parousia of kings. It was woven as a garland of oak, ivy, parsley, myrtle, or olive, or in imitation of these in gold. In some passages the reference to the game is clear, 1 Cor. 9:25; 2 Tim. 4:8 (`crown of righteousness'); it may be so in 1 Pet. 5:4, where the fadeless character of `the crown of glory' is set in contrast to the garlands of earth. In other passages it stands as an emblem of life, joy, reward and glory, Phil. 4:1; l Thess. 2:19; James 1:12 (`crown of life'); Rev. 2:10 (ditto); 3:11; 4:4,10: of triumph, 6:2; 9:7; 12:1; 14:14.

"It is used of the crown of thorns which the soldiers plaited and put on Christ's head, Matt. 27:29; Mk. 15:17; Jn. 19:2,5. At first sight this might be taken as an alternative for *diadema,* a kingly crown (see below), but considering the blasphemous character of that masquerade, and the materials used, obviously *diadema* would be quite unfitting and the only alternative was *stephanos* (see Trench XXXII).

"DIADEMA is never used as *stephanos* is; it is always the symbol of kingly or imperial dignity, and is translated `*diadem'* instead *of* `*crown'* in the RV., of the claims of the Dragon, Rev. 12:3; 13:1; 19:12." [15]

Paul was careful to use *stephanos* only as a reward for the church at the Bema of Christ. In fact *diadema* is not to be found in Paul's letters.

What might the crown of righteousness be? From *2* Tim. 4:8 we note by the definite article that Paul had a specific crown in mind. Could it be that this is the superior crown given for faithfulness in the three areas described in 4:7?

Paul saw other believers (perhaps those he had won to Christ) as his crown, see Phil. 4:1 as well as 1 Thess. 2:19.

H. THE JUDGMENT SEAT OF CHRIST PRECLUDES PRESENT (IMPERFECT) JUDGMENT

This fact is forcefully demonstrated in the contexts of the following verses.

[15] Op.cit., W. E. Vine, p. 258.

A. Romans 14:10

Here Paul asked some hard-hitting questions. Observe Rom. 14:4 "Who art thou that judgest another man's servant?" Apparently only a master may so judge his own servant. Servants were not to judge fellow-servants. Romans 14 deals with "the faith," and in particular strong and weak believers. Our primary focus and direction as servants of the Lord should be to the Lord. Believers are not to sit in judgment of other - weak or strong servants; specially when it comes to non-essentials such as eating herbs or observing days, Rom. 14:17-19.

Consider another question from Paul that immediately introduces the Bema of Christ. In Romans 14:10 he asks: "But why dost thou judge thy brother? or why dost thou set at nought thy brother?..." Here Paul doesn't refer to the one judged as a servant, rather here he is a *brother.* They are one in the family of God. They share common spiritual parentage. Evidently Paul has given sufficient evidence and proof that this judging should stop. To "set at nought" means to treat one, or esteem one, as nothing. In Luke 23:11 this is how Herod and his soldiers treated our Lord. Once a person is esteemed as nothing, mocking or ridicule will follow.

Paul levels the playing field with a bold statement: "for we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ," Rom. 14:10. "All?" Yes, Paul even includes himself. No member of Christ's church is excluded nor exempt from this Bema of Christ.

Paul used Isa. 45:23 in Phil. 2:10,11 to prove that Christ will receive ultimate worship from all creatures to God's glory. His use of Isa. 45:23 in Rom. 14:11 is taken by some to make the Bema the same as the Great White Throne judgment. For reasons why this is not true see Chapter 2, III, The Great White Throne is not the same as the Judgment Seat of Christ. Paul's quotation of Isaiah 45 doesn't mean that the Bema of Christ is thus prophetically fulfilled nor that Isaiah had the Bema in mind when writing. Paul by inspiration understood Isaiah as a parallel truth to what God will accomplish in the Church at the Bema of Christ. If it's parallel it is not identical.

Paul concluded. "So then every one of us shall give account of himself to God," Rom. 14:12. This accounting may involve believers' sins, all of which have been forgiven, see Eph. 1:7; Col. 2:13,14; note also: Chapter 14 Are Un-Rewardable Works Sins? The account to be given here refers to the service faithfully rendered to our Lord. The believer belongs to His Lord, see Rom. 14:8. Therefore, we must give account of our service to Him at the Bema. He will be no man's debtor, Rom. 11:35.

This sober reality leads Paul to conclude: "Let us not *therefore* judge one another any more: but judge this rather, that no man put a stumbling block or an occasion to fall in his brother's way," Rom. 14:13.

B. 1 Corinthians 4:5

In 1 Corinthians four the context of 3:9-15 is continued. Paul continued to deal with the ministry and ministering. And what quality is primary in ministry? What quality is essential in stewards of God's mysteries? Fidelity or faithfulness is that required factor, see 1 Cor. 4:1,2, "Let a man so account of us, as of the ministers of

Christ, and stewards of the mysteries of God. Moreover it is required in stewards, that a man be found faithful."

Apparently Paul was being scrutinized by these Corinthians. See I Cor. 4:3. He is bold to refuse any human judgment regarding his service. Paul was accountable to the Lord alone. Does this attitude produce in Paul self aggrandizement or just the opposite? Grace caused him to live a life of selfless service. For example:

1 Cor. 4:6 Paul desired honest evaluation of himself.

4:7 Paul (as all believers) has nothing but what he received; no boasting permitted.

4:8 Paul hints he was not quite faring as a king, yet!

4:9 As an apostle he sees death a daily possibility.

4:10-13 Paul's humility often is taken advantage of by others.

Why would Paul ask that the Corinthians follow him? 1 Cor. 4:16. Is this the path a faithful steward of the mysteries of God must walk? Did these Corinthians evidence this kind of fidelity in their ministry? And might we apply these verses ourselves today? In the light of Christ's coming Bema, just how faithful have we been?

Let's consider 1 Cor. 4:5, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: and then shall every man have praise of God." Again Paul refers to Christ as "the Lord." Our imperfect judging is not to be used on each other. "The time" is coming when the Lord's perfect Judgment will be experienced in the Church. The bringing to light all hidden things of darkness in believers' lives of service will be a sobering thought to us all. "Manifest" means to make apparent, show forth itself, or manifestly declare. These are areas where only God's discernment operates, Since Christ is light and believers reflect that light this must characterize the rewardable qualities in our service at the Bema of Christ, Eph. 5:8.

C. 2 Corinthians 5:10

Paul wrote about a "groan," see 5:4. He spoke of being "burdened." Surely every believer can identify with these realities of life. Our earthly tabernacle (tent) is at best a body humbled by the Fall.

There are positive factors while we are in this earthen vessel (2 Cor. 4:7). For example:

1) we have a building of God, an house, eternal in the heavens, 5:1

2) we have the earnest ("pledge that secures") of the Holy Spirit now, 5:5

3) we (must) walk by faith, believing God's promises now, and not allowing "sight" to dictate our experience, 5:7.

In light of all of this (2 Cor. 5:1-8) we labor...we expend spiritual energy furnished by grace (Eph. 2:10; and 2 Cor.9:8, et al.). We do this to be approved by Him at the Bema of Christ.

III. THE BEMA OF CHRIST USHERS IN GOD'S PRAISE AND THE PRESENTATION OF HIS CHURCH, 1 Cor. 4:5 and Eph. 5:27

We've seen that this Bema is a future event. It is a reserved event to which every member of Christ's Church will be summoned subsequent to His Rapture return. Immediately after receiving our glorified resurrection bodies every one in the Church will stand before the Judgment Seat of Christ.

"Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, *but we shall all be changed,* In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and *we shall be changed.* For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality," 1 Cor. 15:51-53.

"For our conversation is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Saviour, the Lord Jesus Christ: Who shall *change* our vile body, that it may be fashioned like unto his glorious body, according to the working whereby he is able even to subdue all things unto himself," Phil. 3:20,21. As glorious as it will be to possess and experience our final redemption, that is: our redeemed body, there is still more to come! It is in this changed, glorified state that we will stand at the Bema of Christ. It is after our Lord has brought to light the hidden things of darkness and has made manifest the counsels of our hearts; "then shall every man have praise of God," 1 Cor. 4:5. God's praise will not erase the loss of 3:15. But somehow God's last word here is positive, not negative, l Cor. 4:5, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: *and then shall every man have praise of God."*

One more text for our consideration seems to be identified with this Bema. In Eph. 5:27 we have what we will call "the Presentation," God's presenting of Christ's Church to Himself. "...That he might present it to himself a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that it should be holy and without blemish," Eph. 5:27.

From our two starting texts, Romans 14:10 and 2 Corinthians S:10 we have seen emphasis on individual accountability at this coming Bema. Each of us must run his race and accordingly we'll be rewarded, "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad." 2 Cor. 5:10.

But in the final event, so to speak, as the Church corporately enters its eternal home a grand and glorious presentation will occur. Reflecting the very holiness and glory of Christ our Head, the Church will be presented without spot or wrinkle or any such thing. "That in the ages to come he might shew the exceeding riches of his grace in his kindness toward us through Christ Jesus," Eph. 2:7.

Chapter 5

Are Rewards A Grace Concept?

To properly understand the addressed question, "Are Rewards A Grace Concept?" we must recognize a basic distinction. It must be conceded that the believer's salvation in Christ differs from his resultant service for Christ. The former has nothing to do with reward(s) whereas rewards are for faithful service.

Two apparently conflicting words come to mind. They are Grace and Works. Note here Romans 11:6, "And if by grace, then is it no more of works: otherwise grace is no more grace. But if it be of works, then is it no more grace: otherwise work is no more work." In dealing with Paul's thoughts here it will be helpful to look at the expression "no more." These two words mean: "no longer." Thus in God's dealings in the past, works played a significant part in His program with Israel. The works of the Law could not in themselves save (Rom. 3:20, 28; 9:32; Gal. 2:16) however, while the Law dispensation stood, works were expected to accompany faith, see James 2:21-26. This same James told Paul in Acts 21:20 "..Thou seest, brother, how many thousands of Jews there are which believe [thus, faith]; and they are all zealous of the law," [thus, works]. But the Law and works associated never saved. But Paul is bold to state in Romans 4:13ff that God's promise is by faith not by law - i.e. the seed is not according to the Law. The righteousness of faith is superior to the works concept. And with faith, now, goes grace! Since God's righteousness without the Law has been manifested, Rom. 3:21,22, the faith principle of Christ's credible redemption has released grace. Now, God's true believers are not under a works program. Therefore, salvation is no more of works, but of grace, Rom. 11:6.

In the matter of salvation it is all of God's grace - no human merit, energy, effort or work has any part. Paul clearly stated that salvation is "not of works," Eph. 2:8; and Titus 3:5.

How then are rewards which believers work for, considered a grace concept? We must realize that once saving grace has entered the believing sinner it then becomes the motivating and energizing factor in his new life. This extra dimension of grace is what Paul teaches to prepare us for the coming Judgment Seat of Christ.

To this matter of "rewards" Zane Hodges wrote "..because this doctrine seems to suggest `merit' instead of `grace'.. They argue that the doctrine of meritorious works is a contradiction to the truth that we are not under the Law but under grace (Rom. 6:14)." [16]

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[16] Zane Hodges, Doctrine of Rewards Part I, Rewards and Grace, in the Grace Evangelical Society News, Sept-Oct., 1944.

Are rewardable works and grace compatible? Paul apparently thought so. Perhaps one of the reasons why the doctrine of the Judgment Seat of Christ has been poorly understood comes from confusion over rewards for works produced by God's grace. Regardless of our present day confusion, misunderstanding, or questions here, Paul alone had the answers. Only Paul wrote about this Bema of Christ. In this Chapter we'll see Paul's statements about the Bema of Christ, his personal example therein, and his extended teaching about the Bema of Christ.

I. PAUL'S STATEMENT OF FACT:

A. God's Grace and Salvation

Grace is the major factor in God's dealings with man today. Much is made of the love of God from verses like John 3:16. I recall in my early experience as a believer that John 3:16 was taught to me as the quintessence of God's dealings with the world and His church. Truly the love of God is a prime factor in Christ's redemptive work. Even Paul demonstrates this, see Rom. 5:8; 2 Cor. 5:14; Gal. 2:20; Eph. 1:4; 5:25, et al.

However, when God named this present administration as committed to Paul for Gentiles (Eph. 3:2) it was not called the "dispensation of love." It was called "the dispensation of the grace of God." In a very real and special sense today, grace is King, "That as sin hath reigned unto death, even so might *grace reign* through righteousness unto eternal life by Jesus Christ our Lord," Rom. 5:21.

Grace is shown to be the bringer of salvation: "For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men," Titus 2:11. In the immediate context of Titus 2, we'll note (in 2:10) a reference to the Saviour-God. A similar reference is made in Titus 1:3 to the "Saviour-God." Again the same may be seen in 2:13. Clearly the Saviour-God is identified with His grace that brings salvation.

B. God's Grace in Good Works

Some of the most familiar and most used verses dealing with the saving grace of God would be Eph. 2:8 and 9, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast." Certainly these are Pauline facts relating to what we could call today: "saving grace."

There is an additional principle which is not so widely recognized. It is that saving grace issues in and produces good works! Note: Tit. 2:14, "Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of *good works."* We had used Tit. 2:11 (in context here) to establish Paul's teaching about saving grace. Now the extended text shows how such grace produces good works. Couldn't we thus determine that these good works as then practiced by believers are the rewardable qualities for which the believer will be rewarded at the Judgment Seat of Christ? In similar fashion we'll return to our Eph. 2:8 and 9 context. Here in 2:10 he wrote: "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus *unto good works,* which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them." As with Tit. 2:14, so here in Eph. 2:10,

these good works are the rewardable qualities with which God the recompenser will deal at the Bema of Christ.

C. God's Grace Teaches Believers How To Live

Now in Tit. 2:12 God's grace "teaches us [how]..we should live-" We are not directed back to the Law - to teach us how to live. No! The Law could not save. It can not keep one saved nor can it instruct believers how to live "soberly, righteously, and godly.." Grace becomes the dominant force today for godliness. And we are bold to say, grace is that necessary ingredient in the believer's life of service that will usher in rewards at the Bema of Christ.

Paul shows this quality of grace in Rom. 5:17. Note some of his words of emphasis and description: "For if by one man's offence death reigned by one; *much more* they which receive abun*dance* of grace and the gift of righteousness shall reign in life by one, Jesus Christ." Look at these words again: *"much more,"* and *"abundance"* (of grace). This is enabling grace. This is enhancing grace, grace that puts the believer on the throne in life, as it were.

Paul has moved us beyond saving grace which super abounded over sin and death, Rom. 5:20. Yes, we are moved to the "much more..abundance of grace" which is King (Rom. 5:21); and this grace makes the believer to be King, i.e. "reign in life by one, Jesus Christ," Rom. 5:17.

II. PAUL'S PERSONAL EXAMPLE OF ENABLING GRACE TO SERVE

A. Grace Is True Strength

One of the practical results of God's grace is the impartation of strength. Paul learned his true weakness through his thorn in the flesh, 2 Cor. 12:7-10. God taught Paul a special lesson of grace..with His grace, see 12:9. In this verse God emphasizes the word *grace.* First He says: *"My grace* is sufficient for thee." Then (carefully note this) God says: "for *my strength* is made perfect in weakness." What a concept! God's *grace* is also God's *strength!* Little wonder Paul wrote to Timothy, "Thou therefore, my son, *be strong in the grace* that is in Christ Jesus," 2 Tim. 2:1.

It was also to Timothy that Paul wrote of "the glorious gospel of the blessed God, which was committed to my trust," 1 Tim. 1:11. The word *committed* in the Greek is the verb "to believe," pisteuo. Here the element *of* commitment is evident as God entrusted to the Apostle of the Gentiles the very good news *of* Christ's glory. Then in 1:12 Paul, having been entrusted with this gospel/ministry, gives thanks to God. He thanks God "who hath enabled me." The word *enabled* is endunamoo, which means: "to strengthen in, i.e., to render strong, to impart strength to." [17] Here Paul calls this gospel committed to him, "the ministry." Along with this see how Paul handled it in 1 Cor. 9:16-18, "For though I preach the gospel, I have nothing to glory of: for necessity is laid upon me; yea, woe is unto me, if I preach not the gospel! For if I do this thing willingly, I have a reward: but if against my will, a dispensation of the gospel is committed unto me. What is my reward then?

[17] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth edition, 1957, p. 248.

Verily that, when I preach the gospel, I may make the gospel of Christ without charge, that I abuse not my power in the gospel." Paul associates his ministry with required willingness. Such ministry committed (Greek, pisteuo, in 9:17) to him, willingly discharged, issued in a reward at the Bema of Christ.

B. Grace Not Received In Vain

Paul gave us more of his personal experience of enabling grace in his ministry which would produce reward(s). Observe here, "But by the grace of God I am what I am: and his grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain; but I laboured more abundantly than they all: yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me," 1 Cor. 15:10.

This verse illustrates two aspects of grace. First, saving grace and second, enabling grace. When Paul said, "But by the grace of God I am what I am," he meant what the saving grace of God had done for him and made of him. Remember how the comic strip character "Pop-eye" used to dramatize his spinach-induced strength. After eating his can of spinach he would flex his biceps and say "I am's what I am!" However, Paul said "I am what I am..by the grace of God." God's saving grace not only converted Saul of Tarsus but also transformed him into a trophy of that grace. Further, Paul wrote, "and his grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain..." In what sense can the saving grace of God be bestowed "in vain?" One is either saved by grace or he isn't. From 2 Cor. 6:1-3, a comparable text, more light will be shed. These Corinthians were called "fellow workers," in 6:1. This indicates that they were believers and thus were to be active Ambassadors (5:20). They were asked not to receive the grace of God in vain. If we move directly to verse 3, the significance of what kind of grace may be received in vain is clearly associated with "the ministry." Therefore, "grace received in vain" has to do with God's enablement in service.

C. Grace Produces More Abundant Labor

Returning to Paul's example in 1 Cor. 15:10, he boldly asserted that God's grace upon him was not in vain. How does he prove this? Listen to his statement of proof, "but *I laboured more abundantly* than they all..." Does Paul mean that he never got out from under that legal performance system of the Law? Are we to believe that the Apostle here was motivated by a competitive spirit with the Twelve? Paul will answer for himself! He assures us that the enabling grace of God in service motivated and caused him to "labour more abundantly" than the Twelve Apostles. Here are his own words: "yet not I, but *the grace of God which was with me."*

To demonstrate the kind of work Paul performed let's look at the word here in the original. It is *kopiao,* and means: "to be beat out, i.e. be weary, faint, then, to weary one's self as with labour, to toil." [18] Paul used this word in 1 Cor. 4:12: "And *labour,* working with our hands..." Would such "labor" come of/from grace? Might Paul be exhibiting in his own personal life this magnificent quality of enabling grace which God makes available to us today? Here then God has portrayed in the life of

[18] Ibid, p. 438.

His chosen Apostle, what enabling grace can produce that is, good works. Would such labor and good works be rewardable at the Bema of Christ? What Paul preached and taught about grace, he also lived and practiced!

III. PAUL'S FURTHER GRACE TEACHING ABOUT REWARDS

A. Besought As Workers Together

Grace might be likened to an exquisitely faceted diamond. Each slight movement of this gem reflects the brilliance of the light from another angle. One facet may be saving grace, another might be educating grace, still another would be grace to serve. Paul brought this subject of grace to the work force in 2 Cor. 6:1ff. He saw the Corinthians, as his co-workers. There is our individual, personal accountability to the Lord when we think of the Judgment Seat of Christ. But there is also a corporate, united, joint-service in which we participate. In Paul's words this necessitates not receiving the grace of God in vain. Therefore, only grace will enable us to function as workers together. Only grace worked out will keep the "ministry from being blamed," 2 Cor. 6:3.

B. God...Makes All Grace Abound

Paul brought the subject of grace in service into full view in 2 Cor. 9:8. The context of 2 Corinthians 8 and 9 deals with giving. This is an obvious area of good works that will be rewardable at the Bema of Christ! The very magnificence of God Himself is seen in this precious jewel called His grace: "And God is able to make all grace abound toward you; that ye, always having all sufficiency in all things, may abound to every good work," 2 Cor. 9:8. What a treasure chest full of value and worth is contained in this verse! We observe a few of these riches here:

1. All this is attributed to "the able-God," this is God's doing. During previous dispensations God has always shown grace, "Noah found grace…" Gen. 6:8; Moses, "...and thou hast also found grace in my sight." Ex. 33:12; and even Christ's earthly ministry, "And of his fulness have we all received, and grace for grace. For the Law was given by Moses, but grace and truth came by Jesus Christ," John 1:16,17. Yet there is only one dispensation of grace, Eph. 3:2 wherein Paul characterized grace as abounding, yes, super-abounding, "...Where sin abounded, grace did much more abound," Rom. 5:20; "...that the abundant grace might..redound," 2 Cor. 4:15; "...all grace abound toward you," 2 Cor. 9:8; "...And the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant," 1 Tim. 1:14.

2. "...All grace abound toward you" - what resources await our claiming. Such wealth and strength stands available to us today. Often we live and serve as if impoverished and using only our own resources and abilities.

3. "...Ye, always having all sufficiency in all things..." Could ever such words exist apart from "all grace abounding??"

4. All these are factored, to the end: "..that ye..may abound to *every good work."*

There it is again! All grace abounding and available always to every believer to the end that good works are produced. Question: "Are Rewards A Grace Concept?" Paul answers this with a resounding, "Yes!"

C. "...Be Strong In The Grace That Is In Christ Jesus..."

One more text is here presented as representative of Paul's grace teaching, that rewards are a grace concept. "Thou therefore, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus," 2 Tim. 2:1 . What might this "therefore" mean? In the foregoing context (1:16-18) the Apostle recited the faithful ministry of Onesiphorus toward himself. Onesiphorus oft *refreshed* Paul. The idea here of *refreshed* means "to draw a breath again; to revive by fresh air." [19] Paul was greatly strengthened and impressed with the fidelity of Onesiphorus. Paul so commended him that he even suggested that God will recognize it "in that day." What other day could Paul have in mind here, but the Bema of Christ!

Paul accentuated this thought to Timothy by using the word "therefore" in 2:1. When thinking of this Bema of Christ Paul always instructed the believer to be strong in grace. Why? Because grace is the underlying empowerment and motivation provided by God by which we are to serve Him. If Onesiphorus will be rewarded at the Bema of Christ (and he will) just so also will Timothy need to be strong in that same grace that is in Christ Jesus. The same must surely apply to believers today.

See how this is further developed, "And the things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also.

"Thou therefore endure hardness, as a good soldier of Jesus Christ.

"No man that warreth entangleth himself with the affairs of this life; that he may please him who hath chosen him to be a soldier.

"And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully," 2 Tim. 2:2-5. The figures of the Teacher, Soldier, Athlete and Farmer equally identify with strong grace operating in believers. Such fidelity expected and evidenced will be rewarded at Christ's Bema.

These teachings of grace are not hidden nor secreted away from us. Paul's church letters abound with the grace concept. This is the fundamental basis for our rewards at the soon coming Bema of Christ.

"Are Rewards A Grace Concept?" If the reader has come thus far and is yet hesitant to give a confident, affirmative answer may we suggest Chapter Five be re-read. Also the cumulative weight of grace teaching to come should eventually evoke that positive response asked of the above question.

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[19] Ibid, p. 631.

Chapter 6

Loss Of Rewards:
How? And Why?

Every contest comes with its own set of rules. Specially is this true in athletic contests. Each athlete is made aware of the rules as part of his training and discipline. The rules are administered by referees, umpires, and judges.

Paul clearly informed Timothy (and by extension the Church) just how important rules are in our contest. "And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully" 2 Tim. 2:5. This verse contains some special words:

1) "strive for masteries" = Greek "athleo, to contend, contend for mastery in the public games." [20] Our English word "athlete" means: "one who contends for a prize," and comes directly from this Greek word.

2) "crowned" = Greek stephanoo, "to put round, hence, to crown." [21]Paul associates this crown with the Judgment Seat of Christ. See I Cor. 9:25; Phil. 4:1; 1 Thess. 2:19; and 2 Tim. 4:8.

3) "strive" - same as #1 above.

4) "lawfully" = Greek, nominos "lawfully, according to law and custom." [22]

The point is clearly made: if the athlete does not compete according to the rules he will not receive the prize. The crown is not forthcoming if the law of the games is violated.

I. THE BEMA OF CHRIST BRINGS LIGHT - 1 COR. 4:5

Paul wrote, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: and then shall every man have praise of God," 1 Con 4:5. Obviously, the subject here is the Bema of Christ. When He comes He will bring to light the hidden things of darkness. He will openly reveal the counsels of the heart. Then will each believer possess his redeemed body of glory. Then will we applaud such manifesting of the counsels of our hearts.

J. N. Darby has an interesting comment here regarding "light" and the Judgment Seat of Christ,

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[20] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth edition, 1957, p. 744.
[21] Ibid, 195.
[22] Ibid, p.444.

"..for if we have really understood grace, if we are standing in grace, if we know what God is, all love for us, all light for us, we shall like to be in the full light. It is a burden, and encumbrance, to have anything concealed. Without the knowledge of grace we fear the light: it cannot be otherwise. But knowing grace, knowing that sin has been put away as regards the glory of God, and that the offence is no longer before his eyes, we like to be in the light." [23]

A. Hidden Things Of Darkness Brought To Light At The Bema Of Christ

"God is light," as stated in 1 John 1:5. This is the realm where God's essence stands alone. He is the absolute standard to which everything is subject. Absolute reality is found in God alone. The Bema of Christ is set in the quality and essence of God Himself, Light. The hidden things of darkness must be seen for what they have been and really are. These *things* will be judged by the Lord at that day. These *things* have been secreted away from all eyes but His. These *things* must come forth. We, having been identified as "light in the Lord," Eph. 5:8, will concur as the Lord openly shows what part darkness has had in our service for Him.

We who now believe were once characterized as darkness, "For ye were sometimes darkness," Eph. 5:8a. That changed with the light of the gospel of Christ's glory shining into our hearts, "In whom the god of this world hath blinded the minds of them which believe not, lest the light of the glorious gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine unto them.

"For we preach not ourselves, but Christ Jesus the Lord; and ourselves your servants for Jesus' sake.

"For God, who commanded the light to shine out of darkness, hath shined in our hearts, to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ," 2 Cor. 4:4-6. Being now "light in the Lord," we produce fruit of the Spirit, Eph. 5:8 & 9, as a by product of Light. Notice further in Eph. 5:9-13, this fruit issues in "truth" and "proves what is acceptable unto the Lord." Here is more evidence of passing the test ("proving" = Greek, dokimazo) which addresses the coming Bema of Christ. In addition we've learned to disfellowship the unfruitful works of darkness by even reproving them, Eph. 5:11 Thus, the Lord in Light at the Bema will apply this principle perfectly. This light will shine into every nook and cranny of our service for Him. Now to understand what's coming cannot help but make us more conscious that we are building upon the foundation Paul has laid, see I Cor. 3:10. By the way, this foundation on which we are building is part of the larger context of First Corinthians four. Not every piece of building material fitted into the structure is evident to the human eye. But it surely is apparent to the Lord of Light, and at His Bema all flawed workmanship will be shown for what it is.

Surely these *things of darkness* cannot, will not, be rewarded. They must be placed in the loss column at the Bema of Christ. These are characterized as "hidden things of darkness." They do not invalidate other "gold, silver, precious stones," or rewardable works. They represent the un-rewardable parts of our service which will

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[23] J. N. Darby, Synopsis of the Books of The Bible, Stow Hill Bible and Tract Depot, London, 1949, Vol. IV, p. 229.

be judged "loss," "If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire," 1 Cor. 3:15.

What are these *things of darkness?* In Phil. 1:15-17 less than sincere motives were involved even though Christ was preached, "Some indeed preach Christ even of envy and strife; and some also of good will:

"The one preach Christ of contention, not sincerely, supposing to add affliction to my bonds:

"But the other of love, knowing that I am set for the defence of the gospel." Here self seeking and insincerity overshadowed the good work of preaching Christ. Would such service be rewarded when done with impure motives'? Will they not suffer loss for such *"things of darkness?"* Paul refuses to allow these negative motives in his life and thus he exhibits a rewardable quality, "What then? notwithstanding, every way, whether in pretence, (i.e. "things of darkness") or in truth, Christ is preached; and I therein do rejoice, yea, and will rejoice," Phil. 1:18.

Let's look at other such *"things of darkness."* This time the Corinthians offer material for our learning. 2 Cor. 6:11-13 addresses these believers' narrowness and even twisted attitudes: "O ye Corinthians, our mouth is open unto you, our heart is enlarged. Ye are not straightened (i.e. `cramped') in us, but ye are straightened in your own bowels. Now for a recompense in the same, (I speak as unto my children,) be ye also enlarged." Here the Corinthians exhibited a cramped, narrow, (small) heart. They didn't experience such stricture in Paul's heart, but just the opposite. Will not such littleness of heart be brought forth at the Bema as un-rewardable and therefore be loss? We learn what then will be rewardable; even this very "enlargement" to which Paul directed them, "(I speak as unto my children,) be ye also enlarged," 1 Cor. 6:13b.

Compare Paul's words, "But this I say, He which soweth sparingly shall reap also sparingly..." 2 Cor. 9:6. Might this not apply to some *"things of darkness"* that the Light will bring forth at the Bema of Christ? Who but the Lord knows what we could (or should) have sown? Who but the Lord makes the comparison of our investments in time over against eternity? Surely to sow sparingly ("stingily") now is to suffer loss of reward at the Bema of Christ. Do we learn to be stingy in giving, from God? Surely we don't learn it from Him, "And God is able to make all grace abound toward you; that ye, always having all sufficiency in all things, may abound to every good work," 2 Cor. 9:8!

B. The Making Manifest Of The Counsels Of The Hearts

Eph. 5:13 tells us: "whatsoever doth make *manifest* (same word used in 1 Cor. 4:5) is light." And that which is made manifest (lit. "make apparent; make openly known") will be "the counsels of our hearts." The word counsels means; "will, determination, propensity; purpose, design, plan; counsel, advice." [24] From the innermost part of us, God will bring to light what has been the motivation behind our service. All our attitudes and motives will be openly determined by the Lord the righteous Judge.

[24] Op.cit. Bullinger, p. 89.

The Rapture return of Christ is described by the original Greek word: phaino: "to make light, shine, throw light upon." This clearly identifies with the word in 1 Cor. 4:5 "make manifest." In Col. 3:4 it's shown by the English word *appear,* "When Christ, who is our life, shall *appear,* then shall ye also *appear* with him in glory." Since the Church is identified with Christ and He will clearly shine forth, so must we also be made openly to shine forth. The Bema of Christ is the immediate result of this *appearing* of Christ and His Church. Paul assured our appointment, "For we must all appear [lit: "be made to shine forth"] before the judgment seat of Christ," 2 Cor. 5:10. He continues, "Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men; but we *are made manifest [i.e.* even now] unto God; and I trust also are *made manifest* in your consciences," 2 Cor. 5:11.

C. From Such Resultant Light Comes Praise Of God

Paul concludes, "..and then shall every man have praise of God," 1 Cor. 4:5. Remember the Judge is the Lord. He has determined a set "time" to "bring to light" and "make manifest" these things. When the Bema of Christ, has been accomplished, the praise of God will be the portion of His Church.

It must be admitted that this "praise" cannot be intended to invalidate the "loss suffered" of l Cor. 3:17.

Therefore, whatever our understanding of loss of reward may be, certain other texts must be equally considered. For example, note the coming presentation as taught in Eph. 5:26,27: "That he might sanctify and cleanse it with the washing of water by the word, That he *might present it to himself* a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that it should be holy and without blemish." Will this presentation of the Church take place before or after the Bema of Christ? Might this presentation be the very Bema of Christ itself'? Apparently our individual loss(es) of rewards will not change the corporate glory of the Church at this presentation. Thus, when the Lord's evaluation of our service is complete "then shall every man have praise of God," 1 Cor. 4:5.

II. THE BEMA OF CHRIST MANIFESTS EVERY MAN'S WORK BY FIRE

This point is made from 1 Cor. 3:6-15.

A. The Context Of Labor And Work

"For we are labourers together with God: ye are God's husbandry, ye are God's building.

"According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, I have laid the foundation, and another buildeth thereon. But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon.

"For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ," 1 Cor. 3:9-11.

In verse 9, Paul emphasized God's activity. God is at work. Paul and Apollos were planting and watering, 3:6-9, but God gave the increase. "God's husbandry" is related to the Church. This organic produce as "God's husbandry" gives evidence

of human accountability at the Bema of Christ, "and every man shall receive his own reward according to his own labour," 1 Cor. 3:8b.

Paul singled out his special ministry by the term "wise masterbuilder." The Church is also called: "God's building," l Cor. 3:9. The word building is oikodome, "the act of building a house, building, edifice; thus metaph: edification, spiritual profit, or advancement." [25] Paul attributes his being a "wise-architect" to God's grace given unto him; grace not bestowed in vain; grace which produced the foundation. Once Paul's basic ministry here was set, other builders were cautioned as to how they should build thereon. This "building thereon" is similar to "every man receiv[ing] his own reward according to his own labour," 3:8. How important are the materials we use! What materials are worthy or valid to build upon Christ as the central cornerstone of the Church?

B. Paul's Foundation - And Our Building Thereon

In Rom. 16:25 Paul calls his ministry "the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery, which was kept secret since the world began." From Eph. 2:20 Paul described Jesus Christ as "the chief cornerstone," being the foundation of the apostles and prophets. He saw "all the building fitly framed together groweth unto an holy temple in the Lord: In whom ye also are builded together for an habitation of God through the Spirit," Eph. 2:21-22.

Each believer is warned to "take heed how he buildeth thereupon...for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is," 1 Cor. 3: 10b,13. Six building materials were named: gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay and stubble. The first three: gold, silver, precious stones, have intrinsic worth and value. These illustrate proper building materials built upon Paul's foundation. These represent works that will survive the fire and therefore be rewardable.

The latter three: wood, hay, and stubble, are highly combustible and will not survive the fire and therefore are not rewardable.

From the human standpoint which of these two groups contain the most popular building materials? Which material is the most readily available and the easiest to obtain? Which is the least expensive? Yet, with all these qualities the only true test must be: will they abide the fire? One ounce of "gold" or "silver," or "precious stone," built on Paul's foundation is more to be desired than an entire sub-division of a hundred log houses. One might try to argue for the utility of wood. Most of us live in basic wooden homes. But the supreme test of this building project is that spiritual discernment of God Himself described here as "fire."

Remember Jeremiah's words, "Is not my word like a fire? saith the LORD" Jer. 23:29.

C. God's Nature Of Discernment

God's very nature is that of discernment. Being Truth, God will always determine thereby what is the lie, the false, and the error. Such discernment on

[25] Op.cit. Bullinger, p. 120

God's part is considered His judgment. Since Paul uses the metaphor here of construction/building and the six useable materials, it is fitting that the test these should face will be fire. Carefully note (again) it is not the believer himself, who is tested by this fire. It is rather: "every man's *works*" which shall be made manifest. Even if all of the believer's works are un-rewardable (thus "burned, he shall suffer loss") yet he himself shall be saved. "The effect, the fruit of labour would be destroyed - the man who had wrought be saved, because he had built on the foundation - had true faith in Christ..He should be saved as through the fire.." [26]

What is this loss to be suffered at the Bema of Christ? Remember believers will not be punished for their sins. All such have been freely forgiven by Christ's redemptive work by grace, see Rom. 3:24-26; Eph. 1:7; and Col. 2:13.

The words "suffer loss" (in 1 Cor. 3:15) mean: "[verb], to bring loss upon anyone; to receive detriment." [27] Paul used this verb in Phil. 3:8 where he suffered the loss of those things which once he counted gain. The noun form is used in Acts 27:10. Here Paul says: "Sirs, I perceive that this voyage will be with hurt and much damage ["suffered loss"], not only of the lading and ship, but also of our lives." The loss suffered at Christ's Bema will be real. If it can be dismissed as merely figurative what about the rewards themselves" Might they also merely be figurative? The loss here is first of all, loss of reward. Each person will clearly understand why. The Lord's reasons will be clearly manifest in that day. How important it will be at the Bema of Christ that Paul's rewardable materials (1 Con 3:12a) have been used as we have built on the Pauline foundation, Christ according the revelation of the mystery. He cites from his own life how he kept the faith 2 Tim. 4:7. Paul surely built with gold, silver, and precious stones!

III. THE BEMA OF CHRIST ADDRESSES THE WRONG AND BAD, 2 Cor. 5:10 and Col. 3:25

A. The Sanctity Of The Believers' Body

In Chapter 3 we learned that God is the great Recompenser, see Rom. 11:35. In that same context we now ask: "What has the believer given to God?" From Rom. 12:1 the answer should be plain. A living sacrifice to God of our body has been the thing asked by Paul. This gift has been given by the believer and received by God. Numerous are the texts that confirm this; a few are suggested to demonstrate the sanctity of the believer's "living sacrifice-body:"

1. 1 Cor. 6:13b "..Now the body is not for fornication, but for the Lord; and the Lord for the body." The highest pursuit and goal for the believer's body finds its satisfaction... *"for the Lord."* This relational association of His Lordship is meaningful in the believer's body.

2. 1 Cor. 6:20 "For ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body, and in your spirit, which are God's." As this is properly done in our present body, so we will be rewarded at the Bema of Christ in our glorified body.

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[26] Op. cit. J. N. Darby, p. 160.
[27] Op.cit. Bullinger, p.468-469.

3. 2 Cor. 4:10 "Always bearing about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our body." Clearly this verse is a stage for the "treasure in earthen vessels" concept, "But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us," 2 Cor. 4:7.

4. Phil. 1:20 "According to my earnest expectation and my hope, that in nothing I shall be ashamed, but that with all boldness, as always, so now also Christ shall be magnified in my body, whether it be by life, or by death." This was Paul's goal. This is Paul's personal application of the "living sacrifice" in Romans 12:1.

5. 1 Thess. 5:23 "...your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ." God makes no excuses for our present body of humiliation, Phil. 3:20. Rather He provides for our serving Him in it with full potential of present sanctification now, and full rewards at His Bema.

More of this heavenly body change is seen in 2 Cor. 5:1-10. The believer is promised an eternal heavenly body, "For we know that if our earthly house of this tabernacle were dissolved, we have a building of God, an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens," 2 Cor. 5:1. Our present body will be dissolved by death or changed at the Rapture, "Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed," l Cor. 15:51. A groan characterizes this present body in which we walk by faith (2 Cor. 5:7), and labour that we might be acceptable to Him at the Bema of Christ.

Remember, this Bema of Christ focuses on "the things done in his (the) body," 2 Cor. 5:10. Note here this expression in the Greek: "pros a eproxen – ‘with reference to what he did.' The aorist is interesting: looking back from Christ's tribunal, the whole life of the individual Christian is seen as a unity. This concept is strengthened by the rather unexpected addition of the neuter singular (following the neuter plural) of eite agathon, eite phaulon – ‘whether it be good or whether it be worthless.' `The change to the neuter singular is significant,' says Plummer. It seems to imply that, although persons will be judged one by one and not in groups, yet conduct in each case will be judged as a whole. In other words, it is character rather than separate acts that will be rewarded or punished ...It is habitual action that will be judged. And this explains the aorist; it is what he did during his lifetime that is summed up and estimated as a total." [28]

B. The "Good," "Bad," Or The "Wrong"

The word "bad" (in 2 Cor. 5:10) is translated by Hughes "worthless," [29] Bullinger concurs.[30] It is necessary that we understand the Bema of Christ is an assessment of worth, not an administration of punishment. The Referee or Judge at the Olympic Games awards the winners - he does not berate or whip the losers.

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[28] Philip Edgcumbe Hughes, M.A., B.D., D.Litt.. Paul's Second Epistle to the Corinthians, Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., Grand Rapids, Mi., 1962, Copyright by Philip E. Hughes, p.181, footnote #58.
[29] Ibid, p.181.
[30] Op.cit. Bullinger, p. 79.

In Col. 3:25 Paul dealt with the Bema of Christ. In 3:25 the *wrong* is: adikeo, "what is not in conformity with ‘dike,' right; what it ought not to be, i.e. wrong." [31]

We see the positive side, "Knowing that whatsoever good (agathos, same as in 2 Cor. 5:10) thing any man doeth, the same shall he receive of the Lord, whether he be bond or free," Eph. 6:8. Whereas Col. 3:25 presents the loss of reward by the words "doeth wrong," both of these texts appear to say the same as does 2 Cor. 5:10.

C. Will There Be Tears, Remorse, Sorrow, Shame, And Regret At The Bema Of Christ?

Remember, believers will stand before the righteous Judge (2 Tim. 4:8) in resurrected and glorified bodies; that is, bodies like Christ's.

"The cause of shame at the judgment seat *of* Christ apparently arises from the believer's own realization [of sin,] unfaithfulness, and neglected opportunities rather than from being rebuked by Christ." [32]

Paul frequently referred to joy as part of his coming experience at the Bema *of* Christ. In both Phil. 4:1 "Therefore, my brethren dearly beloved and longed for, my joy and crown...," and 1 Thess. 2:19, "For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming?" The subject of joy is associated with the reward or crown Paul expected in that day. It has been suggested that if in the glorified body believers may experience joy, might not the emotions of sorrow, shame, regret, remorse and even tears be experienced also? Too often, however, the matter of tears in heaven is taken from our Lord's parables in the Gospel accounts.

Matt. 25:30 "And cast ye the unprofitable servant into outer darkness: there shall be *weeping* and gnashing of teeth."

Luke 13:28 "There shall be *weeping* and gnashing of teeth, when ye shall see Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, and all the prophets, in the kingdom of God, and yourselves thrust out."

It has been erroneously assumed from such texts that the weeping here is carried on in heaven at the Bema of Christ. In both Matt. 25 and Luke 13 the Kingdom is here on earth and the judgment that determines who enters the Kingdom and who will not. As we explained in Chapter Two "The Non-Pauline Texts Re: Judgment, Rewards, and Crowns," do not apply to the Church Christ's Body.

"The judgment seat of Christ might be compared to a commencement ceremony. At graduation there is some measure of disappointment and remorse that one did not do better and work harder. However, at such an event the overwhelming emotion is joy, not remorse. The graduates do not leave the

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[31] Op.cit. Bullinger, p. 907.

[32] Samuel L. Hoyt, Bibliotheca Sacra. April-June, 1980, The Negative Aspects of the Christian's Judgment, Dallas Theological Seminary, Dallas, Tx.. p. 130.

auditorium weeping because they did not earn better grades. Rather they are thankful that they have graduated, and they are grateful for what they did achieve. To overdo the sorrow aspect of the Judgment Seat of Christ is to make heaven Hell. To underdo the sorrow aspect is to make faithfulness inconsequential." [33]

"The bad works are discarded as unworthy of reward but good works are rewarded. The penalty is limited to loss of reward." [34]

It is good advice to heed Paul's words "...let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon..for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is," 1 Cor. 3:10,13.

WHEN I SEE CHRIST

Twill soon be over; ‘twill not be long
Till we'll be with that heavenly throng.
If till He come we occupy
Or if He tarry and we die,
And we are faithful, even though
Friends forsake us here below
Persecute, and scoff and frown,
Suffering saints shall have a crown.
At the rising of the just
When we stand, as stand we must,
Before our Saviour's judgment seat
And He reveals the chaff and wheat,
When hidden things are manifest
Will our works abide the test?
With secret motives brought to light,
When we have finished here our fight,
Shall we hear God's blessed Son
Approve our service with "well done?"
Such words will far out-pay the price
Our suffering, toil and sacrifice.

- J. C. O'Hair

[33] Op.cit. Hoyt, p. 131.
[34] John F. Walvoord, Bibliotheca Sacra, 123, April-June, 1966, p. 99-102.

Chapter 7

"Are All Rewards Yet Future?"

We acknowledge that Paul teaches a future coming *day* reserved for rewards, called the Judgment Seat of Christ. At this event every believer's works will be tried by fire, 1 Cor. 3:13-15. At the end of Paul's life he recognized that *day* was yet to come, 2 Tim. 4:8. Therefore, each day we are instructed to "run the race," and not only run the race, but "run to win," 1 Cor. 9:24-27. While that final accounting and awarding is yet to come are there not some compensations, benefits, and rewards received even in this life? We make bold to answer in the affirmative. Perhaps we could call these: daily reminders, foretastes, and evidences that not all rewards are relegated to the future. How gracious our Lord is to allow us some first-fruits now (as it were) of the coming harvest at the Bema of Christ. This all enhances what is still reserved for that day of reward.

To support the negative answer to our chapter's question the following three points are submitted.

I. THE LAW OF THE HARVEST ILLUSTRATES THAT NOT ALL REWARDS ARE YET FUTURE

See here 1 Cor. 9: 10,11 "Or saith he it altogether for our sakes? For our sakes, no doubt, this is written: that he that ploweth should plow in hope; and that he that thresheth in hope should be partaker of his hope. If we have sown unto you spiritual things, is it a great thing if we shall reap your carnal things?"

Surely the possibility here of Paul reaping the Corinthians' carnal things proves that there are rewards even now.

A. The Plowing and Planting in Hope

Paul cites the Law of Moses (Deut. 25:4) here in 1 Cor. 9:9 showing this to be applicable under grace also. While not all Scripture is to or about us it surely is for our learning and admonition, see Rom. 15:4; 1 Cor. 10:11.

Who of us has not been engaged in plowing a garden? Every Spring it is my job to roto-till my wife's garden plot. Once the frost has gone out of our northern Wisconsin plot and the soil temperature signals germination time we commence our plowing and planting. Although it will be some months before the harvest from our garden there are some benefits realized even in breaking the ground, planting the seed, and marking of the rows. There always is the expectation that the seeds will germinate and produce what the Seed Company advertised it would accomplish. We also can expect (i.e. with the assurance of guaranteed success) to enjoy the process of sowing and watering God's good seed, and the pleasant anticipation of the resulting fruit, long before the full harvest is experienced.

Here in context Paul describes a special grace concept: "Even so hath the Lord ordained that they which preach the gospel should live of the gospel," 1 Cor. 9:14. This is taken as a parallel teaching to the Priests' ministry in Israel's Temple, see 9:13.

That there are present compensations to preaching the gospel is clear. Specially does this apply to those who live of the gospel. Thus, Pastors, Ministers, Evangelists, Missionaries, et al., regularly realize a form of reward from their service. And as this service or stewardship will be acceptable at the Bema of Christ, rewards will be forthcoming in that day also.

Perhaps this seems only applicable to those in (so called) full time Christian service. And truly Paul was speaking about his own situation here as a minister. But it also, by extension, filters down to all believers. Notice here Paul had sown spiritual things to these Corinthians. His Apostolic ministry had invested in them the laid foundation (of 3:10) on which they now must build, 3:12. As with plowing and planting so with building, there are various stages of progress and development. And along with these stages comes a degree of compensation or satisfaction received by the worker. No, these interim rewards are not the ultimate or final evaluation, which will only be shown at the Bema of Christ. However, they are harbingers of that final day of accounting. One of the major benefits of teaching God's Word is that the teacher learns first and (often) the most. And this is not just reserved for the Bema of Christ; it relates to the here and now of our service.

Note for example Paul and Apollos in 1 Cor. 3:5-8. They are called "ministers by whom ye believed." Surely these ministers took encouragement from these Corinthians' belief of the gospel, 3:5. This was a foretaste (so to speak) of the rewards receivable at the coming Bema of Christ. However, in 3:5 the expression "even as the Lord gave to every man," would show that this is wider than just to Apollos and Paul. This same "every man" is mentioned in 3:8 as receiving his own reward. Evidently whoever will receive a reward in that day at the Bema of Christ may also receive an interim compensation now.

B. Increase Is Always of God

This is confirmed when Paul says it is "God that giveth the increase," I Cor. 3:7. Paul saw "increase" as from God in point of time there at Corinth. The fact of this interim "increase" is a matter of history. Since God is the God of the increase (and not all increase is reserved for the Bema of Christ) there will be segments of reward in the here and now. And this increase is a form of harvest. Each step of gardening and farming is an extension of the harvest principle. From the plowing to the planting and watering, each step is an advance and guarantee of the coming harvest.

Paul noted this interim increase principle in 1 Thess. 3:8 "For now we live, if ye stand fast in the Lord." This applies to the here and now. There exists benefit to and for laborers in God's ministry here and now as well as the final day of harvest at the Bema of Christ, note: 1 Thess. 2:19,20.

C. Rewards Confirmed by Interim Wages or Pay

The word translated reward in 1 Cor. 3:8 may also be mean "wages," or "pay." Apparently not all wages or pay are stored up to be disbursed at the Bema of Christ. God in Ills graciousness designs that believers receive some fruit now as well as at the coming Judgment Seat of Christ. Surely in this confirmation of interim increase via good works, there is a compensation. And by the same token these mini compensations further confirm that day of reward at the Bema of Christ. Might not this idea be latent in Paul's words (1 Cor. 3:9) "For we are labourers together with God: ye are God's husbandry, ye are God's building." This joint-labor with God cannot help but have immediate compensations as well as long range rewards. For believers to be called God's husbandry or cultivated field shows a growth factor. This in turn demonstrates repeated compensation as well.

II. THE DAILY POSSIBILITY TO SOW (AND REAP) GAL. 6:6-9

"Let him that is taught in the word communicate unto him that teacheth in all good things. Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap. For he that soweth to his flesh shall of the flesh reap corruption; but he that soweth to the Spirit shall of the Spirit reap life everlasting. And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not."

A. First, the Matter of Sowing, and Planting (Investing)

Most of us are familiar with an eight hour work day and a forty hour work week. Along with this scenario goes pay day when a check is placed in the worker's hand and material value is exchanged for time spent on the job. Thus, first comes the work period, then follows pay day. But is pay day the, only compensation for the many hours invested? Are there not notable benefits received from the job that are not included in that pay check? Might not some valuable friendships result from that employment? Perhaps the kind of work done itself would bring a degree of satisfaction. The enjoyment and pleasure of working, serving, being productive - these all must be considered as part of one's compensation. No pay check can ever fully compensate if these items are lacking in the work place. Speaking for myself as a Pastor, the benefits and periodic blessings that accrue as I serve the Lord and His people are frequently experienced on a daily basis. What a joy to realize that this present compensation is but a token and assurance of that larger and grander reward yet ahead at the Bema of Christ! I hope that your service for Christ is producing some visible compensations for you right now.

The precept of Gal. 6:7 cannot be successfully modified: "whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap." We must call this then, a Law. While not all sowing produces an instant harvest it may also be said: not all reaping must wait for a prolonged time frame, either. Beyond calling this precept a Law we must recognize here that any attempted modification, reversal, or denial of it is an immediate attack upon God Himself. Paul says God is not mocked. If believers live in ignorance of Gal. 6:7, or openly deny it, then God is thereby opposed. In addition to mocking (i.e. ridiculing, turning up the nose at) God, self deception is experienced. Is it possible that believers could be so deceived as to oppose this Law of sowing and reaping? and not only oppose this Law, but by so doing, ridicule God? Once again

the plain teaching of grace as to the Judgment Seat of Christ should keep us all in touch with reality here.

B. Time and Effort Involved

The metaphor of sowing and reaping here, is intended to press the concept that all of the believer's energy each moment of his life is involved therein. We are at this very moment engaged in some form of sowing or reaping. Now, were we literally planting and harvesting, there would be times of in-activity. For example, there are seasons when neither planting nor harvesting are possible, as in the Fall and the Winter. But Paul doesn't seem to apply this seasonal in-activity to the Law of Gal. 6:7. Here Paul only sees: "sowing and reaping." Surely this principle fits in with our question of consideration in this chapter: "Are All Rewards Yet Future?"

Paul's words in 2 Tim. 4:2 apply here also: "..be instant in season, out of season." His direct command is to "Preach the word; be instant in season, out of season; reprove, rebuke, exhort with all longsuffering and doctrine." From this there appears no time allotted for in-activity. At any given time in the believer's life he must be "instant in season, out of season." This surely fixes the running of our race in serving Christ in a state of constancy!

We could move into the believer's commanded vigilance in prayer to see a similar emphasis laid here by Paul.

Eph. 5:20 "Giving thanks..."

Col. 4:2 "Continue in prayer, and watch in the same with thanksgiving."

1 Thess. 5:17 "Pray without ceasing."

1 Thess. 5:18 "In everything give thanks."

Is there any call for, or room for, inactivity here? Is there any time when prayer should not/could not be a part of our sowing or reaping?

One more example is offered here. If we could list all the present tense imperative verbs that Paul uses, it would be an overwhelming evidence of this Law of Gal. 6:7. We'll cite here just one reference from each of Paul's letters:

Rom. 6:11 "Likewise *reckon* ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin.."

1 Cor. 11:1 *"Be* ye followers of me.."

2 Cor. 13:11 "...Be *perfect. .."*

Gal. 5:1 *"Stand* fast...in the liberty.."

Eph. 4:25 *"...speak* every man truth with his neighbor.."

Phil. 2:12 *"..work* out your own salvation.."

Col. 3:1 *"seek* those things which are above.."

l Thess. 4:11 *"..work* with your own hands.."

2 Thess. 2:15 *"..stand fast,* and *hold* the traditions which ye have been taught.."

1 Tim. 4:7 "But *refuse* profane and old wives fables.."

2 Tim. 2:1 "..be *strong* in the grace that is in Christ Jesus.."

Tit. 2:1 "But *speak* thou the things which become sound doctrine.."

Phe. :15 "..that thou *shouldest receive* him for ever.."

All of these listed verbs are present tense, and are in the imperative mood. There is no allowable inactivity in a present tense imperative verb form. What I'd really like to see placed here would be a complete listing of all the present tense imperative verbs Paul used. Someday a Bible software program of that sophistication for the Greek verbs Paul used will be found. I would be anxious to use it for my computer. Regardless, one can come close by reading through Paul's writings in the English Bible, paying close attention to his use of verbs.

This illustrates and documents that believers are directed, yes even commanded, to actively keep sowing and thereby reaping. Yes, the ultimate reaping will be done at the Bema of Christ. But interim fruit is experienced along our way also.

C. The Promised Harvest, When?

Two areas exist in which believers may sow; the flesh, or the Spirit. The former (flesh) produces a harvest of corruption (decay, ruin). The latter (Spirit) yields a harvest of life everlasting. The Spirit here is the realm of the "law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus," see Rom. 8:2. Is it possible in our present life to sow to the flesh (Carnal, Adamic-sin nature) and not experience any harvest therefrom until the Bema of Christ? Surely the fruit of the flesh will show itself along the way. Likewise it is true as one sows to the Spirit. In other words, not all such rewards in these two realms are future. Some are notable, and experienced here and now. Remember Paul's personal experience in 1 Thess. 3:8 "For *now* we live, if ye stand fast in the Lord." This would not be Paul's "now" experience if these Thessalonians had sown to their flesh.

In Gal. 6:9 (similar to 2 Thess. 3:13) a condition is laid down by which the reaping principle is made contingent, "And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not." Possibly this "due season" has a primary reference to the Bema of Christ. But, again, the context allows for some intervening "due seasons" along our life of service also. To be weary here means: "to lose heart, lose one's courage, faint." Why would any believer become weary in well doing? To properly answer this question we need to realize that we don't "weary" *of* well doing, rather we "weary *in*" it. We don't live in a perfect world. The running of the race requires a daily discipline. Therefore, Paul includes himself in this possible weariness and faintheartedness before the due season of the final harvest.

From 1 Cor. 15:58 we take heart, as did Paul: "Therefore, my beloved brethren, *be* ye steadfast, unmovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord." And, by the way the verb "be" is present tense, imperative mood!

III. THE CONSTANCY OF THE RACE

A. For Example: Your Interest in this Book

This very day has exhibited a race for you to run. The race, of course, entails the rigors and demands required to serve Christ by His Spirit through His grace extended. And as this is faithfully discharged rewards will be forthcoming, both along the way and in finality at Christ's Bema. Will the book you presently hold in your hands assist you to run that race? It is my sincere desire that it will. May your time be invested this very day in the framework of Col. 3:23 "And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men." For the very next verse places this all in proper perspective…"Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the reward of the inheritance: for ye serve the Lord Christ."

It seems apparent to me that every day God has built into our service for Him numerous incentives, spiritual perks (if you will), and blessed benefits. All of these prod us on. They confirm and point to that final graduation day of the Bema of Christ.

B. Daily Ministry in the Word, Prayer, Witnessing, et al.

How has your (daily) Bible time gone today? It may have taken the form of reading, study, or both. I find it hard to do the former without the latter. Has this form of your running the race been without compensation? How long may one go in reading/studying the Bible before we receive abundant fruit and harvest therefrom? I think the point is made. We receive such benefit from the Word that we often fail to properly evaluate it. Maybe you've heard a message from a preacher or teacher and the Word has become extremely pointed and applicable to your life. Isn't this God giving you fruit, even compensation in your service here and now? It's much like your favorite dish specially prepared and garnished appropriately. What satisfaction is realized as that delectable repast is anticipated and eaten. Just so, God whets our spiritual appetite with the savory truths of His Word. Such benefits daily bring joy and satisfaction here and now. And at the Bema of Christ we'll know the ultimate rewards.

How about the next time you attend the ministry of the Word at church? Should not this contribute to your running the race also? The fellowship with the brethren in Christ should be a positive factor in our running the race to win. Wouldn't our assemblies be dull and useless if we couldn't gain from them positive fruit in our sowing and reaping? The same thoughts used here as to one's daily Bible time and/or church attendance may be equally applied to prayer, witnessing, and our entire walk in grace.

C. The "Financial" Race

In dealing with the issue of our financial stewardship, we need to come back to Gal. 6:6, "Let him that is taught in the word communicate unto him that teacheth in all good things." This verse not only has its own teaching, but also introduces Paul's further instruction concerning the principle of sowing and reaping, see Gal. 6:7-9.

That there is a financial race is apparent from texts like: 2 Cor. 9:6 and Phil. 4:15-17, as well as here in Gal. 6:6. Paul, and his grace teaching, has a great deal to say about finances and giving for the Church today. Very possibly the Bema of Christ

will call up three essential areas from believers' lives: their Time, their Treasury, and their Talents.

From Gal. 6:6 Paul instructs the Galatians to "communicate" to the one teaching them the Word. By the way, the verb "communicate" is present tense, imperative mood! It is a command which is continuous. By *communicate* here Paul is not speaking about verbal or conversational feed back. The word is: "koinoneo, to have a thing in common, have a share; of things, to partake of; of persons, to partake with." [35] This word is used by Paul in Phil. 4:15, "Now ye Philippians know also, that in the beginning of the gospel, when I departed from Macedonia, no church *communicated* with me as concerning *giving and receiving,* but ye only." The italicized words here explain this communicating. Clearly Paul is talking about giving and probably this is financial giving.

In the Gal. 6:6 passage Paul commands the hearer of the Word to share back with his teacher in all good things. As all teachers of the Word can testify, the one gaining the most from any given lesson taught or message given is the teacher himself. But in addition to this Paul directs the hearer(s) of these truths in the Word to reciprocate in a financial (or in kind) manner. Surely this relates to the sowing and reaping concept which Paul is ready to bring forth in the following verses, i.e. Gal. 6:7-9.

Let's walk ourselves through the sowing and reaping cycle here. The Teacher prepares, in and from the Word, a message or lesson. In this process he is enriched, benefited, and blessed. In a word, he's rewarded as he runs his race faithfully and rightly divides the Word. Then the Word is taught to the class, congregation, or student. Now it's their turn to respond by sowing the resource given them by God, i.e. their money. This money is representative of God's provision via their time and talent. Perhaps, through a job in the work place, one's time and talent have been invested and as compensation on pay day wages are received. Thus, the hearers now are privileged, as part of their race and sowing, "to communicate unto him that teacheth in all good things." At this point the Teacher experiences a reaping/harvest and thus has means to continue his sowing once more.

Your financial offerings are evidence of your running the race in the here and now, and will result in rewards on the final day of accounting at the Bema of Christ.

Paul makes a similar point in 1 Cor. 9:11, "If we have sown unto you spiritual things [i.e. ministry of/in the Word], is it a great thing if we shall reap your carnal [i.e. fleshly, material, financial] things?" Note here Paul actually uses the words "sown" and "reap." Certainly he is making the same point here with these Corinthians that he has made with the Galatians.

Isn’t it therefore obvious that almost daily the certainty of the coming Bema of Christ is strengthened by these incidental benefits (i.e. mini-rewards.) Along the race course God gives foretastes of that final Bema of Christ. It’s a daily plowing,

[35] Ethelbert W.Bullinger,D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth edition, 1957, p. 172.

planting – a daily running of that race. God labors along side of us ever demonstrating His willingness to fully reward faithful service.

Chapter 8

"Are Rewards Based On Works?"

Somehow the word "works" has a negative ring to it for many believers. After all, they reason, don't we live in the dispensation of grace? Grace and works are opposing concepts, are they not?

Paul might be cited here as proof of the distinguishing of grace from works, see Rom. 11:6, "And if by grace, then is it no more of works: otherwise grace is no more grace. But if it be of works, then is it no more grace: otherwise work is no more work."

Admittedly grace and works may not be mixed. "Grace is not grace if mingled with works. The two principles are mutually exclusive (Rom. 4:4,5). Thus in salvation there is no `your part' to perform; it is the gift of God's love, to be received in simple faith (Rom. 6:23; Eph. 2:8,9)" [36]

Are we, therefore, to suppose that grace precludes works? In other words, that, works may not be a part of God's dispensation of grace? Surely numerous passages in Paul's writings come to mind that would contradict this conclusion. The book of Titus alone finds six references to good works:

Titus 1:16, "They profess that they know God; but in works they deny him, being abominable, and disobedient, and unto every *good work* reprobate."

Titus 2:7, "In all things shewing thyself a pattern of *good works:* in doctrine shewing uncorruptness, gravity, sincerity."

Titus 2:14, "Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of *good works."*

Titus 3:1, "Put them in mind to be subject to principalities and powers, to obey magistrates, to be ready to every *good work."*

Titus 3:8, "This is a faithful saying, and these things I will that thou affirm constantly, that they which have believed in God might be careful to maintain *good works."*

Titus 3:14, "And let ours also learn to maintain *good works* for necessary uses, that they be not unfruitful."

It is true: grace and works are different and separate principles. They need to be rightly divided from each other. Each must be kept in its distinct setting as

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[36] C.R.Stam, *Commentary of the Epistle of Paul to the Romans*, Berean Bible Society, Germantown, WI, 1984, p. 266.

designated in God's programs. However, does this mean that in God's dispensation of grace, works have no part? Certainly not. To this subject of works we now address chapter eight's question: "Are Rewards Based On Works?"

By way of review:

POINT ONE: Paul alone writes about the Judgment Seat of Christ. This will be set up subsequent to the rapture return of our Lord. This Tribunal is called in Greek *bema*, "a raised step. Then a tribune to speak from in a public assembly. In the Roman Law courts there were two, for plaintiff and defendant. Then, the elevated seat of a Judge (occ. Acts 7:5)."[37]

POINT TWO: This Tribunal/Bema is for the church the body of Christ. Each believer in attendance will be there in possession of his glorified body.

POINT THREE: The purpose of the Bema of Christ is to manifest a final accounting of believers' past service in their bodies from the point of their salvation until their death or the rapture, which ever occurred first. This Bema of Christ does not punish believers, who have been forgiven by Christ's redemptive work on the Cross. There will be un-rewardable works manifest as well as rewardable ones. The un-rewardable works are "burned" thus evidencing "loss," I Cor. 3:15, "If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire."

Again it needs to be said: When it comes to salvation God will not accept human works: Eph. 2;8,9 "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and *that not of yourselves*: it is the gift of God: *Not of works*, lest any man should boast."

Tit. 3:5 "*Not by works* of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost."

However, in each of the above contexts the cited verse shows a definite place for works by the (now) saved believer, Eph. 2:10 "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus *unto good works*, which God hath before ordained that *we should walk in them*." And Tit. 3:8 "This is a faithful saying, and these things I will that thou affirm constantly, that they which have believed in God might be *careful to maintain good works*. These things are good and profitable unto men."

We will therefore affirm that rewards are based on works and offer the following points showing their place compatible with grace.

I. THE WORK THAT GOD REWARDS

In 1 Cor. 3:8 God makes a promise: "...and every man shall receive his own reward according to his own labour." The word "labour" is the Greek: "kopos, a beating ...the being beat out, weariness; hence, wearisome effort, toilsome labour."[38] Here the figure of planting and watering illustrates a kind of labor or toil associated with the ground that God told Adam (Gen. 3:17-19) had been cursed for his sake. All such manual labor is further illustrated by "the sweat of thy face"

[37] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, A Critical lexicon and Concordance to the Greek New Testament, Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p. 428.
[38] Ibid. p. 438.

idiom taken from this Genesis Three text. Thus Paul is sure a reward is coming to each believer according to his own toil.

To further enhance this, the context (1 Cor. 3:7) speaks of "God that giveth the increase." No amount of planting or watering (i.e. labor by believers) produces anything of itself. The increase (i.e. "cause to grow, make large, or enlarge") comes only from God. He is the God of the increase. By this we may readily see Paul's reference to the Judgment Seat of Christ and the reward(s) promised to faithful laborers. What a special metaphor is used here: planting, watering, and increase! This speaks of something organic, living, and growing. As one labors in the spiritual ministry, certain apparent parallels to Christ's Bema are evident. Human hearts and lives need preparation just as does the ground in any field. God's good seed of grace must be laboriously deposited (planted) in prepared (fertile) fields. All of this doesn't just happen! Human labor is required - and then God's increase must be granted.

Paul sees himself laboring together with God. He was a coworker with God. What joy and satisfaction comes from this cooperative serving with God. So much of today's work is done grudgingly and in a rotten, bad, attitude toward one's employer. Paul will have none of this for himself, nor for other believers in Christ. Observe Col. 3:23,24 "And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily [lit. of one's soul], as to the Lord, and not unto men; Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the reward of the inheritance: for ye serve the Lord Christ."

The Corinthians were called: "God's husbandry ...God's building," 1 Cor. 3:9. "Husbandry" here means a cultivated field, a farm; "building" means an edifice; metaphorically it refers to edification, spiritual profit or advancement. God associates with the work going on in His church. He superintends it all. He is the (very) God of the increase.

As Paul stated (1 Cor. 3:7) that the planter and waterer were not anything, he made plain the God Who gives the increase is everything. This "increase" becomes the reward of 3:8 at Christ's Bema as a result of individual labor.

II. PAUL'S LAID FOUNDATION - THE NORM FOR ALL OTHER BUILDING UNDER GRACE

This metaphor of building or construction is developed further by Paul in 1 Cor. 3:10, "According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, I have laid the foundation, and another buildeth thereon. But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon."

Thus Paul will receive his own reward according to his own labor (3:8) as he laid this foundation. And we who follow after build upon Paul's laid foundation. In the same way we too will receive our own reward according to our own labour. A warning is here issued: "Take heed how he buildeth thereupon," 3:10b.

From Paul's labour here we may learn some important lessons. His labor (laying the foundation) was according to the grace of God given to him. Grace, then, becomes the norm and standard for all subsequent building upon the foundation, it should also be the energizing factor as we build upon it.

This grace comes to believers today in a dimension and enormity that did not exist prior to Paul. God has always dealt with man in grace. But in a distinct and superior manner today God has demonstrated to and through the Apostle Paul and his writings the dispensation of grace, Eph. 3:2 "If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward."

Notice here a few examples of this superior grace:

- it is received [in] abundance, Rom. 5:17
- it does much more abound, Rom. 5:20
- it is enthroned [as King] through righteousness, Rom. 5:21
- in abundance it might redound to the glory of God, 2 Cor. 4:15
- it is made to abound ...to every good work, 2 Cor. 9:8
- it brings forgiveness according to its riches, Eph. 1:7 - in its exceeding riches it will be shown "in the ages to come," Eph. 2:7
- it is mentioned in both the opening and closing of Paul's 13 letters to the body of Christ church:

  Rom. 1:7 and 16:24

  1 Cor. 1:3 and 16:23

  2 Cor. 1:2 and 13:14

  Gal. 1:3 and 6:18

  Eph. 1:2 and 6:24

  Phil. 1:2 and 4:23

  Col. 1:2 and 4:18

  1 Thess. 1:1 and 5:28

  2 Thess. 1:2 and 3:18

  1 Tim. 1:2 and 6:21

  2 Tim. 1:2 and 4:22

  Tit. 1:4 and 3:15

  Phe. 1:3 and 1:25

Surely if Paul, the chief architect, laid the foundation (1 Cor. 3:10) by the grace given unto him, we who now build upon it need grace also. This laid foundation is Christ, 1 Cor. 3:11. Paul clearly explains how Christ's superiority is revealed today: "Now to him that is of power to stablish you according to my gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery, which was kept secret since the world began," Rom. 16:25.

Paul completed his apostolic ministry. Jesus Christ is (the) laid foundation upon which each believer must now build, "For other foundation can no man lay than that is *laid*, which is Jesus Christ," 1 Cor. 3:11.

Before looking at the building materials available let's observe Paul's warning: "...But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon" 1 Cor. 3:10b. No believer is here excluded or overlooked: "every man" is addressed. "Take heed" means to "look intently." In other words: "keep your eyes on" Pauline truths which will aid by grace in building on this laid foundation. Paul is very concerned "how" we build on Christ! Our English word "how" is defined: "adv. 1. In what manner. 2. To what degree or extent. 3. For what reason; from what cause. 4. By what means. 5. In what state..." [39]

Next Paul gives the church the "manner, degree, extent, reason, means and cause" for building upon this foundation.

III. WORKS TO BE REWARDED OR BURNED

The following is taken from the January 6, 1998 devotional Our Daily Bread under the title: Work That Won't Burn. "My father-in-law spent 30 years helping people in the public health field. When he went to heaven at the age of 76, he left a closet full of files and a wall full of awards.

"When it came time for us to clean out his `work' closet, the family pictures and a few mementos were kept, and all the rest had to go. I got the job of disposing of it. I hauled it up past the barn into an open field, doused it with diesel fuel, and set it on fire - old project files, slide presentations, plaques of appreciation, correspondence, everything - and I watched it burn.

"Watching letters and proposals turn to ashes gave me a new understanding of 1 Corinthians 3:13. Paul said ‘Each one's work will become clear; for the Day will declare it, because it will be revealed by fire; and the fire will test each one's work, of what sort it is.'

"Today the work. Tomorrow - the fire.

"That afternoon in the pasture made me more careful, more thoughtful, about my fleeting opportunities to do work that won't burn - DCM." [40]

The materials available for believers to build upon Paul's laid foundation are described in 1 Cor. 3:12,13: "Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble; Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is."

Six materials are here presented - they range from gold to stubble. If we make further comparison of these materials they could line up thus; comparing the best with the worse:

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[39] Noah Webster's First Edition of an American Dictionary of the English Language, by Foundation For American Christian Education, 1967.
[40] Our Daily Bread, copyright 1997, RBC Ministries, Grand Rapids, ML, Vol. 42, no. 10.

A. Gold

B. Silver

C. Precious stones

C. wood

B. hay

A. stubble

Or if we compare the three sets in order it might look like this:

A. Gold

B. Silver

C. Precious stones

A. Wood

B. hay

C. stubble

No matter how one compares these six the two sets of three are discernibly different. They just don't favorably compare when it comes to intrinsic value. Perhaps if some world renowned artist would craft some exquisite figurine from a rare piece of wood it might have a market value of more than an ounce of gold. But in Paul's analogy here the test that these materials must face is trial by fire. Wood may evidence great value when crafted by a skilled artisan, but fire will soon reduce it to ashes. In contrast gold's intrinsic value is not harmed when "revealed by fire."

A point that needs to be established here is that at Christ's Bema it isn't our craftsmanship, that has made the wood, hay, or stubble appear more valuable, that counts for anything. If the fire burns the wood, hay, and stubble it also reduces our craftsmanship to ashes. Gold, silver, and precious stones hold intrinsic (i.e. "belonging to the essential nature or constitution of a thing <the -- worth of a gem>)" value.

Let's then look at the first triad - gold, silver, precious stones. These are clearly the desired materials with which Paul would have us build. These will not be "burned" at the Bema of Christ. They are valuable because they evidence by metaphor the comparable worth and value of the foundation upon which we build. The second triad - wood, hay, stubble has no valid equality when compared with Paul's laid foundation. The trial by fire of 1 Cor. 3:13 does not respect cheap, inexpensive, combustible materials. To do so would impugn the nature of the test, i.e. the "fire" itself. The nature of fire is to reduce to ashes all combustible materials.

Therefore as to value the first triad is preferred. It is necessary that believers here and now accept no less a standard than that of "gold, silver, and precious stones." For at the coming Bema of Christ only that standard will be approved by the righteous Judge.

Looking at the corporate, professing church today we note a glaring absence of Pauline building materials. By this is meant the preferred Pauline building materials are largely absent today. Listen carefully to the doctrines taught via the so called Christian media today. What part does Pauline doctrine, grace teaching, and right division play? From my observation few if any of these Pauline components are evident in today's church. If Pauline truth represents the gold, silver, precious stones (and I firmly believe it does) as equal to and comparable to his laid foundation, what is to be said for the "works" in today's church?

The only conclusion to draw - is that these "works" being not of grace represent wood, hay, and stubble. These will be burned and loss will be suffered. Paul says: "Every man's work shall be made manifest," 1 Cor. 3:13. This speaks of our work being openly, visibly seen. Primarily this "manifesting" will be before Christ as the righteous Judge, 2 Tim. 4:8. Paul addresses this issue in 1 Cor. 4:5, "...until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts."

This Bema of Christ is assigned a specific time frame. Scripture uses various time segments to express events: e.g. "a moment," 1 Cor. 15:52, describes that instant when the bodily change takes place at Christ's rapture return; "this present hour," 1 Cor. 4: 11, is a time segment describing Paul's then current experience of self sacrificing. The time frame Paul assigns to the coming judgment seat of Christ is not a moment, nor an hour; rather it is a "day." The Greek word day (Greek - hemera) is translated "judgment" in 1 Cor. 4:3, referring to "the time or period in which man judges." [41] Whatever the length of this day, it is clear that sufficient time will be allotted so that "Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the *day* shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is," 1 Cor. 3:13.

Works that abide the testing fire at the Bema of Christ will be rewarded. Abide means to remain, continue, stand, or dwell. These rewardable works will be proven consistent with Paul's laid foundation. Christ as the *Head* of the church is also that *laid foundation* of His church. As believers are workers together with Paul (2 Cor. 6:1) we will consistently allow God's enabling grace to produce rewardable works to our account at the coming Bema of Christ. And in this we obey 1 Cor. 4:16, "Wherefore I beseech you, be ye followers of me."

[41] Op.cit., Bullinger, p. 203.

Chapter 9

"Will There Be Tears At Christ's Bema?"

The Church has developed two extremes in dealing with the Pauline doctrine of the Judgment Seat of Christ. The first extreme is to make the Judgment Seat of Christ "a protestant purgatory, i.e. a time of punishment for unconfessed sins." [42] The other extreme is to play down the "loss" (1 Cor. 3:15) to the extent that faithfulness is seen as un-needed or of no consequence.

"To overdo the sorrow aspect of the judgment seat of Christ is to make heaven hell. To underdo the sorrow aspect is to make faithfulness inconsequential." [43]

By referring to these two opposing views and calling them extreme we contend that there is a balanced teaching which adequately handles both addressed issues. This balanced view is Paul's plain teaching. The daily benefit of this teaching should be realized in our service for Christ.

I. THE SOLEMNITY OF THE POSSIBLE LOSS OF REWARD

The matter of rewards or loss of them will be administered by "the Lord." Paul describes this in 2 Tim. 4:8 "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which *the Lord,* the righteous judge, shall give to me at that day..." Christ here is called: "the Lord, the righteous judge." Christ's Lordship is linked with His being "the righteous judge." Often we readily assign Christ's office as Judge to the unbelievers and that coming final judgment at the great white throne described in Rev. 20:11-15. But that quality of *judging* also belongs to the Lord, at the Bema of Christ. The Greek word for judge in 2 Tim. 4:8, means: "he who decides, a judge, umpire. The presiding judge; one who decides according to equity and common sense."[44] That the "righteous judge" is also the Lord brings a certain degree of solemnity to this Bema of Christ. Further emphasis that the One administering judgment is the Lord is seen in 1 Cor. 4:5, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until *the Lord* come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: and then shall every man have praise of God."

Another component of Christ's Lordship reserved for the judgment seat is "the terror of the Lord," 2 Cor. 5:11 "Knowing therefore the terror of *the Lord,* we persuade men; but we are made manifest unto God; and I trust also are made

[42] John F. Walvoord, Bibliotheca Sacra, Vol. 123 #490 April-June 1966, pp. 99-102.
[43] Samuel L. Hoyt, Judgment Seat of Christ, Part II, Negative Aspects of the Christian's Judgment, Bibliotheca Sacra, Vol. 137 #546, April-June 1980, p. 125.
[44] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press. Ltd., London, Eighth edition. 1957- p. 426.

manifest in your consciences." Once again we often readily assign "the terror of the Lord" to the great white throne judgment of the unsaved according to Rev. 20:11-15. However, here Paul introduces it as consistent with Christ's Lordship administered in regard the coming Bema of Christ. The word "terror" is seen in Rom. 13:3, "For rulers are not a *terror* to good works, but to the evil. Wilt thou then not be afraid of the power? do that which is good, and thou shalt have praise of the same."

"Concerning the word `terror,' another very fitting use of this Greek word is found in Eph. 5:33, `Nevertheless let every one of you in particular so love his wife even as himself; and the wife see that she reverence (phobeo) her husband.' The wife is not normally to be in *terror* of her husband's return, but her conduct while she is waiting is in light of that return, in respect for him, in acknowledgement of his authority, and motivated by her desire to please him. *If* she has been unfaithful, however, she should truly fear his return."[45]

"Terror" is "phobos, fear, fright, dismay, `hence,' flight. `It denotes the outward manifestation rather than the sensation of fear. In a bad sense, it is the effect of the spirit of No. 2 [i.e. moral cowardice, timidity]; in a good sense the fear of God."[46]

Surely Paul does not trifle here with words. Did he not know of the "terror of rulers?" Did he not also know of the "terror of the Lord?" Does he not write in such a manner as to dramatize for us the solemnity of our Lord as He administers this coming Bema? Remember, it is not our intent to overdo nor underdo these applied descriptions of our Lord. There is a sacred seriousness associated with Christ's administration of this coming judgment seat. And this has been known by the church since the days of Paul. Paul used "the terror of the Lord" in 2 Cor. 5:11 to persuade men. Now is the time to allow the gravity associated with our Lord's administering the coming judgment seat to be meaningful in our attitudes, motives, and service for this same Lord!

While persuading men, Paul "was manifest" unto God, and equally so, in the Corinthians' consciences, 2 Cor. 5:11b. Such openness and spiritual transparency comes through Paul as the practical outworking of the "terror of the Lord." May we all follow Paul in this also; see 1 Cor. 4:16 and 11:1,2.

Two additional qualities are evident by the word "both" in 1 Cor. 4:5. First, our Lord "will bring to light the hidden things of darkness..."

"And what meanness could be baser than to desire that everything which would bring us praise might be brought to light, but that all our faults and failings and sins might be concealed? "[47]

These hidden things have been suppressed in all our lives. All this must be brought to light at the Bema of Christ. The believer then will stand before the Lord in a glorified, redeemed body reflecting the very light and righteousness of which Christ

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[45] William P. Heath, unpublished notes.
[46] Op.cit. Bullinger, p. 279.
[47] Sir Robert Anderson, Forgotten Truths, (reprint) Kregel Publications, Grand Rapids, Mi., 1980, p. 120.

is the essence. There will be no fear of that Light, but rather a complete revelling therein by the church.

"For if we have really understood grace, if we are standing in grace, if we know what God is, all love for us, all light for us, we shall like to be in full light ...It is a burden, and encumbrance to have anything concealed.

"Without the knowledge of grace, we fear the light; it cannot be otherwise. But knowing grace, knowing that sin has been put away as regards the glory of God, and that the offense is no longer before His eyes, we like to be in the light, it is joy to us, it is that which the heart needs, without which it cannot be satisfied, when there is the life of the new man.

"The truth is, the judgment seat is what most brings out our assurance before God; for as He is, so are we in this world; and it is when Christ shall appear we shall be like Him."[48]

The second quality involved in the "both" of 1 Cor. 4:5 is: "and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts..." The "manifesting" here, is the same word "appear" in 2 Cor. 5:10, "For we must all *appear* before the judgment seat of Christ..." There will be a "shining forth," an "open declaring," and a "rendering apparent" at this coming Bema of Christ. The counsels of the heart seem to deal with the: volition, the will, determination, propensity, motive; the very purpose, plan, counsel, advice, that we've used in all of our service rendered to our Lord. This really gets down beneath the surface into realms to which only "the Lord the righteous judge" is privy. And as Darby put it so well: "...It is a burden, and encumbrance to have anything concealed."

With such full and total accounting of "things done in the body" looming larger in his future (2 Cor. 5:10) well might the believer now render daily his service and run his race in all seriousness and sacred solemnity.

Paul's words in 1 Cor. 9:24-27 express his personal concern for the possibility of standing before the Bema of Christ a castaway, or un-rewarded,

"Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize'? So run, that ye may obtain.

"And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible.

"I therefore so run, not as uncertainly; so fight I, not as one that beateth the air:

"But I keep under my body, and bring it unto subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others. I myself should be a castaway."

The word "castaway" is the Greek word: adokimos, which means disapproved, the very opposite of approved. At Christ's Bema un-rewarded works will not receive God's approval. Paul saw a possibility that he could be placed on the shelf or

[48] J. N. Darby, Synopsis of the Books of the Bible, Vol IV, Stow Hill Bible and Tract Depot, London, 1949, pp. 229-237.

disapproved in his life of service. If this was possible in the believer's life of service, surely rewards would be missing at the Bema of Christ.

The following quotations appear to answer "Yes," to the question we pose "Will There Be Tears At The Bema of Christ?"

"`For a thousand years when the Lord reigns and rules over the earth you'll not rule...But throughout that one thousand years, up there in the outer darkness ...there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth ...But He's going to send all of the wicked, lazy, unprofitable Christians ...to outer darkness for one thousand years and they shall weep and there shall be gnashing of teeth."[49]

Here the "weeping and gnashing of teeth" is taken from Matt. 25:30 and erroneously applied to "unprofitable Christians" at the Bema of Christ. We have dealt with such mis-application of these non-Pauline texts in Chapter two. Since only Paul writes about the Judgment Seat of Christ our Lord's teaching in Matt. 25:30 (et al.) does not apply to the church to whom Paul writes his thirteen letters.

"Justice toward His children demands that God reward them for both good works and bad works at the Judgment Seat of Christ. There will be crowns and rewards for good works. There will be chastisement and stripes for bad works."[50] Although this quote does not mention "tears" one would probably be correct in assuming Dodson's "Yes" to our current question in this Chapter.

"If any one owes you a debt, it will have to be acknowledged. If a Christian has wronged you in any fashion, hurt you by an idle word or the spreading of a false and irresponsible report, such an one will have to apologize to you before high heaven and the assembled host."[51] Once again "tears" are not mentioned in Haldeman's statement. But it is apparent he could be placed with those agreeing that such will be the case at the Bema of Christ.

"If you do not want to be ‘ashamed before Him at His coming;' if you do not want to face `the terror of the Lord' and suffer loss, seeing your works all burned up,' then dear Christian, WATCH NOW, labor, win souls, abide in Christ, live a holy life. There will be tears in Heaven for your sin and failure here."[52] Here then is Rice's clear affirmation: "there will be tears in Heaven." In fact he wrote an entire book asserting this (see footnote #10 below).

It will be helpful to observe the context of Paul's accountability in 1 Cor. 9:24-27. Here it is in 1 Cor. 9:16-18,

"For though I preach the gospel, I have nothing to glory of: for necessity is laid upon me; yea, woe is unto me, if I preach not the gospel!

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[49] George W. Dollar, taped sermon preached at Faith Baptist Church, LaCrosse, Wi., quoted in Bibliotheca Sacra, Jan. 1980, by Samuel L. Hoyt.
[50] Kenneth F. Dodson, The Prize of the Up-Calling or Paul's Secret Victory, Baker Book House, Grand Rapids, Mi. 1969, p. 82.
[51] I. M. Haldeman, Ten Sermons on the Second Coming of our Lord Jesus Christ (reprint) Baker Book House, Grand Rapids. Mi., 1963, p.341.
[52] John R. Rice, Tears in Heaven, Sword of the Lord Publishers, Murfreesboro, Tn. 1941, p. 11.

"For if I do this thing willingly, I have a reward: but if against my will, a dispensation of the gospel is committed unto me.

"What is my reward then? Verily that, when I preach the gospel, I may make the gospel of Christ without charge, that I abuse not my power in the gospel."

Paul serves his argument well here by using himself as an example. Two options were open to him in preaching the gospel. First, if he were faithful in his serving he would receive a reward. Second, were he unwilling, he still was accountable. Notice in 1 Cor. 9:16 Paul says "woe is unto me, if I preach not the gospel!" When might this "woe" be realized? Surely he has in mind the coming Bema of Christ.

Therefore, Paul continues, all believers are to run the race (of service and activity) to obtain (katalambano, "to seize, possess, or attain") the prize or crown, 9:24. Ours is not a corruptible crown. Rather it is incorruptible. Well has it been said: "God has no cheap rewards."

Paul sees his body kept in strict temperance or self-control. "But I keep under my body ["to hit under the eye," lit. give one a black eye], and bring it into subjection ["enslave it"]: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway ["rejected, disapproved" thus at the Bema of Christ]," 1 Cor. 9:27.

Two forceful motivations are presented in l Cor. 9:24,25 and 27. First, the obtaining of the prize...an incorruptible crown. Second, self discipline lest Paul should be un-rewarded. We run to win - but need to exercise self discipline or else we will stand unrewarded.

The body here represents to Paul what needs self discipline. This he saw as the need of every man "that striveth for the mastery," l Cor. 9:25. The athlete must train and be the master of his body. Thus, as in the Greek games, he may win the corruptible crown. To win the incorruptible crown demands temperance/self control over one's body also. And from 2 Cor. 5:10 we again are reminded why we will stand at the coming Bema of Christ: "...that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad."

II. THE JOY OF CONTEMPLATING REWARDS TO COME

Paul illustrates a definite joy when looking ahead to that day of the judgment seat of Christ.

"As also ye have acknowledged us in part, that we are *your rejoicing,* even as ye are *ours* in the day of the Lord Jesus," 2 Cor. 1:14.

Whatever acknowledging had taken place between these Corinthians and Paul, the greater rejoicing is reserved for "the day of the Lord Jesus." Such joy Paul evidences here - and this involves these Corinthians. This Corinthian church had been far from what Paul could call spiritual. He readily called them "carnal, even as...babes in Christ," 1 Cor. 3:1. Yet in this second letter to them he looks forward with joy to their being at the Bema of Christ. Surely this speaks positively for what some have called the "soul winner's crown." Do we see here any hint from Paul of tears at the prospect of this coming day of the Lord Jesus? Does he suggest

weeping here - even over these Corinthians'? The verse is one of clear, positive rejoicing. How then might this be compared with l Cor. 3:15 "he shall suffer loss?" Could Paul rejoice if Corinthian believers suffered loss at the Bema of Christ? He would not rejoice at such loss, but would find joy that they were there, even though "...saved; yet so as by fire."

For another example of Paul's joyous contemplation of Christ's coming Bema, notice 1 Thess. 2:19,20,

"For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming`?

"For ye are our glory and joy."

Before moving through this verse we want to point out how the crown is associated with Christ's coming. This again establishes the time of this Judgment Seat of Christ. In this same vein Paul even uses the word hope as synonymous with the words: crown and joy! Hope speaks of certainty, fixedness, and guarantee. Paul was sure about these factors. And one component of hope, is joy. No hint of tears or weeping here! Admittedly Paul strongly associates this joy with expecting believers to be in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming," 1 Thes. 2:19. We don't want to minimize the coming/return of Christ. However, Paul does include the word "crown" here. And this associates the event of the Bema with it. In fact he not only includes the word "crown" but "crown of rejoicing" is the full phrase used. Verse twenty establishes further this idea of joy as being high on Paul's list of priorities as regards the Bema of Christ.

It is well for us to return to 1 Cor. 4:5 again,

"Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: *and then shall every man have praise of God."*

It is this closing phrase we need to consider. It is not too far removed from the preceding chapter. In chapter three we have that solemn text (3:15) where possible loss of reward is spelled out. The "praise of God" in 4:Sb, is not intended to weaken nor nullify the possible "loss" in 3:15. These two concepts must be balanced in our understanding.

The phrase may be translated: "...and then shall each receive his due(8) praise from God."[53] The word "praise" is "praise upon, applause, commendation, approbation."[54]

"The judge at the Bema bestowed rewards on the victors. He did not whip the losers."[55]

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[53] W.J.Conybeare and J.S.Howson, The Life and Epistles of St. Paul, Wm.B.Eerdmans Publishing Co., Grand Rapids, Mi. 1953, p. 387. His footnote *#8* reads, "`His praise,'..." The error in A.V. was caused by not observing the article."
[54] Op.cit., Bullinger, p. 594.
[55] Samuel L. Hoyt, Bibliotheca Sacra, June 1980, p. 38.

We need to present an added point here in tune with Col. 2:13, "...having forgiven you all trespasses." "The point Paul makes is that the believer is completely forgiven legally before the sin is ever committed ...God can therefore find no cause for accusing the Christian judicially any more than He can find cause for accusing Jesus Christ. Therefore at the Judgment Seat of Christ forensic punishment [i.e. what relates to the courts enacting punishment] will not be meted out for the believers' sins."[56]

Paul sees a final presentation of the church in Eph. 5:26,27,

"That he might sanctify and cleanse it with the washing of water by the word,

"That he might present it to himself a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that it should be holy and without blemish."

Now a question comes to mind: Will the church be "presented" (as per 5:27), before the Bema of Christ, or after? It would appear this "presentation" occurs after the Judgment Seat of Christ; even with some of the believers "saved; yet so as by fire," I Cor. 3:15.

Paul asserts that joy was the emotion dominant in his contemplation of the coming Bema of Christ. He does not actually mention tears or weeping as responses when believers lose rewards. If the emotion of joy may be experienced, it stands to reason that sorrow (or tears) may also be experienced there. It must be remembered that believers stand at the Bema of Christ in their glorified bodies. That reality will greatly temper the potential loss of rewards. And added to this is the due praise of 1 Cor. 4:5b and the "presentation" of Eph. 5:27.

HIS PLAN FOR ME

When I stand at the judgment seat of Christ
And He shows His plan for me,
The plan of my life as it might have been,
Had He had His way -- and I see

How I blocked Him here, and checked Him there,
And I would not yield my will,
Will there be grief in my Saviour's eyes,
Grief, though He loves me still?

He would have me rich, and I stand there poor,
Stripped of all but His grace,
While memory runs like a hunted thing
Down the paths I cannot retrace.

[56] Ibid, p. 38.

Lord, of the years that are left to me,
I give them to Thy hand;
Take me and break me, and mold me
To the pattern Thou has planned!

- Author Unknown

Chapter 10

"What Will The Rewards Be?"

Television brings into our homes every few years coverage of the Olympic games. Both winter and summer games are equally presented. We are accustomed to see the three top athletes pose on that three tiered platform. They receive the gold, silver, and bronze medals in world athletic competition. They are the world's *first*, *second,* and *third* best contestants in their respective event.

In this same vein I recently read in the sports page about one of the prestigious golf tournaments here in the United States where the winner, with the lowest score, won $400,000.00. The remainder of the finalists were listed thereafter as they finished "in the money" all the way down to the cut off which was listed at $5,000.00.

Most competitive events offer other valuable prizes and awards in the form of trophies, medals, rings, badges, emblems, jackets, et al. These are given to the winners. Paul acknowledged this in 1 Cor. 9:25, "And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now *they* do it to obtain *a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible."* And carefully notice his immediate response (in 9:26), "I therefore so run..." Paul was motivated to run by an incorruptible crown. What influenced and motivated Paul was set forth in Scripture sent to these Corinthians. We today are members of that same body of Christ church and to us has been written (by extension) Paul's words, "So run, that ye may obtain," 1 Cor. 9:24; and "I therefore so run..." 1 Cor. 9:26. Are you running today? Are you running, like Paul, to win?

Just what might that incorruptible crown be that caused Paul to so run? What will the rewards be that He has reserved for the Bema of Christ? Will they be visible, like medals, badges, emblems, insignia? Or will they take the form of privileges, benefits, expanded capacities, domains over which to rule? Just what will these rewards be?

Regardless of what we find in Paul's letters to answer this question, suffice it to say that God has no cheap nor insignificant rewards!

I. PEOPLE RELATED REWARDS FOR FAITHFUL SERVICE

One of the Apostle Paul's most loved ministries was the church at Thessalonica. It is significant in Acts 17:4, that in Thessalonica, "the devout Greeks a great multitude" believed and consorted with Paul and Silas. Now, I don't know how many "a great multitude" is, but I doubt that most of the congregations I have pastored would be placed in that category! That such a number of Gentiles believed Paul's gospel must have been an encouragement to him.

Paul commends these believers in 1 Thess. 1:6, "And ye became followers of us, and of the Lord, having received the word in much affliction, with joy of the Holy

Ghost." They believed Paul's gospel and then followed the apostle in his teachings of grace. Therefore he writes his second letter to them that this precedent be continued, 2 Thess. 3:6,7 "Now we command you, brethren, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that ye withdraw yourselves from every brother that walketh disorderly, and not after the tradition which he received of us. For yourselves know how ye ought to follow us: for we behaved not ourselves disorderly among you."

In looking ahead to the judgment seat of Christ Paul called these Thessalonians his "crown of rejoicing," 1 Thess. 2:19,20: "For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming? For ye are our glory and joy."

Paul called these believers his crown of rejoicing. That these believers would be in attendance and in the presence of our Lord Jesus at His coming is most assuredly a reference to the Bema of Christ. How then could people be considered a crown? Might not the emphasis of joy and rejoicing be considered here, as the reward? Apparently Paul experienced joy even as he wrote these verses. That joy would not be less nor diminish in the day of the judgment seat of Christ.

Another of Paul's most loved ministries was the church at Philippi. There, from day one, Paul had spiritually bonded with these believers, and they with him, Phil. 1:3-5, "I thank my God upon every remembrance of you, Always in every prayer of mine for you all making request with joy, For your fellowship in the gospel from the first day until now."

These Philippians endeared themselves to Paul by even financing his ministry in Thessalonica, Phil. 4:15,16, "Now ye Philippians know also, that in the beginning of the gospel, when I departed from Macedonia, no church communicated with me as concerning giving and receiving, but ye only. For even in Thessalonica ye sent once and again unto my necessity."

Now, if Paul could see the Thessalonians as his crown of rejoicing, and if the Philippians supported that ministry through Paul, wouldn't it also follow that these Philippians could be similarly rewarded at the Bema of Christ? An interdispensational principle applies here as stated by our Lord in Matt. 10:41, "He that receiveth a prophet in the name of a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward; and he that receiveth a righteous man in the name of a righteous man shall receive a righteous man's reward." Therefore, by extension of the principle of ministry, rewardable service may be shared by many at Christ's coming judgment seat.

Little wonder then that Paul calls these Philippians (4:1) "...my brethren dearly beloved and longed for, *my joy and crown..."* It appears highly significant that both churches were called Paul's "joy and crown." They comprised at least a part of his rewardable ministry. And to the degree that the Philippians invested in the Thessalonian ministry through Paul it seems reasonable that they also will share in a righteous man's reward.

This thought of believers being Paul's joy and crown is, to a degree, also associated with his Corinthian ministry, 2 Cor. 1:I4, "As also ye have acknowledged us in part, that we are your rejoicing, even as ye also are ours in the day of the Lord

Jesus." Yes, even these Corinthians would be a rejoicing for Paul at that day. Although the words crown or reward are not used here, it seems reasonable to believe that they are understood to be part of the coming Bema of Christ. The joy of the Lord will be assigned as a reward and crown for ministering in the lives of fellow saints. Surely there is no lasting joy apart from that which is in the Lord. And if today we are instructed to "Rejoice in the Lord alway: and again I say Rejoice," Phil. 4:4, what joy and rejoicing will be experienced by faithful servants at the judgment seat of Christ.

II. SPECIFIED REWARDS

A. The Prize. Phil. 3:14, "I press toward the mark for the *prize* of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus." Here Paul recognizes something beyond "the high calling," which he calls the prize.

1 Cor. 9:24, "Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the *prize?* So run, that ye may obtain."

"PRIZE, Brabeion, a prize bestowed on the victors in the public games of the Greeks, such as a wreath, chaplet, or garland."[57]

Was this prize of no consequence to the contestant in the Greek games? Was it the intrinsic value or worth which made it sought after? The answer to both of these questions is "No." The actual prize, was not just a wreath or garland. Rather, to the winner thereof, the ancient Greek world assigned fame, acclaim, and often great wealth. And all of this Paul effectively sets aside in 1 Cor. 9:25 with these words: "...Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown..." Yes, the fame, acclaim, and great wealth of ancient Greece easily fits into Paul's descriptive, "a corruptible crown." However, Paul adds..."but we an *incorruptible!"* An incorruptible prize; what ever it must be it surpasses any concept of our finite mind. How much do we know today of incorruptibility? We are surrounded by the opposite, corruption, of which this present evil age is the devil's masterpiece.

Possibly one reason why Paul makes so many references to the Greek games in his Corinthian letters is due to the fact that "the Isthmus of Corinth was one of the four sanctuaries where the most celebrated games were periodically held."[58]

B. The Reward of the Inheritance. Col. 3:24, "Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive *the reward of the inheritance:* for ye serve the Lord Christ." Here, Paul combines two nouns that depict two separate truths. First, is the word "inheritance." In Col. 1:12 "inheritance" is associated with that of which the saints partake having been fitted for it by the Father. In other words, this describes the believer's position and standing before God in Christ. Col. 1:13 further explains our inheritance, "..Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son..."

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[57] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p. 604.
[58] W.J. Conybeare,M.A., and J.S. Howson, D.D., The Life and Epistles of St. Paul Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1953, Grand Rapids, Mi. p. 540.

In God's Son the believer now finds a familial relationship that legally issues in an inheritance called "The inheritance of the saints in light," Col. 1:12b. This inheritance is of grace. It is a gift. Therefore, rewards will not be given at the Bema for this inheritance. In Col. 3:24 we are told of the second noun: "the *reward* of the inheritance." It is this reward that may be forfeited according to Col. 2:18,19 "Let no man beguile you of your reward in a voluntary humility and worshipping of angels, intruding into those things which he hath not seen, vainly puffed up by his fleshly mind, And not holding the Head..."

Paul's teaching in Colossians chapter two (2:9-23) clearly distinguishes between unfinished law works and Christ's completeness. This is seen in Christ, Himself, as well as in His redemptive triumph. Could anything be greater than this inheritance? Yes, God has designed *the reward* of this inheritance. And this reward is based on serving the Lord Christ.

C. The Crown of Righteousness. 2 Tim. 4:8, "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing."

This crown is associated with righteousness. If ever righteousness was shining forth, it is today in the dispensation of grace. The very gospel of grace (called "the gospel of Christ" in Rom. 1:17) has revealed therein, the righteousness of God. This very "righteousness of God without the law is manifested, being witnessed by the law and the prophets; Even the righteousness of God which is by faith of Jesus Christ unto all and upon all them that believe: for there is no difference," Rom. 3:21,22.

Therefore, "a crown of righteousness" is a fitting description (under grace) for a reward available at Christ's Bema. Paul calls our Lord "the righteous judge" as He administers a crown of righteousness at His Bema. We see that this reward/crown shows compatibility between it and the Lord Himself. Paul states that this same crown, of which he is assured, is available to "all them also that love his appearing," 2 Tim. 4:8b.

In context we note a wider field of Paul's service that contributed to this assured crown. In verse seven he wrote, "I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith."

These three may be singled out thus:

1. "fought the good fight" - ran the good race.

2. "finished my course" - completed my career.

3. "kept the faith" - preserved the "one faith" of Eph. 4:5; the "my doctrine" of 2 Tim. 3:10a, et al.

Paul summed up his ministry by these three listed activities. Thus he wrote in the following verse (2 Tim. 4:8) "Henceforth..." may be translated "finally," "furthermore," "now it remaineth," "then." Whatever this crown of righteousness is, it is given for fidelity in living, extending, and preserving Pauline teaching. Could it

be that this crown of righteousness is *the* crown above all others that is available to believers at Christ's Bema?

Each believer needs to come here to Paul's statements in 2 Tim. 4:6-8. Here they need to lock into the truth of Christ's Bema and that for which this crown of righteousness is to be granted. Then, the believer will be well served to work back from this point to where he or she is in his service/ministry at the present. Truly this will produce a spiritual perception and sacred balance which motivates us all to so run the race that we may win.

III. PAUL'S THREEFOLD VOCATIONAL ILLUSTRATION, 2 TIM. 2:3-6

Timothy is given a command to "be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus," 2 Tim. 2:1. This grace would be the enabling factor in Timothy's ministry/service of "teaching others also," 2:2.

In the following verses Paul cites three vocations to illustrate how Timothy could be taught to run his race, being confident of the promised reward.

2 Tim. 2:3-6, "Thou therefore endure hardness, as a good soldier of Jesus Christ.

"No man that warreth entangleth himself with he affairs of this life; that he may please him who hath chosen him to be a soldier. And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully. The husbandman that laboureth must be first partaker of the fruits."

Let's examine, in order, these vocations:

1. The good soldier (of Jesus Christ). Paul calls Christ the commander in chief of this good soldier. It isn't just any soldier that he has in mind. It is a *good* soldier which is Paul's example. And as a good soldier of Jesus Christ, hardness is to be endured. Surely military life illustrates comparable lessons for the believer in his life of service for Christ. Thus, Paul brings to mind the. matter of enduring hardness. Hardness means to suffer trouble or afflictions. Paul was probably looking at a Roman soldier (to whom he was chained) as he wrote to Timothy. He had seen his share of soldiers, both good ones, and the other kind.

The good soldier would not entangle himself with civilian things when his life and service were to be in military things. This obviously translates to mean that believers' service must be equally dedicated to Christ and separated from worldly distractions.

The reward for being a good soldier is "that he may please him who hath chosen him to be a soldier," 2 Tim. 2:4b. To please Christ at His Bema would then mean to be rewarded by Him. To displease Christ would result in being unrewarded by Him. Observe here a similar text in 2 Cor. 5:9, "Wherefore we labour, that, whether present or absent, we may be *accepted* [i.e. "well pleasing"] of him." Notice that the next verse (5:10) links this with the judgment seat of Christ.

2. The Athlete and Masteries. The phrase "strive for masteries," 2 "Tim. 2:5, is in Greek "athleo" from which we get our English word "athlete." The contest of the race track was in Paul's thinking. The emphasis here is how the athlete conformed to the rules of the contest. Only those runners who played by the rules could expect to win

in the Greek games. Paul applies this athletic metaphor to believers. No one at the Bema of Christ will be rewarded who didn't "strive lawfully." There will be no rewards for circumventing the rules. Such rules are designed by the Administrator of the rewards Himself. This One Paul called "the Lord the righteous judge," Look back at just three texts and determine what some of the rules laid out are: 1 Cor. 3:12-15; 1 Cor. 4:1,2; and 1 Cor. 9:24-27.

3. The Diligent Farmer. Paul didn't say in 2 Tim. 2:6, "The husbandman...must be first partaker of the fruits." He did say: "The husbandman *that laboureth* must be first partaker of the fruits." It is only as the husbandman labours that his reward is to be partaking of the fruits. We recall that all increase (i.e. fruit) comes from God, 1 Cor. 3:7. Therefore "fruits" are set down here as the rewardable increase that crowns the harvest.

What will the rewards be? We know they will be above our comprehension. They are designed by our Lord Himself. They are consistent with His very Being. They are what bring pleasure to Him. They are worth striving for. So run, that you may win them!

Chapter 11

The Issue of Sufferings and Reward

It has been said, "No pain, no gain." I understand that this adage was attributed to the late Vince Lombardi. This expression is used to motivate people to do more, go farther, try harder, reach higher, and in general exceed the status quo.

How does this expression apply to believers and the issue of sufferings and rewards at the Judgment Seat of Christ? One thing is certain, the Apostle Paul's life was a demonstration of sufferings for Christ's sake. Christ informed Ananias about the newly converted Saul of Tarsus, "...Go thy way: for he is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel: For I will shew him how great things he must suffer for my name's sake," Acts 9:15,16.

These verses do not mention rewards for sufferings for Christ's name, but we will see in Paul's writings how he dealt with this subject. Paul not only thought sufferings were a basis for rewards, he also experienced them in his daily walk and service for Christ.

Paul received, on numerous occasions, revelations from the ascended Christ which were incorporated into his thirteen inspired letters to the church, "If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward: How that by revelation he made known unto me the mystery; (as I wrote afore in few words, Whereby, when ye read, ye may understand my knowledge in the mystery of Christ)," Eph. 3:2-4.

Because of the "abundance of the revelations, there was given unto me a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure," 2 Cor. 12:7. Here, Paul learned what true strength is. He prayed three times for the elimination of this thorn in the flesh. The Lord's answer was, "...My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness...," 2 Cor. 12:9. Paul mentioned twice in one verse, why God gave this "thorn" to him, "And lest I should be exalted above measure ...lest I should be exalted above measure," 2 Cor. 12:7. Sufferings played a major role in demonstrating to Paul God's strength of grace in the midst of human infirmities.

The believer who would follow Paul's revelations from Christ may also expect to experience Paul's sufferings, "For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his sake; Having the same conflict which ye saw in me, and now hear to be in me," Phil. 1:29,30.

I. THE FACT OF THE EARTHEN VESSEL AND SUFFERING

"But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

"We are troubled on every side, yet not distressed; we are perplexed, but not in despair;

"Persecuted, but not forsaken; cast down, but not destroyed;

"Always bearing about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus, that the life also of Jesus might be made. manifest in our body.

"For we which live are alway delivered unto death for Jesus' sake, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our mortal flesh.

"So then death worketh in us, but life in you.

"We having the same spirit of faith, according as it is written, I believed, and therefore have I spoken; we also believe, and therefore speak;

"Knowing that he which raised up the Lord Jesus shall raise up us also by Jesus, and shall present us with you.

"For all things are for your sakes, that the abundant grace might through the thanksgiving of many redound to the glory of God.

"For which cause we faint not; but though our outward man perish, yet the inward man is renewed day by day.

"For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory," 2 Cor. 4:7-17.

In verse seven Paul presents two contrasting subjects: "this treasure in earthen vessels..."

A. The Earthen Vessels. These are "earthen ware, like made of clay."[59] At best they are fragile, breakable, easily chipped, and readily marred. They are called vessels, "implement of any kind, utensil, instrument; (‘hence, in plural it denotes' all that belongs to a complete outfit; movables ‘as opposed to fixtures.’)”[60] Saul of Tarsus was called, "...a chosen *vessel* unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel:

"For I will shew him how great things he must suffer for my name's sake," Acts 9:15,16.

Human weakness is readily personified in Paul's use of "earthen vessels."

B. This treasure

A treasure, "thesauros, anything laid up in store; `hence,' treasure, wealth."[61]

What is this treasure that we have in earthen vessels? The context offers help as we look back at verse 1, "Therefore seeing we have *this ministry,* as we have

[59] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, A Critical Lexicon and Concordance to the English and Greek Testament, The Lamp Press Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p. 242.
[60] Ibid, p.846.
[61] Ibid, p. 818.

received mercy, we faint not," 2 Cor. 4:1. "This ministry," is linked by the word "therefore" to chapter three. In 2 Cor. 3 there are notable subjects that could be part of the "ministry." In 3:3 we note, "Forasmuch as ye are manifestly declared to be the epistle of Christ *ministered* by us, written not with ink, but with the Spirit of the living God; not in tables of stone, but in fleshly tables of the heart."

In chapter three the following passages indicate: "a new testament," a "ministration of the spirit," a "ministration of righteousness," and an ascending "glory" were part of "this ministry" of 4:1:

- 2 Cor. 3:6, "Who also hath made us *able ministers of the new testament;* not of the letter, but of the spirit: for the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life."
- 2 Cor. 3:8, "How shall not the *ministration of the spirit* be rather glorious?"
- 2 Cor. 3:9, "...much more doth the *ministration of righteousness* exceed in glory..."
- 2 Cor. 3:18 "...are changed into the same image from *glory to glory* even as by the Spirit of the Lord."

Moving therefore into chapter four in quest of "this treasure," (which is "this ministry" of 4:1) we note two complementary terms are added: "the word of God," and "the truth," "But have renounced the hidden things of dishonesty, not walking in craftiness, nor handling *the word of God* deceitfully; but by manifestation of *the truth* commending ourselves to every man's conscience in the sight of God," 2 Cor. 4:2. "This treasure" now is called "this ministry." It is further called "the word of God," and the "manifestation of the truth." In verses 3-6 of chapter four, additional descriptives are added, "our gospel," 2 Cor. 4:3; "...the glorious gospel of Christ," 2 Cor. 4:4; "...Christ Jesus the Lord," 2 Cor. 4:5; and "the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ," 2 Cor. 4:6.

We have returned to our starting text, 2 Cor. 4:7, "But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us." "This treasure" is that composite truth of the Lord Jesus Christ as centered in Paul's gospel and administered by the Spirit in each believer today. This is true wealth and is contained in earthen vessels. This is where the suffering comes into play. There seems to be a certain tension experienced because this treasure has been placed in such frail containers. It is our earthen vessel which detracts from the treasure.

Our experience frequently sees all earthen vessel, and no treasure! Had we designed this ministry, we surely would have eliminated the earthen vessel. However. God placed this sacred treasure in these earthenware containers for a special purpose, "...that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us," 2 Cor. 4:7b.

This "treasure-earthen vessel" concept is illustrated in 2 Cor. 4:11, "For we which live are alway delivered unto death for Jesus' sake, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our mortal flesh."

Paul saw the believer (and himself included) "alway delivered unto death for Jesus' sake." This is a display of our weakness, frailty, and testing. Death, even here, is not a pleasant experience. But in this crucible, Paul saw equally "the life also of Jesus ...made manifest in our mortal flesh." Jesus' perfect performance of the Father's will in human flesh is demonstrated in believers as we also are delivered unto death for His sake'. These references to "Jesus" (His earthly name) remind believers today of Christ's complete obedience to the will of His Father, "And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross," Phil. 2:8.

Twice in Second Corinthians chapter four Paul says "we faint not," once in 4:1 and again in 4:16: "For which cause *we faint not;* but though our outward man perish, yet the inward man is renewed day by day." "We faint not" even though a part of us is perishing, another part is renewed day by day. This speaks of the tension between the earthen vessel and the treasure.

C. The Reward Involved

Paul's attention is fixed upon something productive, "For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory," 2 Cor. 4:17. This "far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory," is being constantly produced by the light affliction. In other words, present sufferings are contributing to the coming rewards. Therefore Paul said, "For which cause we faint not," 2 Cor. 4:16.

Sufferings, at best, are for a moment, "parautika, at this very instant, momentary, the briefest duration, transient."[62] All the while they are working, "katergazomai, to work down, effect, achieve."[63]

II. VOLUNTARY SUFFERINGS AND GLORY: PAUL'S TEACHING

"And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with him, that we may be also glorified together," Rom. 8:17.

Here, Paul established the legitimacy of the believer. He argued: If believers are children of God (and they are), it follows that they are heirs. The word "heir" is "kleronomos, receiving a portion, especially, f. an inheritance;.. he who has the inheritance, `the stress being laid on the possession."[64] The child of God is not only an heir, but a joint-heir with Christ. "Joint heirs. Roman law made all children, including adopted ones, equal inheritors. Jewish law gave double portion to the eldest son. The Roman Law was naturally in Paul's mind, and suits the context, where adoption is the basis of inheritance."[65]

"In law there is a difference between an heir and a joint-heir. The. distinction can be explained as follows. If a man dies, leaving a large farm to four heirs, the estate is divided evenly and each heir receives twenty-five per cent of the whole. But if the

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[62] Ibid, p.504.
[63] Ibid., p.899.
[64] Ibid., p.367.
[65] Marvin R. Vincent, D.D., Word Studies in the New Testament, Vol. III, New York, Charles Scribner's Sons, 1901, p. 92.

man leaves a farm to four of his sons as joint-heirs, then each son owns the whole farm ...In human divisions such a procedure might be undesirable because it would be possible for brothers to quarrel over the inheritance, but in divine procedure it is perfect, for we shall all be like the Lord Jesus Christ, and each will be seeking the good of others before his own good."[66]

The conditional use of "if" in Rom. 8:17a, demonstrated the condition as fulfilled. "If children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ," Rom. 8:17a.

In the latter half of Rom. 8:17 Paul used a different word for "if," "The phrase `if so be that' is a single Greek word *eiper* and is used six times in the New Testament. If we examine each of these, we will see that it is not a phrase implying doubt."[67]

The six references to *eiper* in the New Testament are here listed:

1. Rom. 8:9, "But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, *if so be that* the Spirit if God dwell in you..."

2. Rom. 8:17, "And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ; *if so be that* we suffer with him, that we may be also glorified together."

3. 1 Cor. 8:5, "For though there be that are called gods, whether in heaven or in earth, *(as there be* gods many, and lords many.)"

4. 1 Cor. 15:15, "Yea, and we are found false witnesses of God; because we have testified of God that he raised up Christ: whom he raised not up, if *so be* that the dead rise not."

5. 2 Thess. 1:6, *"Seeing it* is a righteous thing with God to recompense tribulation to them that trouble you."

6. 1 Pet. 2:3, "*If so be* ye have tasted that the Lord is gracious."

Paul's use of *eiper* in Rom. 8:17 demonstrated no doubt that those joint-suffering would be joint-glorified also. The pronoun "him" in 8:17, has been supplied by the translators. This is probably taken by the translators from the phrase "and joint heirs *with Christ"* used in the first part of the verse. Suffering with Christ is the condition for being glorified together with Him.

Barnhouse does not see in Rom. 8:17, "voluntary suffering," rather he calls it "sympathetic suffering,"

"These sufferings are not the ordinary sufferings of this life ...The word that is translated *suffer with* (sumpascho) is found but twice in the New Testament, here and in a passage in Corinthians (1 Cor. 12:26). The context shows that the human body consists of many members, hands, feet, eyes, ears, and so on. In like manner the body of Christ is not one member, but many. After setting this forth, he concludes, ‘And whether one member suffer, all members suffer with it.' (v. 26). The last phrase includes our word, *suffer with.* It is very important to note that this suffering is not voluntary suffering. This is not a suffering which we choose to

[66] Donald Grey Barnhouse, Romans, Vol. 3, Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., Grand Rapids, ML, 1991 p. 113.
[67] Ibid, p. 117.

undergo - through surrender, or through living in such a way that we will draw upon ourselves the hatred of the world. This is the sympathetic suffering which comes because of the oneness which we have with all the body. If we have a hurt foot, we may have a headache from the pain of the foot...

"The suffering is to terminate in glory, the enduring is to terminate in reigning (2 Tim. 2:12)."[68]

There is much with which to concur in this quote from Dr. Barnhouse. It is his major premise that does not fit the Rom. 8:17 and 2 Tim. 2:12 texts. He assumes that the meaning of *suffer with* (Greek, sumpascho) in 1 Cor. 12:26 is identical with Rom. 8:17. "And whether one member suffer [pascho], all the mernbers *suffer with* [sumpascho] it; or one member be honoured, all the members rejoice with it," I Cor. 12:2b.

The Corinthian (12:26) text deals with the corporate body as it is interrelated and responds sympathetically to hurt, as well as to honor. The Romans (8:17) text affirms that believers suffering with (Him) will then also be glorified together with (Him).

Barnhouse holds that the "glorified together" of Rom. 8:17 is identical with the "reigning with him" of 2 Tim. 2:12, "If we suffer, we shall also *reign with him..."* He does not see "suffering" in these texts as "voluntary ...which we choose to undergo through surrender..."[69]

The 2 Tim. 2:12 text will be dealt with in Roman Numeral III, of this Chapter. This text plainly shows that reigning with Christ is reserved only for believers voluntarily suffering with Christ.

There is a general glory to which the church is destined:

- "For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us," Rom. 8:18.
- "So also is the resurrection of the dead ...It is sown in dishonour; it is raised in glory..." 1 Cor. 15:42,43.
- "When Christ, who is our life, shall appear, then shall ye also appear with him in glory," Col. 3:4.

There is also, a special "glorification together with [him]" reserved for those choosing to "suffer with" Christ. This is the teaching of Rom. 8:17. Paul's life illustrated this voluntary aspect of suffering for Christ's sake:

1. "Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses *for Christ's sake:* for when I am weak, then am I strong," 2 Cor. 12:10.

Notice here the preposition "in." If one is "in" something, he is surrounded by it - it is: over him, under him, before him, and behind him. Thus was Paul "in" these things. Observe also, that the "infirmities, reproaches, necessities, persecutions, and distresses" are all plural. Paul welcomed these "for Christ's sake."

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[68] Ibid., p. 119-120.
[69] Ibid. p. 119-120.

2. "For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to *suffer for his sake;* Having the same conflict which ye saw in me, and now hear to be in me," Phil. 1:29,30.

This translates into ministerial sufferings as these Philippians duplicated Paul's personal example.

3. "That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection, and the fellowship of his sufferings, being made conformable unto his death; If by any means I might attain unto the resurrection of the dead," Phil. 3:10,11.

In the same context Paul wrote, "I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus," Phil. 3:14.

III. SUFFERING IN ORDER TO REIGN WITH CHRIST

"Wherein I suffer trouble, as an evil doer, even unto bonds; but the word of God is not bound.

"Therefore I endure all things for the elect's sakes, that they may also obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus with eternal glory.

"It is a faithful saying: For if we be dead with him, we shall also live with him:

"If we suffer, we shall also reign with him: if we deny him, he also will deny us:

"If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself," 2 Tim. 2:9-13.

Second Timothy chapter two begins, "Thou therefore, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus," 2:1.

The suffering of 2 Tim. 2:12, demands the strength of grace in 2:1. Observe from 2:1 the following:

- The believer is not automatically strong in this grace. If he were, Paul's words were superfluous.
- The verb "be strong" is in the present tense imperative; therefore it is a command to be continuously obeyed.
- The context demonstrates how the believer must, enabled by the strength of this grace, be a faithful workman.

A. Paul's gospel - The Reason for his Sufferings

Paul opened this second letter to Timothy with a plea, "Be not thou therefore ashamed of the testimony of the Lord, nor of me his prisoner: but be thou partaker of the afflictions of the gospel according to the power of God," 2 Tim. 1:8. If Timothy needed these words, how much more does the church today? Paul did not ask anything of Timothy here, that he didn't practice himself, see 2:9ff.

This expression "the testimony of the Lord ...me his prisoner" fits what Paul calls in 2:8, "my gospel." As in 1:8 there were "afflictions of the gospel" so Paul "suffer(ed) as an evil doer," in 2:9.

Dear reader, what do you understand "Paul's gospel" to be? If you cannot define it, if you see no significant meaning to it, how then will you willingly be a "partaker of the afflictions" thereof? And if you do not suffer for it, how can you expect to reign with Christ according to 2 Tim. 2:12?

The context here builds upon "Paul's gospel" and the need to faithfully stand for it as did the Apostle. Timothy was reminded of those who renounced Paul and his gospel, "This thou knowest, that all they which are in Asia be turned away from me..." 2 Tim. 1:15. These refused to "partake of the afflictions of the [Paul's] gospel." They chose not to suffer, and forsook Paul. Therefore, in context (2:12) these will not reign with Christ, either.

There was one believer (1:16) whom Paul commended. He was commended for not being "ashamed of my chain." This is what Paul advocated in 1:8. Paul was certain Onesiphorus would be a candidate for a crown for such faithful service, "The Lord grant unto him that he may find mercy of the Lord *in that day:* and in how many things he ministered unto me at Ephesus, thou knowest very well," 2 Tim. 1:18.

B. Paul suffered and endured..

Did Paul volunteer to suffer for the word of God? "Wherein I suffer trouble, as an evil doer, even unto bonds; but the word of God is not bound," 2 Tim. 2:9. We have our answer. Paul's "my gospel" (2:8) is called in 2:9 "the word of God." He called these two, "the faith" in 2 Tim. 4:7. He willingly preserved this gospel even in the face of suffering.

The word of God (i.e. Paul's gospel, here) is not bound, it was free and liberating. But those (like Paul) who choose to "partake in the afflictions of the gospel" will suffer. This suffering identifies one with Christ and results in reigning with Him. The Bema of Christ will determine this.

What might be the "all things" that Paul suffered in 2:10? Surely the "trouble" and "bonds" were part of what he endured. The word "endured" in 2:10, is the same word in 2:12 which is translated, "suffer."

C. Paul suffered ...and shall reign with Christ

A faithful saying is something worth believing. Paul set forth this faithful saying, "...For if we be dead with him, we shall also live with him," 2 Tim. 2:11. The grammar here indicates that the condition ("if') is fulfilled. There is no doubt whatsoever; all is certainty. The past: "be dead with him" assures the future certainty: "shall also live with him."

What is necessary (from 2:12) for believers to "reign with him" (Christ)? In order to reign with Christ, the believer must suffer with Him. The condition ("If") is also fulfilled. Its a certain fact: to suffer, is to reign.

How can a believer "deny him?" The word "deny" is translated: "refuse" in Heb. 11:24. Believers may "deny Christ" by refusing to suffer with Him. This suffering has been shown in Second Timothy chapter one and two: to mean partaking of the

"afflictions of the [Paul's] gospel." If the believer refuses these sufferings he is, in effect, denying Christ!

If the believer denies Christ, Christ will deny him the reward of reigning with Himself. If believers do not accept this fact, "If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself," 2 Tim. 2:13. Our unbelief here cannot nullify God's pledged truth. God has said: "If we suffer, we shall also reign with him." If we refuse to suffer, we have therefore chosen not to reign with Christ.

It needs to be said, that "reigning" here is placed before the believer as a reward. All members of the Church, Christ's body, will be forever with the Lord, "Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord," 1 Thess. 4:17. However, only those who suffer with Christ will reign with Him. The Judgment Seat of Christ will make present suffering with Christ, well worth it all.

WHEN WE SEE CHRIST

Oft-times the day seems long
Our trials hard to bear,
We're tempted to complain,
to murmur and despair;
But Christ will soon appear
to catch His *Bride away,
All tears for-ever over
In God's eternal day.
CHORUS: It will be worth it all
When we see Jesus,
Life's trials will seem so small
When we see Christ.
One glimpse of His dear face
All sorrow will erase.
So bravely run the race
Till we see Christ.
-Esther Kerr Rusthoi, 1909-1968[70]

[70] Great Hymns of the Faith; Singspiration, Inc. World Pub. Zondervan Pub. House, Grand Rapids, MI. 1969. *Your author prefers here the word "Church."

Chapter 12

How Attitudes Affect Rewards

Our English word "attitude" is defined by Webster, "1: the arrangement of the parts of the body or figure: POSTURE. 2: a position assumed for a specific purpose (a threatening ~). 3: a ballet position similar to the arabesque in which the raised leg is bent at the knee. 4: a: a mental position with regard to a fact or state. b: a feeling or emotion toward a fact or state. 7a: a negative or hostile state of mind. b: a cocky or arrogant manner."[71]

In seeking to define the word "attitude" it was my expectation to find a more concrete explanation. Somehow Webster didn't furnish me with a definition that lived up to my expectations. A few synonyms would have helped clarify the meaning. The more one ponders this word the more its obscurity becomes evident! We are not considering ballet so the physical position of one's leg is of no consequence. Our definition takes us into "a mental position," or "a feeling or emotion toward a fact or state." Therefore, "attitude" is a state of one's mind or manner.

Webster used the word POSTURE to define the word attitude. This relates to the "arrangement of the parts of the body or figure." Rather than the order of body parts, the POSTURE we'll consider here is more of a mind set.

The word "attitude" is not used in the Authorized Version of the Bible. Paul used various texts to instruct us in the totality of our service for Christ. These passages plainly illustrate a special mind set or manner that becomes our attitude and thereby relates to rewards at the Judgment Seat of Christ.

A sampling of these are offered here:

- "Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God," 1 Cor. 10:31.
- "Do all things without murmurings and disputings," Phil. 2:14.
- "And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men," Col. 3:23.

It is unlikely that we will discover a text from Paul that has not been previously used in our handling of the Judgment Seat of Christ. Many are the virtues that are commended to believers for our walk and life of service. All of these are intended to shape our attitudes. The following come to mind:

- Humility
- Diligence

[71] Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary, Tenth Edition; Merriam-Webster, Inc., Springfield, Mass. USA, 1993.

- Obedience
- Truthfulness
- Honesty, et al.

Three godly qualities are outstanding in Paul's writings as they shape and mold attitudes in our service for Christ. These three are: willingness, heart, and love.

I. THE MATTER OF THE WILL

"For if I do this thing *willingly, I* have a reward: but if against my will, a dispensation of the gospel is committed unto me," 1 Cor. 9:17.

Something weighed heavily on Paul. A responsibility had been entrusted to him and he could not take it lightly. In First Corinthians nine, Paul's Apostleship is defended against attack at Corinth. Paul points out that these Corinthian believers are his very apostolic seal, "If I be not an apostle unto others, yet doubtless I am to you: for the seal of mine apostleship are ye in the Lord," 1 Cor. 9:2.

Paul had sown spiritual seed in these hearts at Corinth and had a legitimate right to reap their carnal (even monetary) things. This sowing and reaping, is a fitting illustration of the rewards receivable at Christ's Bema.

As Paul progresses in this chapter he uses the term "gospel" as representative of his authority and the focused responsibility he carried. Notice in:

9:12 "...but suffer all things, lest we should hinder *the gospel* of Christ."

9:14 "Even so hath the Lord ordained that they which *preach the gospel* should live of *the gospel."*

9:16 "For though *I preach the gospel ...*if *I* preach not *the gospel!"*

9:18 "What is my reward then? Verily that, when I *preach the* gospel, I may make *the gospel of Christ* without charge, *that I abuse not my power in the gospel."*

From 9:18, Paul plainly evidences his special "power" (lit. ability to perform, capability) in the gospel. He sees himself as the steward (1 Cor. 4:1,2) faithfully discharging the orders of his master. To Timothy he wrote, "According to *the glorious gospel* of the blessed God, *which was committed to my trust,"* 1 Tim. 1:11. The word "committed," in 1 Tim. 1:11 and 1 Cor. 9:17, is the verb form of the noun "faith:" "pisteuo, to believe, rely upon, trust, put confidence in.[72] Paul took seriously this responsibility. To him was committed a "dispensation:" "oikonomia, administration of a household, actively the administrative activity of the owner or the steward; passively, that which is administered. (Eng. economy) i.e., a disposition or arrangement of things, a scheme or dispensation, (occ. Luke 16:2,3,4)."[73]

[72] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon And Concordance to the English And Greek Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p. 171.
[73] Ibid, p. 228.

TWO POSSIBILITIES

Paul could discharge this dispensation committed to him willingly or he could set his will against it. To do it willingly meant to be in full agreement and with a voluntary attitude. The main requirement was to be willing and that attitude would produce reward. Paul saw himself under constraint to preach the gospel, "For though I preach the gospel, I have nothing to glory of: *for necessity is laid upon me;* yea, *woe is unto me,* if I preach not the gospel," 1 Cor. 9:16. Just when might Paul experience this "woe" if he did not willingly preach the gospel nor willingly and faithfully discharge the dispensation? The Judgment Seat of Christ was obviously in Paul's mind as to when this loss of reward would be experienced.

Sometimes grace believers mistakenly contend that there are no demands nor compulsions placed on us today under grace. Paul clearly shows the opposite to have been his experience. But let's re-think the "mistaken contention" cited here. There can be an experience for believers free from these demands and necessities as were exhibited in Paul's life. Yes, such a path and walk is available under grace today! But, one thing is also certain, if the believer follows that line of least resistance, he is assured zero rewards! Remember Paul's words, "If we suffer, we shall also reign with him..," 2 Tim. 2:12.

Paul deals with the possibility of being unwilling in this dispensation committed to him. What happens if the apostle were to be unwilling in this commitment? He says "...a dispensation of the gospel is committed unto me." That doesn't sound like Paul was released from his responsibility. In fact, it actually means nothing has been changed! God is saying, in effect, "Paul, you may choose to be unwilling; you may refuse to volunteer and thus not be in full agreement here - but it really doesn't change anything!" It is patently evident here that Paul did not consider this latter option. Each member of the church, Christ's body, is indebted to this apostle who willingly discharged his God-committed dispensation.

Paul saw his reward in, "...that, when I preach the gospel, I may *make the gospel of Christ without charge,* that I abuse not my power in the gospel," 1 Cor. 9:18. He desired, above all, to pass along this gospel "without charge:" "adapanos, without expense, and so costing nothing."[74] Paul placed no hurdle nor barrier before those who would preach his gospel. His voluntary and willing attitude was intended to go beyond what was required, not to fail to fully carry out the dispensation of God.

II. A MATTER OF THE HEART

"Every man according *(as he purposeth in his heart,* so let him give; not grudgingly, or of necessity: for God loveth a cheerful giver," 2 Cor. 9:7.

Another godly quality that shapes our attitude is the *heart.* Note what the Greek word *kardia* means: "as the corporeal organ of the body, it is the seat of life, which chiefly and finally participates in all its movements. Also as the seat and center of man's personal life, in which the distinctive character of the human manifests itself. Hence the significance of the heart is the starting point of the developments and

[74] Ibid, p. 144.

manifestations of personal life, as well as the organ of their concentration and outgo."[75]

It is in the context of giving that Second Corinthians eight and nine were written. Giving, is an ideal topic to consider in the matter of rewards at the Judgment Seat of Christ. In 2 Cor. 9:6 Paul wrote about sowing and reaping. These are figures of speech that illustrate the ministry of giving. In fact, the actual point made here is that the degree that one sows will determine the extent that he reaps. This will all focus for the believer at the Bema of Christ. Reaping, then, is just another term for reward(s).

This matter of giving begins in the heart. Paul said it thus, "according as he purposeth in his heart, so let him give," 2 Cor. 9:7. The heart becomes the starting point if one's ministry of giving is to please the Lord. The word "purposeth" (proaireo) here means: "to take forth out of any place, to take one thing before another, prefer, choose. In N.T. mid., to purpose or prefer to one's self."[76] Surely whatever is purposed in the heart has been deliberated. Two negatives are added over which the heart-purposed giving must pass. They are: "not grudgingly, or of necessity." It is possible to have a *grudging* attitude, i.e., "one out of sorrow." This is a heart attitude of choice. There also may be a heart attitude of "necessity," i.e., "necessity arising from constraint." Neither of these two attitudes will produce rewards at the Bema of Christ. When both "grudgingly," and "of necessity," have been eliminated, a "cheerful giver" results! It is this "cheerful giver" that God loves. It is also the "cheerful giver" who will be rewarded at the Judgment Seat of Christ.

This heart attitude is seen also in Eph. 6:5, "Servants, be obedient to them that are your masters according to the flesh, with fear and trembling, *in singleness of your heart,* as unto Christ." Here the heart is to be "single." The idea being "unfolded," as a length of cloth. When cloth is folded there exists the possibility in the folds that defects or imperfections could be hidden. The opposite of simplicity is not complexity, but duplicity. A "single heart" is thus required by Paul. All believers are servants of the Lord and should have this single heart attitude "as unto Christ," Eph. 6:5.

III. THE MATTER OF LOVE

God uses "charity" to shape the attitudes of believers.

"Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal.

"And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing.

"And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, *it profiteth me nothing,"* 1 Cor. 13.-1-3.

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[75] Ibid, p. 362.
[76] Ibid. p. 614.

In First Corinthians twelve, thirteen, and fourteen Paul is dealing with spiritual things, "Now concerning spiritual *gifts*, brethren. I would not have you ignorant," 1 Cor. 12:1. The word *gifts* has been supplied by the translators, as it is not in the original text. In chapter twelve Paul deals with:

1) spiritual *gifts* later called *signs (1* Cor. 14:21,22; and Rom. 15:18-20); eg: the word of wisdom; the word of knowledge; faith; healing; working of miracles; prophecy; discerning of spirits; divers kinds of tongues; interpretations of tongues, I Cor. 12:8-10; also Rom. 12:6b.

Also: Apostles, prophets, and miracles were added to the Church, 1 Cor. 12:28-30. These were shown to be temporary and were to cease (13:8-12) when the revelation given to Paul had been fully received, Eph. 2:20; Rom. 15:29.

2) spiritual gifts also utilized in the ministry but permanent in the Church:

- individual members of the Body of Christ Church, 1 Cor. 12:14-27
- teachers, helps, and governments, 1 Cor. 12:28a; also Rom. 12:4,5,7-9.

3) spiritual "abiders" (1 Cor. 12:31; 13:13, "faith, hope, charity [love]"

The greatest of this "abiding trinity" (1 Cor. 13:13) is love; therefore Paul concluded chapter thirteen.

The three opening verses of First Corinthians thirteen show the importance of love in one's attitude.

If these sign gifts of 1 Cor. 13:1-3 were practiced (in the Acts period) and love was absent, Paul plainly shows the result would be emptiness.

In 13:1, Paul shows how "the gift of tongues" appears without love. It is just so much "noise pollution!"

In 13:2, Paul continues this hypothetical illustration by including the gifts of prophecy, understanding, and all faith. Were Paul to practice these without love, he was nothing! In other words, there could be no positive value or gain by Paul for such service. How can such spiritual activity produce nothing? The answer: it produces nothing because of the absence of the necessary ingredient - love.

In 13:3, we have a reference to the Judgment Seat of Christ. Here, great benevolence is hypothesized by Paul. Think of giving *all* of one's goods to feed the poor! and besides this, becoming a martyr! Even actions which *seem* to *demonstrate* love are nothing without *love.* Paul's words of accountability are piercing, "and have not charity [love], it *profiteth me nothing,"* 1 Cor. 13:3b. According to this scenario, when would Paul have expected to receive profit from these good works? At the Judgment Seat of Christ. And so, when would he have profited "nothing" but at the Judgment Seat of Christ?

For over nineteen hundred years the Church has been the recipient of that fullness of Pauline truth he anticipated in 1 Cor. 13:10-12; cf Rom. 15:29. Are we to conclude that love is no longer the greatest of that abiding trinity of 1 Cor. 13:13?

"Three time periods are in view in 1 Cor. 13. There is a time when the miraculous gifts are in the church and so also are Faith, Hope, and Love. There is a second period when they have been done away and only Faith, Hope, and Love remain. At the rapture, however, Faith becomes sight (Heb. 11:1), Hope becomes realization (Rom. 8:24), and only Love remains (1 Cor. 13:8). This is why Love is the greatest of the three (since DURATION IN TIME is the characteristic that is in view in this section). The removal of the miraculous gifts cannot come at the rapture, or there would never be a time when Faith, Hope and Love would be present with the miraculous gifts missing. They must disappear at a previous time. The first time period above is from the beginning of the Body of Christ until its maturity at the completion of the Pauline revelation: the second is from then until the rapture: the third extends from the rapture on into eternity. 'LOVE NEVER faileth."[77]

Paul prayed for the Philippians, "...that your love may abound yet more and more in knowledge and in all judgment," Phil. 1:9. Love transcends human emotion and earthly feeling. Love is to increase in knowledge and all judgment. This quality is only produced by the Holy Spirit. Love is intended to shape our attitude as we serve the Lord Christ.

[77] William P.Heath, Help In Hard Places, Things To Come Mission, Inc., P.O. Box 617, Cebu City, Philippines, 1984, pp. 151-152.

Chapter 13

"We Must All Appear"

It is my firm belief that the Judgment Seat of Christ (Bema) is given insufficient emphasis in the believer's life today. One Pastor has called the Judgment Seat of Christ, "the Lost Chord of the church." The next time you visit a Christian Book Store ask the clerk if they have in stock any books about the Judgment Seat of Christ. You will find, as I have, that books on that theme just are not on the shelf. Another factor which compounds the problem is that the clerk himself might not know what the Judgment Seat of Christ is!

My own personal experience attests to a lack of emphasis of this doctrine. The subject of rewards for the believer's faithful service is a prominent teaching in Paul's letters to the church. It deserves our diligent study and therefore our faithful obedience.

The passage under consideration here will be 2 Cor. 5:1-11:

"For we know that if our earthly house of this tabernacle were dissolved, we have a building of God, an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.

"For in this we groan, earnestly desiring to be clothed upon with our house which is from heaven:

"If so be that being clothed we shall not be found naked.

"For we that are in this tabernacle do groan, being burdened: not for that we would be unclothed, but clothed upon, that mortality might be swallowed up of life.

"Now he that hath wrought us for the selfsame thing is God, who also hath given unto us the earnest of the Spirit.

"Therefore we are always confident, knowing that, whilst we are at home in the body, we are absent from the Lord:

("For we walk by faith, not by sight:)

"We are confident, I say, and willing rather to be absent from the body, and to be present with the Lord.

"Wherefore we labour, that, whether present or absent, we may be accepted of him.

"For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad.

"Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men; but we are made manifest unto God; and I trust also are made manifest in your consciences."

In 2 Cor. 5:10, the Greek word "must" is "dei:" "it needs, there is need of `some thing absent or wanting;' it needs, it is necessary, one must, it ought."[78]

"The presence of this impersonal verb dei, leaves no room for doubt ...Paul literally tells us, 'for it is necessary that we all be revealed before the judgment seat of Christ.' There is no doubt.

"Furthermore, we are assured that we shall all stand (parastesometha) before the judgment seat of Christ (Rom. 14:10), and that 'every one of us shall give account (logon dosei) of himself to God, (Rom. 14:12). Both of these future active verbs give the distinct impression that nothing will prohibit the evaluation of our deeds. Standing before the Bema of Christ is an event which is not only universal in nature. It is necessary that our service for Him be evaluated in keeping with God's holiness and justice. All believers must stand before Jesus Christ the Judge."[79]

The context of 2 Cor. 5:10, offers three reasons why "we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ."

I. REASON #1 BECAUSE GOD HAS WROUGHT US FOR THIS PURPOSE

"Now he that hath wrought us for the selfsame thing is God, who also hath given unto us the earnest of the Spirit," 2 Cor. 5:5.

Chapter five of Second Corinthians opens (v. 1) with Paul talking about two different "houses," "For we know that if our earthly house of this tabernacle [house #1] were dissolved, we have a building of God [house #2], an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens," 2 Cor. 5:1.

The possibility exists of "house #1" being dissolved, "kataluo, to loosen down, dis-unite (the parts of anything), destroy."[80] The point Paul makes is that when our earthly body dies the believer has a body eternal in the heavens awaiting him. While in our present body (house #1) we groan desiring (present tense) to be clothed upon by our heavenly body (house #2).

In verses three and four Paul presents the conditions of being "found naked" and being "clothed upon." He was "burdened," not to be unclothed, i.e. found naked, which takes place at physical death. But rather 11e desired to be "clothed upon, that mortality might be swallowed up of life," 5:4. Paul didn't desire physical death, instead he expected the Rapture return of Christ when believers receive their heavenly bodies in resurrection glory.

"For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: *and the dead in Christ shall rise first:*

"Then *we which are alive and remain* shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord," 1 Thess. 4:16,17.

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[78] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon And Concordance To The English And Greek Testament, The Lamp Press, Ltd., London, Eighth Edition 1957, p. 512.
[79] Woodrow Michael Kroll, Tested By Fire, Loizeaux Brothers, Neptune, New Jersey, 1977, p. 48.
[80] Op.Cit. Bullinger, p. 229.

This is confirmed in 1 Cor. 15:51-53, "Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed,

"In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we [i.e. the living] shall be changed.

"For this corruptible [i.e. the dead bodies] must [dei] put on incorruption [i.e. the body from heaven of 2 Con 5:1-4], and this mortal [those alive at the Rapture] must put on immortality [i.e. the body from heaven of 2 Cor. 5:1-4]."

Paul offers special assurance to the believer in two areas: first, "he that hath wrought us for the selfsame thing is God." The believer's heavenly, eternal, "house" is no accident nor afterthought. The word "wrought" here means: "work down, effect, achieve," and is used in 2 Cor. *4:17, "worketh* for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory." The second assurance granted believers here is the "earnest of the Spirit," the Holy Spirit Himself is the guarantee that the believer's body of glory will be possessed.

Therefore, the believer is "always confident:" "tharrheo, to be of good cheer; to have good courage; to be full of hope and confidence."[81] Even when we believers are in this earthly body, which is "home" for now, we are absent from the Lord. Although absent from the Lord, we possess the indwelling Holy Spirit and the confidence from the Word of God in these verses. Thus, it is that "we walk by faith," in dependence upon God's written Word. We do not conduct our daily walk by mere externals.

Paul gives the believer a "double confidence," as it were. In 2 Cor. 5:6, he speaks of "always confident," and in v. 8, he mentions being "confident." The believer possesses strong assurance which makes him willing to be bodiless (i.e. "naked," or "unclothed,") while being present with the Lord. Death does not rob the believer of this confidence.

II. REASON #2 BECAUSE BELIEVERS LABOR TO BE ACCEPTED AT THIS BEMA

"Wherefore we labour, that, whether present or absent, we may be accepted of him," 2 Cor. 5:9. As a direct result of Paul's teaching in verses 1-8 he concludes, "we labour." The word labor is most interesting, "philotimeomai, to be ambitious of doing anything, to exert oneself (from love of honor) to make it a point of honor (to do anything)."[82] This word is only found two other times in the New Testament:

- Rom. 15:20, "Yea, so have I *strived* to preach the gospel, not where Christ was named, lest I should build upon another man's foundation."
- 1 Thess. 4:11, "And that ye *study* to be quiet, and to do your own business, and to work with your own hands, as we commanded you."

[81] Op.Cit. Bullinger, p. 179.
[82] Op.Cit. Bullinger, p. 438.

What a noble word for labor - "love of honor." Surely this is designed to elevate the quality of our service for the Lord. Here, then, is a tranquil energy expended in place of excited, un-quiet, bustle! This word *labor* ("love of honor") dignifies the work of the believer by keeping before him that appointed Judgment Seat of Christ.

There is a stated purpose for this labor: "to be accepted of him." The motivation to labor and serve is to be well pleasing to Him. Remember how we loved to have the commendation of our parents. The more special a person is to us, the more we value that one's commendation. Think what it will be to have the very commendation of our Lord Jesus Christ! This *acceptance* does not deal with our position in Christ, which is perfect and cannot improve. However, our service ("labour" of 5:9) which necessitates our appearance at the Judgment Seat of Christ, may earn His approval or disapproval.

Our text presents Paul's viewpoint (2 Cor. 5:1-9) both before he mentions the Bema of Christ (i.e. in S:10) and after it is called to our attention (vs. l 1-13). In both passages he appeals to "knowledge." Before "the Bema" text (5:5-9) Paul shows double confidence (5:6,8), he walks by faith (5:7), and he labors for acceptance (5:9). Paul shows no cringing fear nor a haughty flippancy either. He evidences a settled spiritual awareness as he lives and serves with assurance.

Then, see Paul's remarks in 5:11-13 (after the Bema text of 5:10). Here he *knows* the terror (fear) of the Lord. He is sobered to know that he will appear before THE LORD. He anticipates Christ's righteous evaluation of the things done in his body. How does this affect Paul? Hear his response: "we persuade men." This is part of his "labouring to be accepted [i.e. well pleasing]" in 5:9. Paul claims to be manifest (transparent) before God. This he will be at the Judgment Seat of Christ. He claims to be transparent also before these Corinthians.

"And knowing the terror of the Lord, we shall persuade men. Thus Paul (it is conscience in view of that most solemn moment) possessed the righteousness which he saw in the Judge, for that which judged was His righteousness; but then he consequently seeks others earnestly, according to the work which had thus brought him near to God, to which he then turns (verses 13,14). But this view of judgment and our complete manifestation in that day, has a present effect on the saint according to its own nature. He realizes it by faith. He is manifested. He does not fear being manifested. It will unfold all God's past ways towards him when he is in glory; but he is manifested now to God, his conscience exercised in the light."[83]

III. REASON #3 BECAUSE THE LORD, THE RIGHTEOUS JUDGE, WILL BE THE REWARDER

"For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad," 2 Cor. 5:10.

Here is a divine appointment every member of Christ's Body Church has scheduled for him. The *appearance* which is here required is more than a token or

[83] J.N. Darby, Synopsis Of The Books Of The Bible, VOL.IV, Stow Hill Bible And Tract Depot 5, Fife Road, Kingston-On-Thames, 1949, p. 234.

fleeting appearing. The Greek word is, "Phaneroo, to make manifest, make apparent, show forth."[84] This same word is used twice in Col. 3:4, "When Christ, who is our life, *shall appear,* then *shall* ye also *appear* with him in glory." As Christ will be "manifested, shown forth, made apparent in glory," so shall the believer (at the same time) be "manifested, shown forth, and made apparent with him in glory." This will be the most important *appearance* the believer has ever experienced! This appearing is named The Judgment Seat (Bema) of Christ. It is obvious that this Bema is closely associated with Christ's Rapture return for His Church.

Therefore, those present at the Bema of Christ have just experienced the fullness of His (resurrection) life. Christ, being "our life" (Col. 3:4a), then will sit on His Bema and will judge the things believers have done in their bodies. It is important to remember that the believer stands before our Lord at this Judgment Seat in his glorified, resurrected body. This means that Christ's imputed fullness will be experienced and reflected by His Church there. No hindrance, opposition, nor flawed comprehension will be experienced by the Church as He judges the things we've done in our bodies. The believer will concur with and applaud every "good or bad" that Christ brings to light.

It is the *time* when "the Lord ...will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest [phaneroo] the counsels of the hearts: and *then shall every man have praise of God,"* 1 Cor. 4:5.

Every believer stands at the Bema with a perfect salvation in Christ. This salvation is exactly the same for all. Each believer stands there with a resurrection body of glory which does not essentially differ one from the other. The area of difference will be seen in the rewards received at the Bema of Christ. It is possible to over emphasize this spiritual identity and sameness that the Body of Christ Church mutually shares, obscuring the importance of proportionate and differing rewards. This inequity and imbalance of truth does not properly recognize Paul's teaching about rewards and the righteous judgment at Christ's Bema.

It deserves special note that the One before Whom the Church will appear, is called the Lord. It is this *Lordship* of Christ that believers acknowledge in their service to God:

- Rom. 14:8, "For whether we live, *we live unto the Lord;* and whether we die, we *die unto the Lord:* whether we live therefore, or die, *we are the Lord's."*
- 1 Cor. 4:5, "Therefore judge nothing before the time, until *the Lord come,* who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts: and then shall every man have praise of God."
- 2 Cor. 5:11, *"Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord,* we persuade men..."
- Gal. 6:17, "...for I bear in my body *the marks of the Lord Jesus..."*
- Eph. 5:10, "Proving [dokimazo] what is *acceptable unto the Lord."*

[84] Op.Cit., Bullinger, p. 59.

- Phil. 4:1, "Therefore, my brethren dearly beloved and longed for, my joy and crown, so *stand fast in the Lord,* my dearly beloved."
- Col. 3:24, "Knowing that *of the Lord ye shall receive the reward* of the inheritance: *for ye serve the Lord Christ."*
- 1 Thess. 1:6, "And ye *became followers of us, and of the Lord,* having received the word in much affliction, with joy of the Holy Ghost."
- 2 Thess. 3:16, "Now the *Lord of peace himself give you peace always* by all means. The *Lord be with you all."*
- 2 Tim. 2:24, "And the *servant of the Lord* must not strive; but be gentle unto all men, apt to teach, patient."
- Phe. :16, "Not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved, specially to me, but how much more unto thee, *both in the flesh, and in the Lord?"*

Paul further describes the Lord in 2 Tim. 4:8, "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, *the righteous judge,* shall give me at that day..." He foresaw a "crown of righteousness" awarded him by "the Lord, the righteous judge."

The 2 Cor. 5:10, passage sees believers receiving for "the things done in his body, whether it be good or bad." The things which are good will merit rewards or crowns. The "good" is equated with the "gold, silver, and precious stones" (of 1 Cor. 3:12), and the "crowns" (of 1 Cor. 9:25; Phil. 4:1; 1 Thess. 2:19 and 2 Tim. 4:8). But what is the "bad," in this text? Obviously, the "bad" or worthless, is the un-rewardable brought before the Bema of Christ. The un-rewardable works when brought to light at Christ's Bema do not measure up to the "fire" (of 1 Cor. 3:13) nor the "righteousness" (of 2 Tim. 4:8). Therefore, the "bad" becomes the "loss" (of 1 Cor 3:15) and is the "wrong" of Col. 3:25.

Therefore, Paul wrote, "we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ..." He included himself in this divine appointment. The context shows clear teaching and plain confidence. Ignorance is displaced and the faith walk is encouraged. God has spoken, let all believers "So run that they may obtain," 1 Cor. 9:24.

Chapter 14

"Are Un-rewardable Works, Sins?"

It is clear from Paul's letters that the Judgment Seat of Christ is the final accounting of all that the believer has done in his life from the time of his conversion until his death or the Rapture return of Christ, which ever occurs first. Only believers will stand before Christ to have their works judged at this Bema, "For we [Paul includes himself] must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad," 2 Cor. 5:10.

It is God's desire to issue crowns, prizes, and rewards at this Bema of Christ. These will be given to those who faithfully have served the Lord, "And if a man also strive for masteries, yet is he not crowned, except he strive lawfully," 2 Tim. 2:5.

We have made the point that it is not our salvation in Christ that will be judged, at Christ's Bema. This salvation is eternal in Christ and cannot be diminished nor increased. Positionally in Christ, every member of the Body of Christ church is equally redeemed and "blessed ...with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ," Eph. 1:3. It is only in the area of our walk and service for Christ that proportionate rewards will be determined at the Judgment Seat of Christ. It must also be noted that some works by believers will go un-rewarded.

It is time we face the issue before us - Are Un-rewarded Works Sins? The following questions ask the same thing:

- Is "loss" at Christ's Bema caused by sins?
- If believers have been forgiven all sins (Col. 1: 14 and 2:13), and if we suffer loss at the Bema of Christ for un-rewardable works, does this indicate we were not really forgiven these sins?
- If un-rewardable works are not sins where did they fit into the believer's life, in the sphere of the flesh? or Spirit?
- What is the difference between un-rewardable works (which will be burned at the Bema of Christ) and the sins for which Christ died and for which we've been forgiven?
- Is it possible that un-rewardable works were performed in the Spirit?
- Are the works of "wood, hay, and stubble" (1 Cor. 3:12-15), anything but sins in the life of the believer?

Since these un-rewardable works do not bring punishment nor wrath at Christ's Bema, it might be assumed by some that they are less than sins. Others might reason that these works are considered neutral - neither "good" nor "bad." They are not good enough to be rewarded nor are they bad enough to be sinful, therefore they conclude, they are just cast off as un-rewardable. But Paul does not use "neutral" words to describe these un-rewardable works. Anything that is un-rewardable by the Lord, the righteous Judge, must be classified as sinful.

Just as the believer operates in either one of two spheres (i.e. flesh, or Spirit) in his walk, so his works are aligned with one of these. If his works are produced by the flesh there cannot be any good thing realized, "For I know that in me (that is, in my flesh,) dwelleth no good thing..." Rom. 7:18. No reward will ever be given at Christ's Bema for works produced by the flesh. The flesh does not produce works of neutrality. The works of the flesh are sins.

The following facts will present an affirmative answer to the question: "Are Un-rewardable Works, Sins?"

I. UN-REWARDABLE WORKS ARE PRODUCTS OF THE FLESH - THEREFORE THEY ARE SINS

The flesh is that part of the believer:

- In which "dwelleth no good thing," Rom. 7:18
- "that ...cannot please God," Rom. 8:8.
- that "lusteth against the Spirit," Gal. 5:17, and is contrary thereto.

Paul attributed nothing good to his flesh, "For I know that in me (that is, in my flesh,) dwelleth *no good thing:* for to will is present with me; but how to perform that which is *good* I find not. For the *good* that I would I do not: but the evil which I would not, that I do. Now if I do that I would not, it is not more I that do it, but sin that dwelleth in me," Rom. 7:18-20.

Paul saw two realms in which the Judgment Seat of Christ will determine the works of believers. These will be in the realm of "the good" or in the realm of "the bad." Since "good" cannot come from the flesh (one's sinful nature) it follows that the "bad" (worthless, un-rewardable) must come therefrom.

It is possible for the believer to sow to his flesh and then to reap therefrom, "Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap. For he that soweth to his flesh shall of the flesh reap corruption..." Gal. 6:7,8a. This sowing and reaping is used by Paul to teach the principle of Christ's coming Bema, "...but he that soweth to the Spirit shall of the Spirit reap life everlasting. And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not," Gal. 6:8b,9.

The flesh only produces a harvest of corruption: "phthora, a spoiling, corruption, destruction generally the bringing or being brought into a worse state."[85] The flesh is

[85] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., "A Critical Lexicon And Concordance To The English And Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p. 189.

the opposite of the Spirit (Gal. 5:17), and produces the opposite of the "eternal life" harvest of the Spirit.

Our Lord, while on earth, taught that "...the flesh profiteth nothing," John 6:63. Clearly, flesh works will be un-rewardable at Christ's Bema. There should be no hesitancy nor reservation about calling these un-rewardable works, sins!

II. UN-REWARDABLE WORKS ARE SINS

We will introduce a verse which bears on this matter and also has contextual ties to the Judgment Seat of Christ.

"And he that doubteth is damned if he eat, because he eateth not of faith: for whatsoever is not of faith is sin," Rom. 14:23.

Romans chapter fourteen deals with believers judging each other over relatively minor issues called "doubtful disputations." "Him that is weak in the faith receive ye, but not to *doubtful disputations,"* Rom. 14:1. Some of these "doubtful things" were *eating of all things, (14:2),* or *eating herbs, esteeming one day above another, (14:5),* or *esteeming every day alike.* This degenerated into criticism of each other's service and person. This prompted Paul to bring up the reason for the Bema of Christ, see 14:10 "But why dost thou judge thy brother? or why dost thou set at nought thy brother? for we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ ...So then every one of us shall give account of himself to God," Rom. 14:10,12.

These believers were not only majoring in minors (see 14:17,18), they were not fully persuaded and gave in to "doubtful disputations." So Paul lays it plainly on the table - "whatsoever is not of faith is sin," Rom. 14:23b.

According to Paul any "eating not of faith is sin." This "eating" in the Romans fourteen context is admittedly a minor matter. However, if these lesser matters are called "sins," would not all other unfaithful acts/works be equally sins? I believe they are.

Paul classifies un-rewardable works as follows:

- "burned ...loss" in 1 Cor. 3:15. It takes Christ to bring these things to light so they might be seen and judged for what they are: un-rewardable, and therefore sins!
- "the bad" in 2 Cor. 5:10. The word "bad" surely is connected with the flesh and sin. One would be hard pressed to associate "the bad" with the Spirit. Nor does this phrase "the bad," fit with a neutral consideration where the believer supposedly has some works that are neither good nor bad.
- "the wrong which he hath done," Col. 3:25. The Greek for "wrong" here is: "adikeo, to do wrong, to act not in conformity with `dike,' right, to be an adikos [i.e. unrighteous], and act like one."[86]

An honest evaluation of this list necessitates that un-rewardable works be considered sins.

[86] Ibid, p. 908.

III. UN-REWARDABLE WORKS ILLUSTRATED IN THE STORY OF JOSEPH

"Then Joseph could not refrain himself before all them that stood by him; and he cried, Cause every man to go out from me. And there stood no man with him, while Joseph made himself known unto his brethren.

"And he wept aloud: and the Egyptians and the house of Pharaoh heard.

"And Joseph said unto his brethren, I am Joseph; doth my father yet live? And his brethren could not answer him; for they were troubled at his presence.

"And Joseph said unto his brethren, Come near to me, I pray you. And they came near. And he said, I am Joseph your brother, whom ye sold into Egypt.

"Now therefore be not grieved, nor angry with yourselves, for ye sold me hither: for God did send me before you to preserve life.

"For these two years hath the famine been in the land: and yet there are five years, in the which there shall neither be earing nor harvest.

"And God sent me before you to preserve you a posterity in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance.

"So now it was not you that sent me hither, but God: and he hath made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.

"Haste ye, and go up to my father, and say unto him, Thus saith thy son Joseph, God hath made me lord of all Egypt: come down unto me, tarry not:

"And thou shalt dwell in the land of Goshen, and thou shalt be near unto me, thou, and thy children, and thy children's children, and thy flocks, and thy herds, and all that thou hast:

"And there will I nourish thee; for yet there are five years of famine; lest thou, and thy household, and all that thou hast, come to poverty.

"And, behold, your eyes see, and the eyes of my brother Benjamin, that it is my mouth that speaketh unto you.

"And ye shall tell my father of all my glory in Egypt, and of all that ye have seen; and ye shall haste and bring down my father hither.

"And he fell upon his brother Benjamin's neck, and wept; and Benjamin wept upon his neck.

"Moreover he kissed all his brethren, and wept upon them: and after that his brethren talked with him," Gen. 45:1-15.

A. Joseph Reveals Himself to His Brothers

This account from Genesis chapter forty-five provides some parallel matters with the Judgment Seat of Christ as found in Paul's letters. When using the word parallel it is important to understand that parallel things are not identical. There may be here as many un-parallel items as parallels. We will be as forthright as possible in using this text as a mere illustration of Christ's Bema and not making it identical thereto.

1. The brothers were not taken to a court of law. Joseph set the parameters of their meeting in Gen. 45:4 "I am Joseph your brother, whom ye sold into Egypt." This was a family matter and although there had been much wrong done against Joseph and guilt was on the brothers' consciences, the brothers would settle accounts within their own family.

At the Bema of Christ, all assembled will have known forgiveness of all their sins. The un-rewardable works (sins) of the Church all have been paid for by Christ's redemption on the Cross.

"The sins of our whole life are all considered, in the courtroom of heaven, as settled before the bar of justice in the light of the Cross, while the life of the believer as viewed at the Bema is a family affair before the Father. It is not legal justice in view at the Bema, but loving evaluation of service. When a son gets a speeding ticket he comes before the court. When he has paid the fine the case is legally over, but when he returns home he may have to hear a few wise words, and possibly endure some form of chastening from his father. The confrontation with his father is for his own good and will not send him to jail nor impose a fine. 'If ye endure chastening, *God dealeth with you as with sons;* for what son is he whom the father chasteneth not?' Hebrews 12:7. It is important, however, to realize that the chastening is taken care of in this life (or by a shortening of this life - I Cor. 11:30, `For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep'), not at the Bema. Chastening is not to `make us ready for heaven,'[87] but to refine us in our walk and ministry and protect our testimony before men down here - to make us ready for service."[88]

2. Joseph, although sinned against, did not punish his brothers.

Joseph's brothers were grieved and angry at their own deeds, see Gen. 45:5. Joseph embraced and kissed his erring brothers, Gen. 45:15.

Christ will not punish believers at His Bema. Once He suffered punishment for these very un-rewardable works. At His Bema, He will lovingly display his grace and kindness to His own.

B. The Sins of Jacob's Sons Will Be Accounted

1. The brothers had to face Joseph, realizing their sins.

At the Bema Christ the Righteous Judge will dispense a "crown of righteousness," 2 Tim. 4:8. It is before such an One, that we must be manifest (openly shine forth).

2. The brothers had to inform their father of Joseph's rule.

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[87] "The weakest and most wayward true believer is as `ready for heaven' as was Paul when he wrote Second Timothy. Neither is the Bema a judgment to make believers ready for heaven, for most of those at the Bema will have already been consciously in the presence of Christ in heaven for a long time - some for over 1,900 years - before the Bema takes place." Pastor William Heath, personal correspondence.

[88] Ibid.

"And ye shall tell my father of all my glory in Egypt," Gen. 45:13. Of course along with the story of Joseph, the brothers must include their account of evil against him. Believers at the Bema of Christ must be "manifested" which means they will openly acknowledge God's righteous judgment.

3. Joseph shows grace to those who sinned against him.

Joseph's selfless attitude healed the tattered relationships here. Our Lord at the Bema will display His grace anew. Surely if He loved the church and gave Himself for it on the Cross, how much more grace will He display at the Bema, "...Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it; That he might sanctify and cleanse it with the washing of water by the word, *That he rnight present it to himself a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that it should he holy and without blemish,"* Eph. 5:25-27. Surely this "presentation" completes the Bema of Christ, "...and then shall every man have praise of God," 1 Cor. 4:5.

Without doubt, all un-rewardable works at Christ's Bema are sins. Sins which we've committed, but sins forgiven by Christ's redemptive work on the Cross. These we must give account of (Rom. 14:12), before our Lord, the righteous judge (2 Tim. 4:8).

One final verse applies here as the Church stands at this Judgment Seat of Christ, "For as it is written, As I live, saith the Lord, every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall confess to God," Rom. 14:11. Amen and Amen!

Chapter 15

Why Run to Win?

The context for our thoughts on the Judgment Seat of Christ has been the letters of the Apostle Paul. The only two New Testament, direct references to the Judgment Seat of Christ, Rom. 14:10 and 2 Cor. 5:10, are written by Paul. This event is also called by the Greek word Bema (judgment seat) of Christ, and is connected with His Rapture return for the Church, "For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord," 1 Thess. 4:16,17.

"For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ *at his coming?"* 1 Thess. 2:19. Only Paul writes about that coming and to it he attributes the word *mystery,* "Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed," 1 Cor. 15:51.

The teaching of Christ's Rapture return for the Church is distinctly Pauline. And the teaching of the Judgment Seat of Christ is found only in Paul's writings.

It is of major importance that the Church prepare itself for the final accounting that it must give to the Lord at this Bema of Christ, "...for we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ ...So then every one of us shall give account of himself to God," Rom. 14:10,12.

There is no doubt in Paul's mind that every believer is running in this race of life which will be evaluated at the Bema of Christ. Each believer will be well served to follow Paul's example as he daily fought the good fight, stayed his course, and kept the faith. Thus, he wrote: "Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing," 2 Tim. 4:8.

In this concluding chapter, we have posed the question, Why Run to Win? The answer is inferred from the question itself, i.e. "Why Run?" (of course, one runs) "To Win!" Three reasons present themselves as direct answers to our question, from the following text.

"Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize? So run, that ye may obtain.

"And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible.

"I therefore so run, not as uncertainly; so fight I, not as one that beateth the air:

"But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway," 1 Cor. 9:24-27.

Why Run to Win?

I. BECAUSE ITS A COMMAND OF GRACE

The grammatical construction of the phrase "so run" (in I Cor. 9:24b) is noteworthy. The verb *run* is in the imperative mood, "of or relating to or constituting the grammatical mood that expresses the will to influence the behavior of another.. 2: not to be avoided or evaded: URGENT!"[89]

"The imperative is the mood of command, or entreaty - the mood of *volition.* It is the genius of the imperative to express the appeal of will to will. In ordinary linguistic communication the primary appeal is from intellect to intellect, but in the imperative one will addresses another. It expresses neither probability nor possibility, but only intention, and is, therefore, the furthest removed from reality."[90]

Does Paul desire "to influence the behavior" of these Corinthians by commanding them to "so run?" It is obvious that he does! In the final analysis, it is the grace of God which teaches "us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, *we should live* soberly, righteously, and godly, in this present world," Tit. 2:12. Paul uses the imperative "so *run"* to command, influence, and entreat believers to godly activity for Christ.

Paul's use of the imperative in his writings is significant as demonstrated from the following chart.

TABLE FOR IMPERATIVES IN THE NEW TESTAMENT[91]

BOOK	TOTALS
Mark	146
Matthew	285
Luke	283
Acts	124
John, & Epp. 1,2,3	146
Revelation	88
Hebrews	29
James & 1,2, Peter, & Jude	99

[89] Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary, Tenth Edition; Merriam-Webster, Incorporated, Springfield, Massachusetts, U.S.A., 1993, p.582

[90] H. E. Dana, Th.D., and Julius R. Mantey, Th.D., D.D., *A* Manual Grammar of the Greek New Testament, The Macmillan Company, Toronto, Canada, 1957, p. 174.

[91] Chart offered by a Mr. Scott on p. 1409 of A. T. Robertson, M.A.,D.D., LL.D., LITT.D., A Grammar of the Greek New Testament in the Light of Historical Research. Broadman Press, Nashville, Tennessee, 1934.

Paul	422
Grand Total	1,622

The imperative "so *run"* in 1 Cor. 9:24 has afforded us to observe the numerous other uses of that mood by Paul. Remember Paul's teachings are grace teachings, and therefore, grace: commands, entreats, and influences behavior.

Another grammatical observation in the phrase "...so run," is that the verb is present tense. Therefore, it is continuous action, the believer does not cease *running.*

Paul uses the race of 1 Cor. 9:24a, to illustrate the believer's contest in his service for Christ. Strong's Concordance sees this word *race,* the Greek "stadion:" "a stade or certain measure of distance; by implication a stadium or race-course-furlong, race." More detail is given, "stadium, i.e. the standard of `measure' viz. a distance of 600 Greek feet or 625 Roman (equivalent to 604 1/2 feet, or 201 1/2 yards English.) `The course for the Olympic games was a stadium in length; hence, a stadium came to be used of any course where public games were exhibited."[92]

In the *race* the prize was not received until the runner had completed his course. In Second Timothy Paul realized that his martyrdom was near, "For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand," 2 Tim. 4:6. He saw his life of service completed, "...I have finished my course," 2 Tim. 4:7. He successfully crossed the finish line, and expectantly waits the Judge's verdict, i.e. "the crown of righteousness," 2 Tim. 4:8.

II. BECAUSE GOD HAS NO CHEAP REWARDS

The issue at stake in the Greek games was a crown" "stephanos, from prim. stepho, to entwine, or a wreath; a chaplet, as a badge of royalty; a prize in the public games or a symbol of honor."[93] Paul describes this crown at the public games as *corruptible:* "phthartos, corruptible, perishable, from pheiro, to spoil, corrupt, destroy, generally to bring into a worse state."[94]

However, the crown for which the believer *runs,* is called *incorruptible:* "aphthartos, incorruptible, immortal."[95] This word "incorruptible" (immortal) describes the glorified, resurrection body promised to the believer at Christ's Rapture return, "...For this corruptible must put on incorruption...," I Cor. 15:53. What have we experienced that has been incorruptible? Yet, Paul says the crown (reward) that Christ has for the faithful runner of his race, is incorruptible. Therefore, it is associated with glory, heaven, and eternity, as is the resurrection body, "...It is sown in corruption; it is raised in incorruption:...It is sown in dishonour; it is raised in glory: ...It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body," 1 Cor. 15:42-44.

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[92] Ethelbert W. Bullinger, D.D., A Critical Lexicon And Concordance To The English and Greek New Testament, The Lamp Press Ltd., London, Eighth Edition, 1957, p.620.
[93] GodSpeed, by N. Blaine Morgan, Brian G. Moore, Copyright (C) 1987-1990 Brian G. Moore, Kingdom Age Software, Strong's #4735.
[94] Op.Cit., Bullinger, p. 188.
[95] Op.Cit., Bullinger, p.410.

Remember the crowns that Paul named:

- Phil. 4:1 "my brethren dearly beloved ...*my joy and crown"*
- 1 Thess. 2:19 *"crown of rejoicing"*
- 2 Tim. 4:8 *"a crown of righteousness"*

The runner must finish his course and he must compete according to the rules, "And if a man also strive for masteries [i.e. the athletic competition], yet is he not crowned, *except he strive law*fully," 2 Tim. 2:5. Yes, even under grace teaching, there are rules!

A major rule in this race is *temperance,* "And every man that striveth for the mastery (see 2 Tim. 2:5) is *temperate* in all things. Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible," 1 Cor. 9:25. Temperance is self-control: "engkrateuomai, to exercise power or mastery over, hence to exercise self-control."[96] The attribute of *temperance* is part of the fruit of the Spirit in Gal. 5:23. Every runner needs this virtue. Note how encompassing is temperance, "temperate *in all things!"* What a training rule! If the Greeks in their public games needed temperance to win a corruptible crown, the believer needs that fruit of the Spirit to obtain an incorruptible one. "Incidentally, the crowns are not merely tokens of recognition, though they are that also, but eternal realities worth living for -- worth dying for!"[97]

III. BECAUSE IT'S EXEMPLIFIED IN PAUL, OUR PATTERN

"I therefore so run..." 1 Cor. 9:26. *Therefore:* "truly now, accordingly; surely now, indeed now (drawing an inference and used where one proceeds with an inference.)"[98] Paul will live by his own teachings. He will practice what he has preached.

Hardly has the ink of verses 24 and 25 dried before Paul writes: "I therefore so run...!" He exhibits no delay, nor hesitation here. He puts his life into the race. He will be no mere spectator. Grace has commanded: "So run," see 1 Cor. 9:24. Paul's response, "I *therefore* so run." He had commanded others in 9:24: "So run," where the verb was present tense. Now, in his response, 9:26, "I therefore so run," he uses no less than the same present tense!

Obviously Paul's clear response is set in Scripture by the Holy Spirit's inspiration, to challenge the Church to emulation. We grace believers who revel in following Paul's doctrine, need to equally follow him in 1 Cor. 9:26!

Paul sees this race, to be *run,* i.e. "a hasty walk, an unhindered course." This thought is seen in 2 Thess. 3:1, "Finally, brethren, pray for us, that the word of the Lord *may have free course* [i.e. 'run, or move hastily'], and be glorified, even as it is with you." Paul did not compete "uncertainly." This word is also used in 1 Cor. 14:8, of an uncertain sound of the trumpet when summoning troops to battle. There are definite times when certainty is necessary, and Paul exhibited it as he so ran!

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[96] Op.Cit., Bullinger, p.763.
[97] William P. Heath, from personal correspondence.
[98] Op.Cit., Bullinger, p.783, #10.

The figure of fighting (to box, or fight as a boxer) is used by Paul to illustrate that he knew how to give a telling blow (lit. `to blacken the eye"). This was no mere "shadow boxing" with Paul, "so fight I, *not as one that beateth the air,"* 1 Cor. 9:26.

Paul held his body captive, actually he *reduced it to slavery,* "But I keep under my body, and *bring it into subjection..."* 1 Cor. 9:27. Is this a mark of legalism by Paul? Had he retreated back under Moses' performance system? Or does he not demonstrate the same grace which causes one to yield one's body according to Rom. 12:1, "I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service?"

The believer knows that his "body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own? For ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body, and in your spirit, which are God's," 1 Cor. 6:19,20.

Remember, it is at the Judgment Seat of Christ that the believer "may receive *the things done in his body, according to that he hath done,* whether it be good or bad," 2 Cor. 5:10.

Paul understood that by grace what was taught here (1 Cor. 9:24-25) must be lived *by grace.* If it were possible for Paul to become a *castaway* (disapproved, Greek: adokimos), is it not also possible for the rest of the Church?

Therefore, Why Run? Dare any believer not to run? Paul permits no option nor choice here - rather he commands: "So run." And even beyond that he says, "So run that ye may obtain!" Permit your faith to rise to the challenge of God's Word, and So Run That You May Win!

WHEN I SEE CHRIST

What a challenge for our best

Our every talent to invest!

Not on earth, our treasures hoard,

But as He said, in heaven stored.

Then He'll prove what here He taught

That no man e'er served God for nought.

So as for me whate'er the cost,

I want to count no day as lost.

I want not temporal things to dim

My heavenly vision and sight of Him,

But day by day to serve my Lord

And wait His time for my reward.

-J.C.O' Hair